

The Scandal of the Cross

Why the Death of God Is the Center of Everything

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The Scandal of the Cross

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Unless otherwise noted, Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

*We preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and
folly to Gentiles, but to those who are called, the power of
God and the wisdom of God.*

PAUL, FIRST CORINTHIANS 1

Contents

Introduction	1
The Center We Cannot Face	
Chapter One	5
The Cross We Made Into Jewelry	
Chapter Two	10
The Scandal the First Christians Could Not Soften	
Chapter Three	15
Why a Good God Would Die	
Chapter Four	20
Where Holiness and Love Meet	
Chapter Five	24
Substitution, and the Charge of Cosmic Child Abuse	
Chapter Six	29
Christus Victor and the Disarming of the Powers	
Chapter Seven	34
The Cross That Moves Us, and the Limit of That	
Chapter Eight	39
The Place Where Violence Ends	
Chapter Nine	43
The Theology of the Cross Against Every Theology of Glory	

Chapter Ten	48
The Cross and Guilt	
Chapter Eleven	52
The Cross and Shame	
Chapter Twelve	56
The Cross and Suffering, or the God Who Is Not Absent from Pain	
Chapter Thirteen	61
The Cross and Death	
Chapter Fourteen	65
The Blood the Modern Church Is Embarrassed By	
Chapter Fifteen	69
The Cross and the Powers of Our Own Moment	
Chapter Sixteen	74
Take Up Your Cross	
Chapter Seventeen	78
The Wisdom That Looks Like Folly	
Chapter Eighteen	83
The Cross at the Center of the Church	
Chapter Nineteen	88
The Hinge of History	
Chapter Twenty	93
The Sacrifice We Stopped Understanding	
Chapter Twenty-One	98
The Cross and the Wrath of God	
Chapter Twenty-Two	102
The Descent into Hell	
Chapter Twenty-Three	106
Cheap Grace and the Cost of the Cross	

Chapter Twenty-Four	111
The Two Thieves	
Chapter Twenty-Five	115
The Cross and the Prodigal	
Chapter Twenty-Six	120
The Cross and the Table	
Chapter Twenty-Seven	124
Why the Resurrection Needs the Cross	
Chapter Twenty-Eight	128
The Fatherless and the Father Who Died	
Chapter Twenty-Nine	133
The Cross and the Enemy	
Chapter Thirty	138
The Cross and the Poor	
Chapter Thirty-One	143
The Scandal to the Religious	
Chapter Thirty-Two	148
The Weight of Glory Hidden in the Weight of the Cross	
Chapter Thirty-Three	153
The Objections of the Honest Skeptic	
Chapter Thirty-Four	158
The Silence of Saturday	
Chapter Thirty-Five	163
The Cross Written on the Body	
Chapter Thirty-Six	168
The Cross and the End of Religion as Performance	
Chapter Thirty-Seven	173
The Cross and the Marriage	

Chapter Thirty-Eight		178
The Cross and Our Sons		
Chapter Thirty-Nine		182
The Cross and the Work That Crushes Us		
Chapter Forty		187
The Cross and the Fear of Death Undone		
Chapter Forty-One		192
The Cross and the Justice We Cannot Achieve		
Chapter Forty-Two		197
The Cross and the Church That Must Suffer		
Chapter Forty-Three		202
The Cross We Cannot Improve Upon		
Chapter Forty-Four		207
The Cross and the Return to Wonder		
Chapter Forty-Five		212
The Cross and the Hope That Does Not Disappoint		
Chapter Forty-Six		217
The Cross and the Forgiveness We Withhold From Ourselves		
Conclusion		222
The Center of Everything		

INTRODUCTION

The Center We Cannot Face

I WORE A CROSS around my neck for two years before I believed a word of what it meant. It was a gift. Silver, small, tasteful. It sat against my chest while I argued that God was a fiction invented by frightened people, and no one who saw it thought anything of it, because by then the cross had become the most familiar object in the Western world and therefore the least examined. That is the first thing I want you to sit with. We have taken the instrument of a tortured death and made it into something you can buy at a checkout counter. We hung it in sanctuaries and tattooed it on forearms and printed it on the covers of books that promise your best life. And somewhere in all that familiarity, we stopped seeing it.

The cross is not a logo. It was a means of execution designed by an empire to be as slow, as public, and as humiliating as human cruelty could arrange. Cicero, writing in the century before Christ, called it the most cruel and disgusting penalty, and said the very word cross should be far removed not only from the body of a Roman citizen but from

his thoughts, his eyes, his ears. That is the object. That is what we made into jewelry. And the central claim of the Christian faith, the claim that either founds everything or founds nothing, is that on one of those crosses, on a spring afternoon under Pontius Pilate, God died.

Not a good man died. Not a teacher, not a martyr, not a symbol of the human capacity for love. God. The maker of the galaxies, hanging from a beam, suffocating slowly the way the condemned did, mocked by soldiers and abandoned by nearly everyone who had followed him. This is the scandal. The Greek word Paul uses is skandalon, the thing you trip over, the offense that will not smooth out. He does not apologize for it. He plants it in the center of the message and dares the world to get past it.

I came to faith from atheism as a grown man, and I did not come because someone made Christianity comfortable. I came because someone made it dangerous again. Someone took the jewelry off the cross and showed me the wood. And what I discovered is that everything I most needed and most feared, everything true about guilt and shame and suffering and death and violence and the ache for justice, all of it converges on that one afternoon. The cross is not a detail of the story. It is the hinge of history. It is the center of everything. And the church that raised most of us has spent a generation smoothing it into something we can live alongside without being disturbed.

This book is an attempt to be disturbed again. I want to recover the crucified God, the phrase Jurgen Moltmann gave us in 1972 when he wrote that a God who cannot suffer is poorer than any human being. I want to ask the questions the checkout-counter cross never makes us ask. Why would a

good God die. What does the death actually do, and can we say what it does without shrinking it to a slogan. Why does Martin Luther insist, all the way back at Heidelberg in 1518, that a theologian of the cross calls the thing what it actually is, while the theologian of glory calls evil good and good evil. And why is it that the death of God, which sounds like the end of everything, turns out to be the deepest answer we have to suffering, to guilt, to shame, to violence, and to death itself.

I am not writing this from a safe distance. I am inside the indictment. I have preached the cross in ways that were too clean, too resolved, too eager to get to the resurrection before anyone had to sit in the dark of Friday. I have handled the blood of Christ like a man embarrassed to mention it in polite company. I have five sons, and I have taught them to sing about a cross I sometimes could not bear to look at directly, because to look at it directly is to be undone. This is not a book I wrote from above the material. It is a book I wrote from inside it.

Here is what I will not do. I will not pick one theory of the atonement and beat the others with it, as though the death of God were a puzzle with a single tidy solution. The tradition has spoken of the cross as a substitution, as a victory over the powers, as the supreme demonstration of love, as the place where violence exhausts itself against a God who will not return it. Each of these sees something real. Each becomes a distortion when it swallows the others. Fleming Rutledge, in her long and patient book on the crucifixion published in 2015, refused to reduce it, and I will follow her in that. The cross is large enough to hold every true thing said about it and to break every attempt to make it small.

So I ask you to take the jewelry off. Feel the weight of the

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

wood. The chapters ahead move from the scandal the first Christians could not soften, through the reasons a good God would die, into what the death accomplishes and what it exposes, and finally into what it means for the particular darkness each of us carries. If you are a skeptic, I am not going to pretend the offense away to keep you reading. I am going to show you that the offense is the point, and that a faith without it was never worth your objection. If you are a Christian who has grown numb to the story, I want to make it strange to you again. And if you are simply tired, carrying more than you can name on an ordinary Tuesday, I want to tell you that the center of everything is a place where God bled. That is not a small comfort. It is the only one that has ever held.

Let us go to the wood.

CHAPTER ONE

The Cross We Made Into Jewelry

WALK INTO ALMOST ANY church in America and count the crosses. They are on the walls, on the pulpit, on the offering plates, embroidered on the paraments, printed in the bulletin, hanging from the necks of half the congregation. We are surrounded by them. And I want to propose that this saturation is not a sign of devotion but a symptom of forgetting. You do not decorate with an electric chair. You do not wear a tiny golden gas chamber to signal your good taste. The reason we can hang the cross everywhere is that we have stopped hearing what it was.

I understand how this happened, and I am not writing to sneer at the woman who wears her grandmother's cross and prays with it between her fingers. There is real faith in that. But something happens to a symbol over two thousand years. It softens. The blood dries and the wood is sanded smooth and the screaming stops, and what remains is a shape, a pleasant geometry, two lines meeting at right angles, easy to reproduce, easy to sell. The offense drains out of it drop by

drop until you can print it on a coffee mug next to the words but first, coffee, and no one flinches. We did this slowly, and we did it to ourselves, and the doing of it cost us the thing itself.

Consider what a first-century person would have felt at the sight. The cross was not a religious symbol to them. It was a current event. Rome crucified rebels and slaves and the lowest criminals along the roads leading into its cities, deliberately, so that travelers would see the rotting bodies and understand what happened to those who defied the order of things. After the revolt of Spartacus in 71 before Christ, the general Crassus lined the Appian Way with six thousand crucified men, mile after mile of them, and left them there. When Paul stood in a Greek marketplace and said we preach Christ crucified, his hearers did not picture a piece of jewelry. They pictured that road. They pictured the smell.

This is the distance we have to recover, and it is a real distance, because the church has an interest in not recovering it. A softened cross asks nothing of us. It is a comfort, a brand, a reassurance that we are on the right side. But the cross as the first Christians knew it is an accusation before it is a comfort. It says that the world was so wrong, so deep in its wrongness, that when God himself entered it, the world killed him, and did so with the full machinery of religion and law and empire all working together and all convinced they were doing right. The men who crucified Jesus were not cartoon villains. The priests believed they were protecting the faith. Pilate believed he was keeping the peace. The soldiers were doing their jobs. That is the horror. The cross is what respectable people do to God when he shows up and refuses to fit their arrangements.

I said I stand inside this indictment, and I do. I have preached sermons that treated the cross as a transaction completed long ago, a debt cleared, a receipt filed, nothing to see, move along to your victorious Christian living. I have let the cross become a doctrine I affirmed rather than a death I stood beneath. It is easier that way. A doctrine can be shelved. A death demands that you look at it and ask what it says about you. And what it says about me is not flattering. The distance between me and the men who drove the nails is smaller than I would like. Given the right crowd, the right fear, the right conviction that I was protecting something important, I do not trust myself to have stood with Jesus rather than against him. Neither should you trust yourself. That distrust is the beginning of understanding the cross at all.

There is a particular version of the softened cross I want to name, because it is the one most likely to be doing damage in your life without your noticing. It is the cross as decoration for a religion of self-improvement. In this version, Jesus died mainly to affirm your worth, to remind you that you matter, to prove that you are loved just as you are. There is a true fragment buried in that. You are loved. But the cross does not tell you that you are fine. It tells you that your condition was so grave that nothing less than the death of God could address it, and that the same death is the measure of how far love was willing to go into the wreckage to reach you. Take away the gravity of the condition and the love becomes sentiment. A God who dies to affirm what is already fine is a God who overpaid catastrophically. The cross only makes sense against the black backdrop of a real emergency.

John Stott, in his great book on the cross published in 1986, wrote that the concept of substitution lies at the heart

of both sin and salvation, and that we sin by putting ourselves where only God deserves to be, and God saves by putting himself where only we deserve to be. Hold that sentence. It is the exchange the jewelry hides. We climbed onto the throne. God climbed onto the cross. Every softened, decorative, affirming version of the cross obscures that trade, because the trade is not flattering to us. It requires us to admit we were on a throne that was never ours. And a culture that has made the self the last sacred thing cannot easily hear that it was the self, precisely the self, that had to be dealt with at Golgotha.

We do not decorate with an electric chair. That we can wear the cross as ornament is not the measure of our reverence. It is the measure of our forgetting.

SO THIS IS WHERE the book begins, with a subtraction. Before I can show you what the cross gives, I have to take back what the culture gave you, which is a cross with the danger removed. I am asking you to un-remember the pleasant shape and remember the wood. To hear the word crucified the way a Roman heard it, with the road and the smell and the shame all present. Because only then does the Christian claim land with its full and terrible weight. The center of our faith is not a symbol of triumph borrowed from a comfortable religion. It is a corpse on a Roman gibbet who

three days later was not in the tomb. If that is true, nothing is the same. If it is not true, we should stop wearing it. What we cannot keep doing is the thing we have done, which is to wear it and not mean it, to hang it everywhere and see it nowhere. Take it off the neck. Put it back in the ground where it stood. Look at what actually happened there. That is where we are going.

CHAPTER TWO

The Scandal the First Christians Could Not Soften

THERE IS A PIECE of graffiti scratched into a wall on the Palatine Hill in Rome, dated to sometime around the year 200. It shows a man raising his hand toward a figure on a cross, and the figure on the cross has the head of a donkey. Beneath it, scrawled in rough Greek, are the words Alexamenos worships his god. It is a mockery. A pagan taunting a Christian, saying in effect, look at the ridiculous thing you bow to, a crucified donkey. It is, as far as we know, the earliest surviving depiction of the crucifixion of Christ, and it is a joke at the Christians' expense. That is where the image begins in the public record. Not in reverence. In ridicule.

I bring this up because it tells us something the sanitized cross conceals. The first Christians were not embarrassed into softening the crucifixion, and they had every reason to be. Their message was absurd on its face, and their neighbors

told them so daily. To the Jewish world, a crucified messiah was a contradiction in terms, because Deuteronomy declared that anyone hung on a tree was under God's curse, and a cursed man could not be the anointed deliverer of Israel. To the Greek and Roman world, the whole notion was beneath contempt, because gods were supposed to be powerful, serene, untouchable, and the idea that the divine had gotten itself tortured to death by a provincial governor was not a mystery to ponder but a punchline to enjoy. The cross was a scandal to one audience and folly to the other, exactly as Paul said. And the astonishing fact is that the church did not flinch.

Think about what a normal religious movement would have done. It would have quietly retired the awkward detail. It would have emphasized the teaching, the miracles, the resurrection, and let the manner of death fade into the background, an unfortunate episode best not dwelt upon. That is what public relations demands. Instead the apostles did the opposite. They marched straight at the offense. Paul told the Corinthians he had resolved to know nothing among them except Jesus Christ and him crucified. He did not lead with the empty tomb and mention the cross as a footnote. He led with the cross and dared them to trip over it. This is not the behavior of people managing a brand. It is the behavior of people who had seen something they could not unsee and would not lie about, whatever it cost them in credibility.

And it cost them everything in credibility. We forget this because Christianity won, because the cross eventually became respectable, because emperors came to bow before it. But for the first three centuries it was the mark of a despised and suspect sect. Cultured Romans wrote it off. The philosopher Celsus, in the second century, sneered that the Christians worshiped a man who had been arrested and

executed like a common criminal, and asked what kind of god allows himself to be treated so. It was a good question by the standards of the ancient world. Power was divinity. Serenity was divinity. A god you could nail to a board was no god at all. The Christians had no answer that would satisfy that logic, and they knew it, and they preached the crucified one anyway.

Here is what I want you to feel, because I think it presses on the skeptic more than any argument I could construct. The offensiveness of the cross is evidence of a strange kind. Movements invent flattering stories, not humiliating ones. If the early church had been fabricating a divine hero, they would not have fabricated this. No one designing a religion from scratch chooses a crucified founder, because crucifixion was the single most shameful death the ancient world could conceive, reserved for slaves and rebels precisely to strip the victim of every shred of dignity. That the church built its entire message on such a death is not what you would expect from people making things up. It is what you would expect from people stuck with a fact they could not get around and would not abandon.

I said this book is written from inside the indictment, so let me confess where I feel it here. I have wanted the respectable cross. I have wanted a Christianity that the thoughtful and the powerful would nod along with, a faith that made me look serious rather than superstitious. And every time I have reached for that respectability, I have found myself reaching to soften exactly the thing the first Christians refused to soften. The temptation Celsus put to the second century is the temptation put to me every Sunday. Preach a more dignified God. Give us power and serenity, not a bleeding provincial. And the moment I give in to that, I am no longer preaching the Christian gospel. I am preaching the

religion of glory that Luther will teach us to distrust, dressed in Christian clothes.

The historical stubbornness of the early Christians on this point is one of the reasons I could not stay an atheist. I had assumed, as most skeptics assume, that religions are wish-fulfillment, comfortable fictions people tell themselves against the dark. But this fiction was not comfortable. It was mortifying. Its adherents were mocked on the walls of Rome for worshiping a crucified donkey, and they kept worshiping. That does not fit the theory that faith is merely the coward's escape from a hard universe. Something held these people to a claim that made them ridiculous. Either a mass delusion of a peculiarly self-defeating kind, or something had actually happened that they could not deny.

*No one inventing a god invents a
crucified one. The shame of the cross is
the fingerprint of its truth.*

SO THE QUESTION THE first Christians pressed on their world is the question I press on you now, and on myself. What do you do with a scandal that will not resolve. You can trip over it, as most of Paul's hearers did. You can laugh at it, as Alexamenos's tormentor did. Or you can ask whether the offense is not a defect to be explained away but the very shape of the thing God was doing, whether the folly is a deeper wisdom and the weakness a deeper power, which is precisely what Paul claimed. The chapters ahead take that claim seriously. But we cannot take it seriously until we have

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

felt the offense in full, until we have stopped protecting God from the indignity of his own cross. The first Christians did not protect him from it. They preached it. And the wall on the Palatine Hill, with its mocking donkey, is a monument to how little they cared what Rome thought of the god they had found.

CHAPTER THREE

Why a Good God Would Die

THE HARDEST QUESTION IS not whether God exists. The hardest question, once you allow that he might, is why he would let himself be killed. A God who dies offends our deepest assumption about what God is for. We want God to be the guarantee against death, the one exception to the universal rule that everything ends. If even God dies, what is left. The instinct to keep God safely immortal and above the fray is ancient and nearly universal, and the Christian gospel walks directly into it and says the thing you were sure God could never do is exactly what God did. So we have to ask, with all seriousness, why. Why would a good God die.

Begin with what the question assumes. It assumes death is a problem, and that a good God would have some stake in solving it. Both are correct. Death is not merely the natural terminus of biological life, a neutral fact to be accepted with stoic calm. In the biblical vision death is an intruder, an enemy, the last enemy as Paul names it, the wage that sin pays out, the shadow that falls across everything good and

turns the whole of human love into a series of impending losses. Every parent knows this without being told. I have five sons, and from the day each of them was born I have loved them in the knowledge that love in this world is always love under sentence, that the very intensity of it is bound up with its fragility. Death is the enemy of everything I hold dear. If God is good, God cannot be indifferent to it. The only question is what a good God does about it.

And here the options narrow more than we expect. A God who merely abolished death by decree, waving it away from a safe distance, would be a God who never entered the country of the dying, never bore what we bear, never knew from the inside what he was undoing. Such a God might be powerful. He would not be with us. There is a kind of help that heals from above and never descends, and there is a kind that comes down into the wound and shares it, and only the second is the help of love. Moltmann pressed this in 1972, arguing that a God incapable of suffering is a God incapable of love, because love opens you to the suffering of the beloved, and a God sealed against all suffering would be sealed against us. The god of the philosophers, serene and untouched, is not the God who is good. He is only the God who is safe.

So a good God, confronted with the enemy death, does not abolish it from above. He goes down into it. This is the logic the cross reveals, and it runs against every intuition we have about divinity, which is why it took the actual event to teach it to us. We would never have deduced a crucified God. We had to be shown one. And what the showing reveals is that God's goodness is not the goodness of the untroubled sovereign who fixes the world with a word while remaining above its pain. It is the goodness of the one who enters, who takes the

enemy's full weight on himself, who dies in order to defeat death from the inside, the only place it could truly be defeated. Athanasius saw this in the fourth century when he wrote that the Word became flesh so that he might make us to be as he is, and that he took to himself a body capable of death, in order that death might exhaust itself upon him and be destroyed.

But there is more to why than the defeat of death, and here we touch the reason that offends modern people most. God does not die only against death. He dies against sin, against the real moral catastrophe of a world in rebellion, against the accumulated weight of every wrong that cries out for justice. A good God cannot simply overlook evil. We know this in our own hearts. A judge who shrugs at atrocity is not merciful but corrupt. A father who greets the abuse of his child with a genial never mind is not loving but monstrous. Real goodness takes evil with deadly seriousness, and the more good a being is, the more seriously its goodness takes the wrong. So the goodness of God cannot merely wink at the wreckage of human history. It must deal with it. And the astonishing claim of the cross is that God deals with it not by destroying the guilty but by absorbing the cost into himself.

This is where I have to be careful, because the next chapters will hold together several ways of speaking about what the cross does, and I do not want to collapse them prematurely. But at the level of why, the answer has a shape we can already see. A good God would die because goodness that will not enter the suffering is not yet love, and because justice that will not bear the cost is not yet mercy, and because the enemy death could only be defeated by a life that passed through it and came out the other side. The cross is the point where God's refusal to be indifferent to our

condition and God's refusal to destroy us in dealing with it meet in a single act. He will not overlook the evil. He will not annihilate the evildoer. So he takes the third road, the road no religion had imagined, and bears it himself.

I was an atheist, and I want to speak to the atheist reading now, because this is where the argument turned for me. I had always thought the problem of evil was the strongest case against God, and in one sense it is. But I had assumed the Christian answer would be some abstract theodicy, some clever accounting that balanced the suffering against a greater good and left God clean and distant. What I found instead was a God who did not answer the problem of evil with an argument but with a wound. He did not explain suffering from the throne. He came down and was tortured to death on a garbage heap outside a city wall. That is not an argument. It is something stranger and harder to dismiss. It is a God who refused to stay above the suffering he could have avoided, and instead went to the very bottom of it. You may still not believe it. But you cannot say it is the wish-fulfillment of people who wanted an easy God.

*A good God does not abolish death from
a safe distance. He goes down into it
and dies, because that is the only place
death could be killed.*

WHY WOULD A GOOD God die. Because he is good, and because we are not, and because between his goodness and our ruin there was no bridge that did not run through a grave.

That is the beginning of the answer. The rest of this book is an attempt to say what happened on that bridge, and why the church has spent two thousand years unable to exhaust its meaning. But the first thing to settle is that the death of God is not a scandal to be explained away. It is the shape love takes when it will not abandon the beloved to death and will not lie about the sin. Hold that, and we can go further in.

CHAPTER FOUR

Where Holiness and Love Meet

THERE IS A FALSE choice that has wrecked more theology than almost any other, and it runs like this. Either God is holy, in which case he must punish sin and cannot simply forgive, or God is loving, in which case he forgives freely and does not need to punish. Pick one. The stern God of judgment or the tender God of mercy. The Old Testament God or the New Testament God, as if they were two different beings. This false choice is everywhere, and it is lazy, and the cross exists in part to destroy it. For at the cross, holiness and love do not compete. They meet. And they meet in a way that neither could have arranged alone.

Start with holiness, because it is the attribute we have most thoroughly lost. To modern ears holiness sounds like prudishness, a fussy concern with rules, a God who is offended by small pleasures. That is not what the word means. Holiness is the burning purity of a being who is utterly good, in whom there is no shadow, no compromise, no tolerance for the corruption that ruins everything it touches.

Holiness is why we cannot bear too much reality. It is the fire that the prophet Isaiah encountered in the temple when he saw the Lord high and lifted up and cried out that he was undone, a man of unclean lips among a people of unclean lips. He did not feel affirmed. He felt exposed, the way you feel when a bright light falls on a surface you thought was clean and reveals every stain. Holiness is not God being touchy. It is God being real, and our discovering that we are not.

Now bring in love, the attribute we think we understand and mostly sentimentalize. Love in the biblical sense is not mere affection, not a warm regard that overlooks everything. It is a fierce commitment to the good of the beloved that will not rest while the beloved is in ruin. And here is where the false choice collapses. A love that did not care about the corruption in us would not be love but indulgence. The parent who loves a child fighting addiction does not love by pretending the addiction is fine. The very intensity of the love is what makes the corruption unbearable to it. So holiness and love are not opposites at all. Holiness is love's refusal to make peace with what is destroying the beloved. Love is holiness bending toward the beloved to rescue rather than to condemn. The two are one motion, seen from two sides.

But they create a problem that only the cross solves. God's holiness cannot ignore sin, because to ignore it would be to stop being holy, to shrug at the very corruption that is killing his creation. And God's love cannot destroy the sinner, because to destroy us would be to abandon the ones he made and will not give up. Holiness says the sin must be dealt with. Love says the sinner must be saved. On the surface these pull in opposite directions, and every human system of justice feels the strain, forever caught between letting the guilty off

and crushing them. We cannot have both mercy and justice in full. We split the difference and call it fairness. God does not split the difference. At the cross he satisfies both at their maximum, holiness in full and love in full, by taking the cost of the sin into himself.

John Stott wrote that the essence of sin is man substituting himself for God, and the essence of salvation is God substituting himself for man. Read those two clauses together and you see how holiness and love meet. Holiness demands that the substitution of ourselves for God, our theft of the throne, be answered. Love provides the answer by God substituting himself for us, taking the place that our rebellion earned. The holiness is not softened. The debt is not waived as if it did not matter. It is paid, in full, by the only one who could pay it without being destroyed, because he was the one who had been wronged. This is why the cross is not God overcoming his own justice with his mercy, as if mercy won a fight against justice. It is God's justice and God's mercy accomplishing a single thing together.

I have to say plainly where I once stood, because I stood in the false choice for years, even after I came to faith. I preferred the loving God and quietly retired the holy one. I found holiness embarrassing, a relic, a concept that made God sound small and anxious about sin. And what I did not see is that a God without holiness is a God without seriousness, a God for whom nothing finally matters, because if the corruption of the world does not grieve and enrage him, then he is not good, only nice. It was the cross that forced me to hold the two together. You cannot look at the death of God for sin and conclude that God does not take sin seriously. And you cannot look at God dying that death in our place and conclude that he does not love. The cross will not let you keep

the loving God and drop the holy one. It nails them together on the same wood.

*Holiness is love that will not make
peace with what is killing the beloved.*

*Love is holiness bending down to
rescue. At the cross they are not two
Gods but one motion.*

SO WHEN SOMEONE TELLS you they prefer the God of love to the God of judgment, you can answer gently that at the cross there is no such division, that the deepest judgment and the deepest love fell in the same place at the same moment on the same person, and that person was God himself. The wrath and the mercy did not cancel each other. They met, and in meeting they revealed a God more terrible and more tender than either the stern moralist or the sentimental affirmer had imagined. That is the God the cross shows. Not holiness without love, which is cruelty. Not love without holiness, which is indulgence. But the living God in whom both burn at full strength, and who found a way, at appalling cost to himself, to be entirely just and the one who justifies the ungodly. Hold that together, and you are ready to look at what the substitution actually means, and at the fiercest objection ever raised against it.

CHAPTER FIVE

Substitution, and the Charge of Cosmic Child Abuse

WE COME NOW TO the model of the atonement that has done the most work in the Western church and drawn the most fire, and I want to face both the work and the fire honestly. The idea is substitution, and specifically penal substitution, the claim that Christ bore in our place the judgment our sin deserved, that he stood where we should have stood and took what we should have taken. It is the model John Stott defended, the model most evangelical churches assume, and in the last generation it has come under an attack fierce enough that many pastors now avoid it entirely. The attack has a memorable name. Critics call it cosmic child abuse. I want to state that charge at its strongest before I answer it, because a caricatured objection is not worth answering.

Here is the objection in the form its most serious defenders would sign. If the cross is God the Father pouring

out his wrath on God the Son, then at the center of the Christian faith sits an image of a father punishing his innocent child for the crimes of others, venting his anger on a blameless victim so that his rage can be satisfied. Feminist and other theologians in the late twentieth century, writing with real moral seriousness, argued that this picture sacralizes violence, that it tells the abused to accept suffering as redemptive, that it makes the Father a divine child-abuser and holds him up for worship. If we teach that the way to deal with wrongdoing is to find an innocent to punish, we have baptized the very logic of scapegoating. That is the charge. It is not stupid. It has moved thoughtful people to abandon substitution altogether. And any honest defense has to feel its weight before it responds.

Now the response, and it begins by correcting a distortion so basic that once you see it the charge loses most of its force. The distortion is the idea of three parties, an angry Father, an innocent third-party Son, and us watching the transaction. That is not the Christian doctrine. It is a heresy the church condemned centuries ago, the notion that the Son is a separate being from the Father who might be victimized by him. The doctrine of the Trinity insists that the Father and the Son are one God, of one being, one will, one love. The Son is not a third party dragged in to absorb a punishment he wanted no part of. The Son is God, and at the cross God is not punishing someone else. God is taking the judgment into himself. It is not the Father abusing the Son. It is the triune God, Father and Son together in one will, bearing in his own person what our sin deserved. Stott put it exactly. God did not lay on Jesus a punishment he was reluctant to bear. God in Christ took his own punishment. The judge and the judged are the same God.

Once that is clear, the analogy to child abuse falls apart, because child abuse requires two parties, a powerful one inflicting and a powerless one suffering against his will. There is no such division at Golgotha. Jesus said no one takes my life from me, I lay it down of my own accord. The Son goes willingly, not as a victim but as a volunteer, and he goes not because he is a separate person forced into it but because he is God, and God has decided that he himself, in his second person, will bear what love and justice require. The cross is not violence done by God to a third party. It is violence absorbed by God into himself so that it need not fall on us. That is the opposite of scapegoating. Scapegoating loads the guilt of the community onto an innocent outsider and drives him away to preserve the guilty. The cross has God himself become the one who bears it, precisely so that the mechanism of scapegoating is exposed and ended rather than sanctified.

But I do not want to defend substitution so smoothly that I lose what is true in the objection, because there is something true in it, and it is this. Substitution has often been preached badly. It has been preached as if the Father were angry and the Son were kind, as if Jesus came to protect us from God rather than to reveal God, as if the atonement rescued us from a reluctant deity who had to be talked into loving us. That preaching is a genuine corruption, and it deserves the fire the critics have aimed at it. If your gospel makes the Father the villain and the Son the hero, you have torn the Trinity in half and you have earned the charge. The corrective is not to abandon substitution but to preach it as the New Testament actually presents it, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself, that the initiative was the Father's love from the beginning, that the Father gave the Son

and the Son gave himself in one act of a single divine will.

Let me stand inside this rather than above it. I have preached substitution badly. I have, in my eagerness to make people feel the seriousness of sin, let the Father sound like a thundercloud and Jesus like the lightning rod who took the strike so I would not have to. And more than one person has come to me over the years carrying a picture of God as an abuser, a picture they got, in part, from preaching like mine. I own that. The doctrine is precious and the mishandling is real, and the answer to mishandling is never to discard the truth but to preach it truly. Christ bearing our judgment in our place is not a barbarism at the heart of the faith. It is the most costly thing love has ever done, God taking into his own body the death our rebellion earned, so that the books could be honest and we could still go free.

It is not the Father punishing the Son.

*It is God taking the judgment into
himself, the judge and the judged one
being, so that the guilty could go free
without the truth being betrayed.*

SO I WILL NOT surrender substitution, and neither should you, but we hold it inside the Trinity or we do not hold it at all. The moment the Son becomes a third party, the whole thing curdles into the horror the critics describe. Kept where it belongs, it is the deepest possible answer to the question of how a holy God forgives without ceasing to be holy. He

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

forgives by bearing the cost himself. That is not child abuse. It is the parent throwing themselves in front of the car meant for the child, except that the parent is God and the car was the just consequence of our own wrong, and he stepped into its path knowing exactly what it would do to him. Substitution is one true thing the cross does. It is not the only thing, as the next chapters will show. But it is a true thing, and the church that has grown ashamed of it has grown ashamed of the very center of grace.

CHAPTER SIX

Christus Victor and the Disarming of the Powers

IF SUBSTITUTION ANSWERS HOW a holy God forgives, it does not by itself answer another question the New Testament plainly cares about, which is how we are freed from powers we cannot break on our own. The earliest church often spoke of the cross less as a payment and more as a battle, a decisive conflict in which Christ met the enemies that held humanity captive and defeated them. This is the model the Swedish theologian Gustaf Aulen recovered in 1931 and named Christus Victor, Christ the victor, and it was the dominant way the ancient church understood the cross for nearly a thousand years before the West grew preoccupied with the legal transaction. It deserves recovery, because without it the cross shrinks to a courtroom and loses the battlefield.

Here is the picture. Humanity is not merely guilty. Humanity is enslaved. We are held by powers larger than ourselves, sin as an occupying force, death as a tyrant, the devil as an accuser, and behind them the whole apparatus

that the New Testament calls the principalities and powers, the structures and spirits that organize a world in rebellion against God. Paul writes that Christ disarmed the rulers and authorities and put them to open shame, triumphing over them at the cross. Notice the military language. Disarmed. Triumphed. This is not a payment metaphor. It is a conquest metaphor, and it corresponds to something we all know, that our problem is not only that we have done wrong but that we are caught, held, unable to free ourselves, addicted to the very things destroying us, ruled by forces we did not choose and cannot escape.

The strange genius of the Christus Victor model is how the victory is won. It is won by losing. Christ defeats the powers not by matching their violence with greater violence but by letting them do their worst and exhausting their power against him. The powers threw everything they had at him, betrayal and injustice and torture and death, the full arsenal of a fallen world, and he absorbed it all and rose anyway. Death swallowed him and found it had swallowed something it could not hold, and in trying to destroy him it destroyed itself, the way a wave that hits a rock is the wave that breaks. The ancient writers had a vivid, almost mischievous way of putting this. They said death was like a fish that took the bait and was caught on the hook of Christ's divinity. Crude, maybe, but it names something real. The powers overreached. In killing the Author of life they signed their own defeat.

I love this model, and I think the modern church, obsessed with the individual and his private guilt, has neglected it to our great loss. Because most people do not walk around primarily feeling guilty. They walk around feeling trapped. Trapped in patterns they hate, in systems that grind them

down, in fears they cannot argue their way out of, in the certainty of a death that makes everything feel provisional. To such people the courtroom model can sound abstract, a solution to a problem they were not sure they had. But the battlefield model lands. You are held, it says, and you cannot free yourself, and at the cross the one who could went to war with everything that holds you and won. That is not abstract. That is liberation, and the human heart knows it needs liberating.

But I want to steelman the objection to this model too, because it has one. Taken alone, Christus Victor can float free of the moral seriousness that substitution guards. If the cross is only a cosmic battle against external enemies, then my own complicity drops out of the picture. I become merely a prisoner of war, a victim to be rescued, and never quite an offender to be forgiven. And that is not the whole truth about me. I am held by the powers, yes, but I am also, in some measure, in league with them. The occupying force did not invade a neutral country. It found collaborators, and I was one. So the victory model needs the substitution model to keep it honest about guilt, just as the substitution model needs the victory model to keep it from shrinking the cross to a private legal fiction. This is why I refuse to choose between them. The cross is both a payment and a battle, and any account that keeps one and discards the other has made the cross smaller than the New Testament made it.

Here is my confession within this chapter. For years I preached a cross that dealt with my guilt and left the powers untouched, and I could not understand why forgiven people, myself included, still walked around defeated. I had a gospel for the courtroom and nothing for the battlefield. I told people their debt was paid and then watched them go back into

bondage to the same fears and compulsions, and I had nothing to say except try harder. What I had lost was the ancient conviction that the cross does not only clear my record but breaks my chains, that Christ did not only take my judgment but conquered my jailers. When I recovered that, my preaching changed, and so did the people who heard it. A forgiven slave is still a slave. The gospel says you are forgiven and freed, the record cleared and the prison door blown off its hinges.

*The powers threw everything they had
at him and found they had spent
themselves against a rock. In killing
the Author of life, death signed its own
execution.*

SO THE CROSS IS a battlefield as much as it is a courtroom, and the victory there is the strangest victory in history, a triumph that looks exactly like a defeat. This is the pattern we will meet again and again, the power of God hidden under its opposite, the win disguised as a loss, which is precisely why the world at the foot of the cross saw only a failed messiah and not the conquest of everything that enslaves us. Luther will teach us to expect this, that God works under the appearance of the contrary, that his strength wears the mask of weakness. The cross as victory is the first great instance. The powers gathered to destroy him, and in the act of destroying him they were destroyed. That is the war the death

of God actually won, and it is a war that was fought for you, over the enemies you cannot beat, on a hill outside Jerusalem where the outcome looked, to everyone watching, like the enemy had won.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Cross That Moves Us, and the Limit of That

THERE IS A THIRD way of understanding the cross, older in one sense than either substitution or victory, because it appeals to something everyone can feel without any theology at all. It is this. The cross moves us. It shows us a love so total, so unguarded, so willing to suffer for those who did not deserve it, that the sight of it breaks something open in us and draws out a love in return. This is usually called the moral influence view, associated with the medieval theologian Peter Abelard in the twelfth century, though the impulse runs through the whole tradition, and it is not wrong. It is only incomplete, and the incompleteness matters enormously. Let me give the view its full strength before I name its limit.

The strength is real and I do not want to undersell it. When you truly see the cross, when you grasp that the one dying there could have called it off at any moment and did not, that

he prayed for the forgiveness of the men driving the nails, that he bore the worst that human cruelty could inflict and answered it with love, something happens in the human heart that no argument could produce. Cold hearts thaw at the foot of the cross. The proud are humbled. The despairing find they are loved after all. Abelard was pointing at a genuine effect, that the supreme demonstration of divine love kindles love in return, that we love him because he first loved us, and that the loving is not incidental to salvation but part of what salvation is. A faith that has all the right theories of the atonement and is never moved by the actual love displayed has missed the point as badly as a faith with no theory at all. The cross is meant to break your heart, and if it never has, you have not yet seen it.

I can testify to this personally, because it was, in part, the sheer moral weight of the cross that drew me out of atheism. I did not reason my way to the foot of the cross through a syllogism. I was undone by it. The idea that God, if he existed, would not stay safely above the suffering but would come down into the very worst of it and let it kill him rather than abandon us, that idea did something no argument had done. It moved me. So I will not stand here and dismiss the moral influence view as if it were sentimental. It names a real power, the power of love displayed to change the one who beholds it, and any full account of the cross must include it.

But now the limit, and it is fatal if the view is taken alone. The moral influence model, by itself, does not actually deal with sin. It changes my response to sin by moving my heart, but it does nothing about the objective fact of my guilt, about the real breach between a holy God and a rebellious creature. It treats the cross as essentially a demonstration, a display meant to affect the spectator, and if that is all the cross is,

then a terrible question follows. Why did he have to die. If the whole point was to show us love, could that not have been shown some other way, some way that did not require torture and death. A demonstration does not need to be that costly. You do not have to actually die to teach a lesson about love. The moment you say the cross is only a display of love, you have made the death unnecessary to its own purpose, and you cannot answer why God chose the most horrific possible method to teach something that a lesser sacrifice could have taught.

The deeper problem is that the moral influence view, taken alone, quietly relocates the problem from God to us. It says the barrier between us and God was never on God's side, only on ours, that God was always willing to forgive and merely needed to persuade us to accept it, to soften our hearts and win us back. But the Bible does not say the barrier was only on our side. It says there was a real breach, a real judgment, a real wrath against sin that had to be dealt with, not merely a misunderstanding to be cleared up by a sufficiently touching gesture. If the only thing wrong was our reluctance, then the cross is God's grand attempt to change our minds, and it is magnificent but it is not a rescue, because there was nothing to be rescued from except our own bad attitude. And that is not the human condition as I have experienced it or as anyone who has looked honestly into themselves has experienced it. Our problem is not only that we do not love God. It is that we have wronged him, and the wrong is real, and it will not be dissolved by being moved.

So here again I refuse the false choice. The moral influence view is true as far as it goes and dangerous when it goes no further. It must be held together with substitution and victory, or it becomes a gospel with no rescue in it, a

cross that touches the heart and leaves the guilt in place. The love displayed at the cross is real and it moves us, yes, but it moves us precisely because of what it is accomplishing. The demonstration is powerful because it is not merely a demonstration. He is not pretending to bear our judgment in order to impress us. He is actually bearing it, and the actuality is what gives the display its infinite weight. Remove the reality of what the cross accomplishes and you have removed the very thing that makes its love so moving in the first place.

*A love that only performs itself to move
the audience is theater. The cross moves
us because it is not performing. It is
paying, and the payment is what
breaks the heart.*

FLEMING RUTLEDGE WARNED, in her 2015 study, against exactly this thinning of the cross into a mere demonstration, and John Stott insisted that the love of God is proved not by a gesture but by an accomplishment, that God shows his love in that while we were still sinners Christ died for us, and the word is died, not merely displayed. So keep the moral influence, but keep it in company. The cross changes us because of what it does, and the doing is substitution and victory and more. Isolate the changing from the doing, and you get a religion of inspiration, a cross that motivates but does not save, a love that stirs the heart while the debt sits

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

unpaid and the powers sit undefeated. That is not the gospel. The gospel is a cross that both accomplishes our rescue and, in accomplishing it, breaks our hearts with the love that would go so far.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Place Where Violence Ends

WE HAVE LOOKED AT the cross as payment, as victory, as the love that moves us. There is one more angle I want to hold up, and it speaks with unusual force to a generation exhausted by violence and suspicious of any religion that seems to bless it. It is the cross as the place where the machinery of human violence runs up against a God who will not run it, absorbs it instead of returning it, and in absorbing it exposes and exhausts it. This is not a competing theory so much as a light thrown across all the others, and it answers a fear that keeps many thoughtful people at arm's length from the faith, the fear that Christianity is one more system that sacralizes bloodshed.

Consider how human societies have always dealt with the tensions that threaten to tear them apart. They find a victim. The French thinker Rene Girard spent his life documenting this, showing how communities on the edge of self-destruction restore their unity by turning together against a single scapegoat, an outsider or a marginal figure who is

blamed for the crisis and destroyed or expelled. The mob feels a rush of restored peace, and mistakes that peace for justice, and builds its myths and its rituals to sanctify the killing. Girard argued, controversially and I think largely rightly, that this mechanism is the hidden engine of human culture and human religion, the way violence keeps violence in check by discharging it onto a victim everyone agrees to hate. It is a peace built on a corpse, and it works, and it is a lie.

Now watch what the cross does to this machinery. Jesus is the scapegoat. Every element of the pattern is there, the crowd whipped up, the leaders agreeing that it is better for one man to die for the people, the accused delivered up, the mob unanimous, the victim killed to restore order and protect the nation. The high priest says it in so many words, that it is expedient that one man die for the people. This is scapegoating in its purest form. But then something unprecedented happens. The story is told from the point of view of the victim, and the victim is shown to be innocent, and the God the crowd claimed to serve turns out to be on the side of the one they killed. The mechanism that had always worked by hiding the innocence of its victims is exposed, once and for all, in broad daylight. The scapegoat is vindicated. The lie at the heart of human violence is dragged into the open, and it can never again operate quite so smoothly, because now we have seen it for what it is.

And here is the deepest part. God, in Christ, does not respond to this violence by returning it. This is the thing that should stop us cold. The one being in the universe with the absolute right to answer violence with violence, to call down the legions of angels, to wipe the mockers from the face of the earth, does not. He absorbs it. He lets the full weight of human cruelty fall on him and he does not strike back.

Father, forgive them, he says, of the very men killing him. The cycle of violence, which runs on retaliation, on the answering blow that provokes the next blow, is broken at the cross because the blow is absorbed and not returned. Violence hits God and does not bounce back. It ends there, in his body, because he refuses to pass it on.

I want to be careful here, because this angle can be pressed too far, and some have pressed it into a denial of substitution, as if the cross were only the unmasking of scapegoating and had nothing to do with bearing our judgment. That overreaches. Girard himself was ambiguous on the point, and I part company with those who use the exposure of violence to erase the atonement. The cross does both. It absorbs and exposes human violence, and it bears the just judgment of God against sin. These are not in competition. In fact they meet, because the judgment God bears is in part the judgment against exactly this, against the violence and injustice and blood-guilt of the human race, and he bears it by letting it fall on him rather than on us. The place where violence ends and the place where judgment is borne are the same place. That is the cross.

Let me put myself under this, because I am not a spectator to human violence, I am a participant in the impulse. I know the rush of the scapegoat mechanism from the inside. I have felt the ugly relief of a community uniting against someone, the pleasure of shared contempt, the way blaming an outsider makes the insiders feel clean and close. I have preached in ways that gave a crowd someone to be against and felt the energy it released and mistaken that energy for the Spirit. The cross indicts me here. It says the peace I have sometimes built was the peace of the mob, purchased by finding someone to hate, and that the God I serve is standing

not with the crowd but with the one the crowd cast out. To follow the crucified God is to be forbidden the oldest and most satisfying tool humanity has ever had for making peace, the tool of the scapegoat, because he became the scapegoat to end the practice forever.

*The one being with every right to
answer violence with violence
absorbed it instead, and let it die in his
body rather than pass it on. That is
where the cycle finally breaks.*

SO TO THE PERSON who fears that Christianity blesses violence, I say look harder at the cross. It is the most thorough exposure and refusal of sacred violence that any tradition has ever produced. Where every other system hides its victims and sanctifies its killing, this one puts the killing in the light and reveals the victim as God. And where every human peace is built on returning the blow, this God builds peace by absorbing it and forgiving. That is not a religion that sacralizes violence. It is the one place in the history of the world where violence was met with a love that would not answer in kind, and so was broken. The blood on the cross is not the blood of a sacrifice we offer to appease an angry god. It is the blood of God himself, poured out to end the whole bloody machinery of scapegoating and retaliation, and to open a peace that is not built on anyone's corpse but his own.

CHAPTER NINE

The Theology of the Cross Against Every Theology of Glory

IN APRIL OF 1518, a young Augustinian friar named Martin Luther traveled to Heidelberg to defend a set of theses before his order. He was not yet the reformer the world would come to know, but in that room he laid down a distinction that I regard as one of the most important things ever said about how human beings know God, and it cuts to the root of nearly everything wrong with the church in every age, including our own. He distinguished between the theologian of glory and the theologian of the cross. And he said, in effect, that these are the only two options, and that almost all of us are the first while imagining ourselves the second.

The theologian of glory, in Luther's account, expects to find God where human beings naturally expect to find God, in strength, in success, in wisdom, in visible power and evident blessing. The theology of glory reasons upward from the good things of the world to a God who is the biggest and best of

them, a God of power who rewards the strong, a God whose presence is proved by prosperity and whose absence is proved by suffering. It is the most natural religion in the world, and it is the religion of the human heart apart from grace, and it is exactly the religion the cross destroys. For the theologian of glory, a crucified God is a contradiction, because God is by definition the one who wins, who dominates, who cannot be defeated. Weakness and suffering are the opposite of God. So the theologian of glory looks at the cross and sees only failure, only the absence of the God he expected, only a scandal to get past on the way to the real, victorious deity.

The theologian of the cross does the opposite. He looks for God precisely where the theology of glory says God cannot be, in weakness, in suffering, in defeat, in the shameful death of a criminal on a Roman gibbet. And there he finds the true God, the living God, who has hidden himself under the appearance of the opposite of what we expected. Luther put it starkly. God can be found only in suffering and the cross. Not because suffering is good in itself, but because that is where God has chosen to reveal himself, hidden under the form of his contrary, so that he cannot be found by the proud reasoning of the theology of glory but only by faith, which sees the God that reason declares impossible. The cross does not merely offend our expectations of God. It reverses them. It teaches us that everything we thought we knew about where to find divinity was exactly backward.

I cannot overstate how much this exposes, and how much it exposes me. Because the theology of glory is not a heresy that lives in other people. It lives in me, and it lives in the American church with a vigor that would have appalled Luther. Every time we measure God's favor by our comfort,

we are theologians of glory. Every time we assume the successful pastor is the blessed one and the struggling one is failing, we are theologians of glory. Every time we promise people that faith will make them healthy and prosperous, that God wants them winning, that the cross was a means to their best life now, we are theologians of glory dressed in the language of the cross, which is the most dangerous form of the disease because it does not know it is sick. The prosperity gospel is the theology of glory in its most naked form, but it is not alone. A quieter version haunts the respectable churches too, the assumption that God is found in our strengths and our successes and our impressive religion, and not in the places of weakness and failure where Luther says he actually lives.

And it does not stop at prosperity. The theology of glory is at work whenever the church reaches for the tools of glory to advance itself, for political power, for cultural dominance, for the respect of the strong, imagining that God's kingdom will come by our winning. Luther's distinction cuts against that with a razor. The God of the cross does not come in the ways of glory. He came in weakness, and he calls his church to a cross-shaped life, not a throne-shaped one. Every time the church trades the way of the cross for the way of power, imagining it is serving God by grasping for control, it has become a theology of glory, and it has abandoned the very center of what it claims to preach. This is not a small correction. It is the difference between the true God and an idol shaped like our ambitions.

Here is my own indictment, and I do not offer it as a rhetorical flourish. I have been a theologian of glory in a preacher's robe. I have wanted the growing church, the impressed visitor, the sense that God was blessing my

ministry because it was succeeding. I have quietly suspected, in seasons of struggle, that God had withdrawn, because I had absorbed the assumption that his presence looks like winning. And every one of those instincts is the theology of glory, and every one of them is the exact opposite of what the cross reveals. Luther's test is merciless and I fail it constantly. It asks whether I am willing to find God in the place of weakness and defeat, in my own failures and in the suffering I cannot fix, or whether I will only look for him in the places of strength where the natural heart expects him. The cross says he is in the first place, hidden, waiting to be found by faith and never by the proud.

*The theology of glory looks for God in
strength and finds an idol. The
theology of the cross looks for him in
weakness and finds the living God,
hidden under the form of everything
we thought he could not be.*

SO LUTHER'S DISTINCTION FROM 1518 is not a piece of historical trivia. It is a permanent test that the church fails in every generation, our own perhaps most flagrantly. A theologian of the cross calls the thing what it is, Luther said. He does not call the suffering good or the weakness a defeat. He sees them for what they are and finds God there anyway. A theologian of glory calls evil good and good evil, dressing up the ways of power as the ways of God and dismissing the way

of the cross as failure. The whole of this book is, in a sense, an argument for the theology of the cross against every theology of glory that has captured the church, including the ones that have captured me. If we are going to recover the scandal of the cross, we have to let it do to us what it did to Luther, and reverse everything we assumed about where to find God, and learn to look for him last in the places we look first, and first in the place we would never have thought to look at all, on a hill of execution, dying.

CHAPTER TEN

The Cross and Guilt

GUILT IS OUT OF fashion, and its disappearance from our vocabulary has not made us freer. It has made us stranger. We do not talk about guilt anymore, at least not as a moral reality, a real debt incurred by real wrong. We talk about guilt feelings, which is a different thing entirely, a psychological state to be managed, reduced, therapized away. The modern move is to treat guilt as a symptom rather than a signal, a malfunction of self-esteem rather than an accurate report on the condition of a soul. And I want to argue that this move, for all its kindness, is a catastrophe, because it takes the one thing the cross most directly addresses and defines it out of existence, leaving people with a suffering they can no longer name and therefore can no longer have healed.

Let me draw the distinction sharply. Guilt feelings can be false. You can feel guilty for things that are not wrong, and much of the real work of counseling is helping people set down burdens they were never meant to carry, the shame handed to them by others, the false responsibility for things beyond their control. I do not dismiss any of that. But underneath the feelings, and often unaddressed by all our management of the feelings, lies the possibility that we are

actually guilty, that we have actually done wrong, that there is a real moral debt that no amount of reframing will dissolve because it is not a feeling but a fact. The man who has betrayed his wife does not primarily have a guilt feeling to be managed. He has a guilt, a real one, and telling him to feel better about himself is not mercy but a lie. His conscience is not malfunctioning. It is working correctly, reporting an actual breach, and the breach is real whether he feels it or not.

The modern therapeutic culture has no category for this and no remedy for it, and so it does the only thing it can, which is to deny the diagnosis. It tells the guilty they are fine, that they should forgive themselves, that the problem is their harsh inner critic and not their actual conduct. And for genuine false guilt this can help. But for real guilt it is a disaster, because you cannot forgive yourself for a wrong you did to someone else. That is not how forgiveness works. Only the wronged party can forgive. Self-forgiveness for a real debt is a category error, an attempt to write off a debt owed to another by declaring yourself satisfied, and the conscience, which is smarter than our theories, knows this and refuses to be talked out of its verdict. So people carry real guilt under a culture that insists guilt is not real, and they wonder why the self-forgiveness they were prescribed does not take.

Into exactly this the cross speaks with a precision nothing else offers. It does not deny the guilt. It does not tell you that you are fine, that your conscience is overreacting, that you should lower your standards and accept yourself. It takes your guilt with total seriousness, more seriously than you take it yourself, so seriously that it took the death of God to address it. And then it does the one thing that actually resolves real guilt, which is to provide a real forgiveness from the one actually wronged. Because underneath every wrong

we do to each other is a wrong done to God, whose image is stamped on the people we sin against and whose order we defy when we sin at all. And God, the ultimately wronged party, the only one with standing to forgive the deepest debt, has forgiven it, at the cost of his own life. That is not self-forgiveness, which cannot work. It is forgiveness from the offended, which is the only kind that can.

This is why the cross is such relief to the guilty and such an offense to the self-satisfied. To the person crushed under a real debt, the news that God himself has borne it and cleared it is the only thing that could ever set them free, because they know, at the deepest level, that their guilt is not a feeling to be managed but a fact to be forgiven, and here at last is forgiveness that does not lie about the fact. But to the person who has been told they are fine, who has managed their guilt feelings and made peace with their conduct, the cross is an insult, because it insists there was a debt after all, a debt so serious it killed God. The cross will not let you keep both your self-satisfaction and your salvation. It offers forgiveness only to those willing to admit there was something to forgive.

I speak here as a man who carried real guilt for years and tried every modern remedy before I found the only one that worked. I had done real wrong, to real people, in the years before I came to faith and after, and I had been told, in a hundred fashionable ways, that I should let it go, that I was being too hard on myself, that the past was the past. None of it touched the thing. The thing sat in me like a stone, because it was real, and the remedies were all pretending it was not. What finally moved the stone was not a technique for feeling better. It was the discovery that the God I had wronged had already, at Golgotha, done what was needed to forgive me, that the debt I could not pay and could not deny had been

paid by the one to whom it was owed. That is not the same as self-esteem. It is the opposite. It required me to admit the worst about myself, and precisely there, at the point of admission, to find that the worst had already been borne.

The cross does not tell the guilty that they are fine. It tells them that they were guilty, and that God has borne it, which is the only word that ever set a guilty person free.

SO DO NOT LET the culture talk you out of your guilt if your guilt is telling you the truth. There is a false guilt to be released and there is a real guilt to be forgiven, and the two require opposite treatments, and only the cross offers the second. The therapeutic world can help you set down burdens that were never yours. It cannot forgive you for the ones that are, because it has denied that such a thing as real moral debt exists, and you cannot cure a disease you have defined out of existence. The cross alone takes your guilt as seriously as your conscience does, refuses to lie to you about it, and then does the impossible thing, bears it away in the body of God, so that you can stand before the one you wronged, fully known and fully guilty, and hear the only words that could ever heal you, which are not you were never guilty but rather you are forgiven.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Cross and Shame

GUILT SAYS I HAVE done something wrong. Shame says I am something wrong. The two are cousins but they are not twins, and confusing them has left a great deal of good preaching aimed at the wrong target. Guilt is about deeds. Shame is about being. Guilt can be addressed by forgiveness, by the clearing of a debt. But shame is deeper and more diffuse, a settled sense that there is something defective in the self, something that would make you unlovable if it were fully seen, and shame is not cured by forgiveness alone, because you can be forgiven for what you did and still believe you are, at bottom, unacceptable. Our age, which has largely lost the word guilt, is drowning in shame, and the cross speaks to it in a way we have barely begun to preach.

Shame is the fear of exposure. It is the certainty that if people saw the real you, the hidden you, the you behind the presentation, they would recoil. It drives us to hide, to perform, to construct a self we can bear to show while burying the self we cannot. And it is corrosive precisely because it attacks not our actions but our identity, telling us not that we did badly but that we are bad, not that we made a mistake but that we are a mistake. Everyone knows this

feeling from the inside, though few name it. It is the voice that says you are a fraud, that your success is undeserved, that if they really knew you they would leave. It is, I think, the dominant spiritual affliction of our moment, more prevalent even than guilt, because a culture that has lost the language of moral wrong has not thereby lost the feeling of being fundamentally not enough. It has only lost the tools to address it.

The Bible knows shame from its opening pages. The first consequence of the first sin is not guilt but shame. Adam and Eve, having done wrong, do not first feel a debt. They feel naked, and they hide, and they cover themselves. Their instinct is exactly ours, to conceal the exposed self from the gaze that might reject it. Shame enters the world hand in hand with sin, and it produces the same reflex it produces in us, the frantic sewing of fig leaves, the construction of a covering to make the self presentable, the flight from the presence of the one who sees everything. Every human strategy for managing shame is a version of those fig leaves, a homemade covering for a nakedness we cannot bear to have seen.

Now consider the strange fact that the God who addresses our shame does so by taking on shame himself. Crucifixion was not only painful, it was designed to be shaming, to strip the victim naked, to expose him to public mockery, to make of him a spectacle of disgrace hung up where all could see and jeer. Jesus did not die a dignified death. He died the most shameful death the ancient world could devise, stripped and exposed and mocked, the object of exactly the contempt that shame most fears. And the letter to the Hebrews says something almost unbearable about this. It says he endured the cross, despising the shame. He did not avoid the shame.

He went into it, all the way into the deepest exposure and disgrace, the very thing every shamed human being spends their life fleeing. God, in Christ, took the fig leaves off and stood naked before the mocking crowd, and did not hide.

And here is why that heals shame in a way that forgiveness alone cannot. Shame is the fear that if I am fully seen I will be rejected. The cross is the place where God fully sees us, all the way down, everything we have hidden and covered and fled from, and does not reject us but dies for us. He goes into the shame, ours and his own, and out the other side, and he does it while knowing everything, while seeing the exact self we are certain would make us unlovable. The gospel is not that God loves the self you present. It is that God sees the self you hide, the one behind the fig leaves, and loves that one, and proves it by dying for that one. That is the only thing that ever finally answers shame, to be fully known and, in the same instant, fully loved, with no gap between the knowing and the loving where rejection could sneak in. The cross closes that gap. He knew the worst and went to the cross anyway.

I carry shame like everyone, and mine has a particular root. I was raised without a father, and the child raised without a father almost always concludes, somewhere below articulation, that the absence was a verdict, that if he had been worth staying for, someone would have stayed. That is a lie, but it is a lie that installs itself deep, and it produces a lifelong sense that one is fundamentally not enough, that the defect that drove the father away is still there, still visible to anyone who looks closely. I preached for years before I understood that the cross spoke to this, that the God who came into the world came, in part, for the fatherless and the shamed, and that he took the ultimate exposure onto himself

so that my exposure could be met with love instead of rejection. I raise five sons now in part against that old lie, and the deepest thing I can give them is not my presence, precious as that is, but the cross, where the God who sees them completely refused to look away.

Shame is the fear that if you were fully seen you would be rejected. The cross is where God saw you fully and, instead of turning away, died for what he saw.

SO IF GUILT IS the fear of the deed found out, shame is the fear of the self found out, and the cross speaks to both, but to shame it speaks with a particular tenderness that the church has been slow to preach. It does not tell you to think better of yourself. It does not hand you a better set of fig leaves. It does something far stranger and far more healing. It takes the covering off, exposes the self you dread exposing, and there, in the full nakedness of being known, meets you with a love that went to a cross rather than turn away. You do not have to keep sewing fig leaves. You do not have to keep constructing a self you can bear to show. The one whose gaze you feared most has already seen everything, at Golgotha, and answered not with the rejection you expected but with his own blood. That is the end of hiding. That is the healing of shame.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Cross and Suffering, or the God Who Is Not Absent from Pain

EVERY HONEST ACCOUNT OF faith must reckon with suffering, and most accounts fail, because they try to explain suffering and the explanations are all, in the end, obscene. Tell a mother who has buried her child that it was for a greater good, that God had a plan, that everything happens for a reason, and if she is honest she will want to strike you, and she will be right. The problem of suffering has broken more faith than any argument from philosophy, and it broke mine, back when I was an atheist, because I could not reconcile a good and powerful God with a world so full of undeserved agony. I still cannot, if reconciling means explaining. What I found instead was not an explanation but a presence, and the presence is the cross.

Let me first honor the force of the problem, because I will

not answer it with a slogan. The suffering of the world is not a philosophical puzzle to the people inside it. It is a wound. Children die in agony. The innocent are tortured. Disease and disaster fall without regard to merit, crushing the good and sparing the wicked with an indifference that mocks every notion of cosmic justice. Any faith that does not feel the full weight of this has not earned the right to speak about it. The classic problem is old and unanswered. If God is good he would want to end suffering. If God is powerful he could end suffering. Suffering continues. Therefore God is not both good and powerful, or is not there at all. I felt the force of that argument for years, and I feel it still, and I distrust anyone who does not.

Now here is what the cross does not do. It does not solve the problem of suffering as a theoretical matter. I want to say that plainly, because Christians often overclaim here, promising an explanation the cross does not deliver. The cross does not tell you why your child died. It does not hand you the reason behind the cancer or the accident or the slow cruelty of a body failing. If you come to the cross for an explanation of suffering, you will leave empty, and you should, because the cross is not an argument. It is something else, and the something else is, I have come to believe, deeper and more usable than any argument could be.

What the cross tells you is that God is not absent from your suffering, because he has been inside it. This changes the question entirely. The philosophical problem assumes a God who sits outside suffering, aloof and untouched, watching from a safe distance and declining to act, and against such a God the problem of evil is devastating, because his distance is precisely the offense. But the God of the cross is not outside the suffering. He came into it. He was tortured, abandoned,

and killed. He cried out from the cross in the words of the psalm, my God, my God, why have you forsaken me, and in that cry God himself entered the deepest darkness a human being can know, the darkness of feeling abandoned by God. Whatever else the cross means, it means this, that when you suffer, you do not suffer alone in a universe governed by an indifferent deity. You suffer in a universe whose God has suffered, who knows the inside of pain, who has cried the cry of the forsaken and does not require you to pretend you have not cried it too.

Moltmann, who as a young man was a prisoner of war and knew suffering from the inside, wrote in 1972 that only the suffering God can help, that a God who could not suffer would be a demon rather than a comfort, and that the cross reveals a God who took the whole of human anguish into his own being. I think he is right, and I think it is the only thing that has ever actually helped anyone in real extremity. The explanations do not help. I have watched them fail at a hundred bedsides. What helps, when anything helps, is the discovery that God is there, in the dark, not as the author of a plan you are supposed to admire but as a fellow sufferer who has been where you are and gone lower, all the way to the cry of dereliction, all the way to death. That does not answer why. It answers who. It tells you who is with you in the pain, and the who turns out to matter more than the why.

I have stood at too many gravesides to offer anyone a theory, and I have stood at enough of them to know what actually holds. What holds is not the sentence God has a plan, which I have come to distrust in the mouth of anyone who has not earned it with their own grief. What holds is the cross, the fact that God did not stay above the suffering but came down into the worst of it, that he is not the distant designer of your

pain but the crucified one who bears it with you and has borne worse. I do not tell the grieving that their suffering has a reason. I do not know that it does, and if it does I do not know the reason, and neither does anyone else who is honest. I tell them that the God who meets them in it is a God with wounds, a God who was forsaken, a God who will not stand at a safe distance from their pain because he already came all the way into it and died there.

The cross does not explain your suffering. It does something the explanations never could. It puts God inside it with you, at the very bottom, crying the cry of the forsaken.

SO THE CROSS DOES not win the philosophical argument about suffering, and I have stopped pretending it does. It does something better. It changes the God we are arguing about. It replaces the aloof deity of the philosophy classroom, whose distance makes the problem unanswerable, with the crucified God, whose presence in the pain makes the problem, if not soluble, at least bearable, because now you are not alone in it. The suffering remains a mystery. But it is no longer the mystery of an absent God's indifference. It is the mystery of a present God's tears. And that, in the hour when suffering actually comes, when the theories all fail and the platitudes turn to ash in your mouth, is the only thing I have ever known to hold. God is not absent from your pain. He is in it, with

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

wounds in his hands, having gone to the bottom of it before you and for you.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Cross and Death

DEATH IS THE ONE certainty we spend our whole lives arranging not to think about. Our culture has become extraordinarily skilled at this concealment. We have moved death out of the home and into the hospital and the funeral parlor, out of sight, handled by professionals, sanitized and scheduled. We use soft words, passed away, lost, gone, no longer with us, anything but the hard word died. We are a people terrified of a thing we refuse to name, and the refusal does not lessen the terror, it only leaves us unprepared for the one appointment none of us will miss. The cross meets death head-on, refuses every euphemism, and does the one thing no philosophy and no denial has ever managed. It defeats death by dying.

Begin with the seriousness of the enemy, because our age wants to make death smaller than it is. There are two comfortable lies about death on offer, and the cross rejects both. The first lie is that death is natural, just part of the cycle, nothing to fear, the way of all living things, and we should accept it with serene acceptance. This is the counsel of the ancient Stoics dressed in modern clothes, and it has a dignity to it, but it is a lie, because we do not experience death as

natural. We experience it as an outrage, an intrusion, the tearing away of what we love, and the Bible agrees with our experience against the Stoic. Death is called the last enemy, not the last stage. It is not a friend to be welcomed but a foe to be defeated. The grief we feel at a grave is not a failure to achieve serenity. It is an accurate response to a real evil.

The second comfortable lie is the opposite, that death is simply the end, extinction, the light going out, and that we should make our peace with our own annihilation and find meaning in the brief flicker we are given. I lived by this lie for years, and I want to grant it its dignity too, because there is a certain bleak courage in facing the void without flinching. But it is a lie, or at least it is a claim no one can actually live by, because everything human in us rebels against it, every love that presents itself as permanent, every intuition that persons matter in a way that mere matter does not, every refusal at the graveside to believe that the beloved is simply gone. The materialist account of death is philosophically tidy and humanly impossible. No one who has truly loved another person can stand at their grave and believe, in their bones, that the person is now nothing.

The cross takes death with the full seriousness that both lies evade. It does not tell you death is natural and fine. It does not tell you death is final and you should cope. It tells you death is a real enemy, so real that God himself had to die to defeat it, and that the defeat has actually happened. For here is the astonishing logic of the cross and the empty tomb that follows it. God did not defeat death by avoiding it, by exempting himself from it, by staying safely immortal above the mortal fray. He defeated it by entering it, by dying a real death, a genuine death with a genuine corpse in a genuine tomb, and then by rising, so that death, which had never

failed to hold its captives, was forced for the first time to give one up. Death swallowed him and could not keep him, and in that failure its whole tyranny was broken. The strong man was bound in his own house.

This is why the cross cannot be separated from the resurrection, and I have spent this whole book on the cross precisely because the resurrection is meaningless without it. A resurrection without a real death is a magic trick, a divine sleight of hand that never actually risked anything. But a resurrection that follows a real death, the death of God himself, is the defeat of the last enemy from the inside, the one place death could truly be conquered. Paul mocks death directly, quoting the prophets, O death where is your victory, O death where is your sting. He can mock it because it has been beaten, not talked out of existence but actually beaten, by a God who went down into it and came back up, dragging its keys behind him. Death is still an enemy, but it is a defeated enemy, a conquered tyrant whose sentence has been commuted, and the Christian faces it not with the false serenity of the Stoic nor the false courage of the materialist but with the strange defiance of one who knows the enemy has already lost.

I did not fear death much as a young atheist, or I told myself I did not, which is a different thing. The fear was there. It surfaced at odd moments, in the small hours, in the presence of the dying, a cold recognition that everything I was building would end and that the ending was total. What changed was not that I stopped taking death seriously. It is that I met a God who took it more seriously than I did, seriously enough to die of it, and who came out the other side. Now I have five sons, and I love them under the shadow of death as every parent does, knowing that love in this world is

love under sentence. But the sentence has been appealed. The cross does not mean my sons will not die. It means that death, for those in Christ, is no longer the end of them but a defeated enemy they will pass through into a life that death can no longer touch. That is not denial. It is the only real answer to the thing we spend our lives denying.

*Death swallowed him and could not
keep him. In that one failure the tyrant
that had never lost was broken forever.*

SO THE CROSS IS where the last enemy met the only one it could not hold. It did not defeat death by pretending death was small or natural or unreal. It defeated death by dying, really dying, and then refusing to stay dead. And the offer this makes to every person under the shadow is not the counsel of the Stoic, resign yourself, nor the counsel of the materialist, distract yourself, but something no philosophy could offer, follow me through it. The crucified and risen God has been through death and out the far side, and he holds out his scarred hand and says that the grave that took him and could not keep him will not keep you either. That is the answer to death, and it is not an argument. It is a person, with wounds in his hands, standing on the far side of the tomb, saying that because he lives, you will live also.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Blood the Modern Church Is Embarrassed By

THERE IS A WORD that runs all through the New Testament and all through the old hymns and has quietly disappeared from a great deal of contemporary Christianity, and the word is blood. We used to sing about it without embarrassment. There is a fountain filled with blood. What can wash away my sin, nothing but the blood of Jesus. Are you washed in the blood. The old hymnody was drenched in it, and somewhere in the last two generations we began to find it distasteful, primitive, off-putting to the newcomer, and we quietly edited it out. The blood language makes us squeamish. And I want to argue that our squeamishness is not a sign of our sophistication but a symptom of how far we have drifted from the center of the faith.

I understand the discomfort, and I do not dismiss it. The imagery is visceral, ancient, bound up with the sacrificial systems of a world that seems impossibly remote from ours,

with altars and priests and the ritual slaughter of animals. To modern ears it can sound barbaric, even bloodthirsty, as though God required a certain quantity of gore before he could be appeased. And there are bad versions of the blood theology that deserve to be retired, versions that make God sound like a deity who simply craves blood, who cannot forgive until his thirst for it is satisfied. If that were what the blood meant, our embarrassment would be righteous. But it is not what the blood means, and in editing out the word we have not escaped a bad theology. We have lost a true one.

Here is what the blood means in the biblical world, and it is the opposite of bloodthirst. Blood, in the Scriptures, is life. The life is in the blood, Leviticus says. So when the New Testament speaks of the blood of Christ, it is not speaking primarily of gore but of life poured out, a life given up, the most precious thing there is surrendered on behalf of another. The blood of Christ is his life laid down, and to speak of being saved by his blood is to speak of being saved by his life given in death for us. Far from being barbaric, the language is the most costly language of love the Scriptures possess, because it names not a symbolic gesture but the actual giving up of a life, the pouring out of the one thing that cannot be given twice. When the hymns sang of the blood, they were singing of a love that held nothing back, that gave the last and deepest thing, life itself.

And there is a further reason we cannot lose the blood, which is that it guards against the thinning of the cross into a mere idea. It is very easy, especially for the educated and the comfortable, to spiritualize the cross into an abstraction, a principle of self-giving love, a symbol of God's solidarity with the suffering, a beautiful concept. The blood will not let us do this. The blood insists on the physical reality, the actual body,

the actual death, the actual mess of an execution. It keeps the cross from floating off into the realm of ideas and holds it down to the wood and the nails and the fluid that ran out of a real body on a real afternoon. The offense of the cross is bound up with its physicality, and the blood is the physicality refusing to be abstracted away. A church embarrassed by the blood is usually a church on its way to a cross of pure idea, a cross you can admire without being disturbed by, and that is a cross that has lost its power.

The New Testament is not squeamish. The letter to the Hebrews says that without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins, and it is not being primitive, it is being honest about the cost of forgiveness. Forgiveness is never free for the one who grants it. It always costs the forgiver, always requires them to absorb the wrong rather than pass it on, and the deeper the wrong the deeper the cost. When you forgive someone who has genuinely hurt you, you pay for it, you bear the loss yourself instead of making them pay, and that bearing is a kind of death you die on their behalf. The blood of Christ is the ultimate instance of this. God's forgiveness of the human race was not a costless waving away of the debt. It cost him his blood, his life, everything. The blood language names the price of grace and refuses to let us imagine grace was cheap.

I have been embarrassed by the blood. I confess it. In my eagerness to make the faith presentable to skeptical and sophisticated people, the very people I was myself not long ago, I have softened the blood language, reached for gentler words, worried that the fountain filled with blood would drive away the newcomer at the door. And in doing so I was, without quite admitting it, embarrassed by the cost of my own salvation, wanting a grace that did not require so much

gore, a forgiveness that did not need a death. But there is no such forgiveness. The blood is the measure of what my rescue cost, and to be embarrassed by it is to wish, at some level, that I had been worth less trouble to save. The blood tells me I was worth the last drop of the life of God. That is not a truth to edit out. It is a truth to fall down before.

*The blood is not God's thirst for gore. It
is the price tag on grace, the measure of
a love that gave the last and deepest
thing and held nothing back.*

SO I WANT TO call the church back to the blood, not to a crude theology of a bloodthirsty deity, which was always a distortion, but to the true and costly language the New Testament uses without a flinch. The blood of Christ means his life poured out for us, the physical, non-negotiable, unspiritualizable reality of a God who died, and the naming of exactly what our forgiveness cost. When we lose the blood we lose the cost, and when we lose the cost we get a cheap grace, and cheap grace, as Bonhoeffer taught us, is grace without discipleship, grace without the cross, grace we bestow on ourselves. The old hymns had it right, however much they make us wince. There really is a fountain, and it really is filled with blood, and the blood really is the life of God poured out, and there really is nothing else in heaven or earth that can wash away what we have done. We should be less embarrassed and more amazed.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Cross and the Powers of Our Own Moment

PAUL WROTE THAT OUR struggle is not against flesh and blood but against the principalities and powers, and for a long time the modern church did not know what to do with that language, so it either literalized it into a private demonology or ignored it entirely. But the powers are not merely private demons, and they are not nothing. They are the structures, ideologies, and systems that organize a fallen world and take on a life larger than the individuals who compose them, that promise us identity and belonging and meaning and then enslave us, that demand our worship and deliver our bondage. Every age has its powers. Ours has its own, and the cross speaks to them, disarms them, and exposes them, if we have the courage to name them rather than serve them.

Let me name a few of the powers of our own moment, and let me name them in a way that indicts my own tribe as

readily as the other, because a critique of the powers that only ever fires in one political direction has stopped being a critique of the powers and become a servant of one of them. The power of the market, which reduces every person and every relationship to a transaction, which teaches us to value ourselves and others by productivity and consumption, which has colonized even our leisure and our worship with the logic of the deal. The power of the nation, which demands an ultimate loyalty that belongs to God alone, which baptizes its violence as righteousness and its enemies as evil, and which has seduced the church of every land into confusing the kingdom of God with the interests of a flag. The power of the self, elevated in our therapeutic age into the last sacred thing, the final authority, the god we are commanded to worship under the name of authenticity. These are powers. They are larger than us, they claim our allegiance, and they enslave.

Now watch what the cross does to them. First, it disarms them, as we saw in the chapter on Christus Victor. The powers do their worst at the cross, the political power of Rome and the religious power of the temple and the mob power of the crowd all converging to destroy Jesus, and in destroying him they are exposed and defeated. The cross reveals the powers for what they are, not the benevolent orders they claim to be but the death-dealing tyrants they actually are, willing to kill God himself to preserve their arrangements. Once you have seen the powers crucify the Lord of glory, you can never again quite believe their advertising. The market's promise of fulfillment, the nation's promise of salvation, the self's promise of freedom, all of them stand exposed at the foot of the cross as the false gods they are, unmasked by what they did to the true one.

Second, the cross frees us from the powers by giving us an identity and a security they can no longer threaten. The powers rule us largely through fear, the fear of not having enough, the fear of the enemy, the fear of being nobody, and the cross addresses the fear at its root. If God has loved me to the point of death, if my worth is established by his blood and not by my productivity or my nation or my performance of an acceptable self, then the powers have lost their grip, because they can no longer offer me the identity I now have as a gift, nor threaten me with a loss that the cross has not already covered. The freest people in the world are those who have died with Christ, because you cannot threaten a dead person with the loss of what the powers control. Bonhoeffer, who faced the most naked power of the twentieth century and was killed by it in 1945, understood this. The man who has died with Christ is free from the powers precisely because he has already lost the thing they use to control him, his own life, and received it back as a gift no power can revoke.

But here is where I must indict my own house, because the great temptation of the church in relation to the powers is not to be enslaved by them openly but to serve one of them while imagining we are serving God. The American church has, in my lifetime, largely failed the test of the powers, not by worshiping the market or the nation in name, which we would never do, but by baptizing one of them in practice, by confusing the kingdom of God with a political program, by trading the scandal of the cross for the respectability of power, by seeking to advance the gospel through the very means the cross exposed. We have wanted the powers on our side rather than under our feet. We have wanted the nation to enforce our faith, the market to fund our ambitions, the self affirmed rather than crucified. And every time we reach for

the powers to do the work of the cross, we have become a theology of glory again, serving the very things Christ disarmed.

I am in this indictment. I have wanted the powers on my side. I have wanted political victories to do what only the cross can do, wanted cultural influence to substitute for faithfulness, wanted the church to win in the way the world wins rather than in the way the cross wins, which looks like losing. The cross rebukes this in me as it rebukes it in the whole church of my nation and my time. It says that the kingdom of God does not come by seizing the powers but by the way of the cross, by a love that lays down its life rather than taking others', by a faithfulness that would rather be crucified than compromise, by a refusal to become the thing we oppose. The powers cannot be defeated by our becoming a rival power. They were defeated by a crucifixion, and they are defeated in us only as we take up the same cross.

*The powers rule through fear, and you
cannot frighten a dead person. The one
who has died with Christ is free,
because the powers have already taken
his life and Christ has given it back.*

SO THE CROSS IS not only ancient history. It is the disarming of the powers of every moment, including the ones that rule us now, the market and the nation and the sovereign self, and the ones I have not named that rule you in

particular. It exposes their advertising as a lie and frees us from their fear by an identity they cannot touch. But it will only do this if we let it stand as the scandal it is, if we refuse to enlist it in the service of the very powers it exposed. A crucified church, free from the fear of loss because it has already died, is the one thing the powers cannot control and have never been able to. That church has been rare in every age, including our own, and the reason it is rare is that the way of the cross always looks, to the eyes of glory, exactly like defeat. It looked like defeat on Friday too.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Take Up Your Cross

THERE IS A SENTENCE of Jesus that we have domesticated more thoroughly than almost any other, and it is this. If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me. We use it lightly. We speak of our various irritations and burdens as our cross to bear, the difficult coworker, the chronic ache, the relative who tries our patience, and in doing so we have emptied the sentence of everything Jesus put into it. Because when Jesus said take up your cross, his hearers did not think of minor irritations. They thought of the road lined with the crucified. They knew exactly what taking up a cross meant. It meant walking to your own execution. It meant death.

We have to recover the ferocity of this before we can hear it at all. In the ancient world, a man carrying a cross was a man on his way to die, forced to bear the instrument of his own killing to the place of his killing, a dead man walking through jeering crowds. That is the image Jesus reached for to describe what following him would cost. Not inconvenience. Death. The death of the self, the surrender of the life we are clinging to, a following that goes all the way to the loss of everything we were holding onto for our security

and our identity and our comfort. Bonhoeffer put it with a bluntness that still cuts. When Christ calls a man, he bids him come and die. That is not rhetorical exaggeration. It is a precise reading of what Jesus said, and Bonhoeffer backed it with his own life, which the Nazi state took at the gallows in April of 1945, days before the camp was liberated. He had understood the call to take up the cross and he had followed it all the way to a real execution.

Now I want to be careful, because this teaching can be twisted into something cruel, and it has been. It has been used to tell the abused to endure their abuse, to tell the oppressed to accept their oppression, to tell the suffering that their suffering is their cross and they should bear it silently. That is a monstrous misuse, and I reject it completely. Taking up your cross does not mean submitting to whatever harm the world wishes to do to you. It does not mean the battered spouse should stay, or the exploited worker should be grateful, or the victim should be silent. The cross Jesus calls us to take up is a chosen cross, freely embraced in the way of discipleship, not a violence inflicted on us by others and endured in the name of piety. Jesus chose his cross. He was not a passive victim of forces he could not resist. He laid down his life of his own accord, and the cross we are called to take up is likewise a laying down, a free surrender of the self, not a submission to abuse.

So what does it actually mean, this taking up of the cross. It means, first, the death of the self as the center of our existence, the ongoing crucifixion of the ego that wants to be god of its own little kingdom. The self that must be first, must be right, must be served, must be admired, must be safe, that self is nailed to the cross in the life of a disciple, put to death daily, so that a new self can live, a self centered not on itself

but on God and neighbor. This is not self-hatred. It is the opposite. It is the death of the false self, the grasping and fearful self, so that the true self, the self God made and loves, can finally live free of the exhausting project of self-worship. The paradox Jesus states is exactly this. Whoever would save his life will lose it, and whoever loses his life for my sake will find it. The self we cling to we lose. The self we surrender we receive back, alive.

And it means, second, a readiness to suffer for the way of Christ in a world that crucified him. If we follow a crucified Lord in a world that put him to death, we cannot expect the world to receive us more gently than it received him. To take up the cross is to accept that faithfulness may cost us, that the way of self-giving love in a world of self-seeking power will often look like losing, will sometimes be met with hostility, will occasionally, as it was for Bonhoeffer, cost everything. This is not a call to seek out suffering, which would be its own kind of ego, a martyr complex dressed as devotion. It is a call to be willing to bear the cost when faithfulness requires it, rather than trimming our discipleship to avoid the cost. The cross-shaped life does not chase suffering, but it does not flee it either when love demands it.

I feel the distance between this teaching and my own life every day, and I will not pretend otherwise. I have built a comfortable Christianity, a following of Jesus carefully arranged to cost me as little as possible, and the call to take up the cross exposes it. I have wanted the crown without the cross, the resurrection without the death, the finding of my life without the losing of it. I have preached self-denial from a life of considerable self-indulgence, and the gap between the sermon and the life is a rebuke I carry. When I raise my five sons, the thing I most want to give them is a comfortable life,

safety, success, ease, and the cross tells me that the deepest thing I could give them is not comfort but the willingness to lose their lives in order to find them, a courage I have not fully found myself. I teach them a call I am still learning to obey.

*When Christ calls a man, he bids him
come and die. We turned that into a
call to inconvenience. He meant a
cross, and he meant it the way the
Romans meant it.*

SO TAKE UP YOUR cross is not a call to bear your minor annoyances with a good attitude. It is a call to die, to the death of the self as god, to the readiness to suffer for the way of love in a world of power, to a following that goes all the way down and holds nothing back. And the strange promise attached to it is that this death is the only road to life, that the self we so frantically protect is precisely the self that is killing us, and that only in laying it down do we find the life we were grasping for and never quite reaching. The world says save yourself. The cross says lose yourself, and in the losing find that you were never more alive. That is the pattern of the crucified God, stamped now onto the life of everyone who would follow him, come and die, and in dying, live.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Wisdom That Looks Like Folly

WE RETURN NOW TO where we began, to Paul's audacious claim that the message of the cross is folly to those who are perishing but to us who are being saved it is the power of God. He said that God chose what is foolish in the world to shame the wise, and what is weak to shame the strong, and that the foolishness of God is wiser than men and the weakness of God is stronger than men. This is not a throwaway paradox. It is the deepest thing Paul says about the cross, and it is the summary of everything this book has tried to show, that the cross overturns not only our morality and our religion but our very standards of wisdom and strength, revealing that what we called wisdom was folly and what we called folly was the wisdom of God.

Consider how thoroughly the cross violates every standard of wisdom the world has ever held. The wisdom of the world says that power is the way to get things done, and the cross achieves the salvation of the world through utter powerlessness. The wisdom of the world says that you must

look out for yourself, and the cross accomplishes everything through a total self-giving that keeps nothing back. The wisdom of the world says that the strong survive and the weak perish, and the cross reverses it, making the weakness of God stronger than all human strength. The wisdom of the world says that gods, if they exist, are to be found in glory and majesty and untouchable power, and the cross finds God in shame and suffering and death. At every point the cross contradicts what the human race has always been most sure of, and it does not contradict it accidentally, as if God simply failed to be wise by our standards. It contradicts it deliberately, to expose our wisdom as folly.

This is why the cross has always been, and will always be, an offense to the sophisticated and a scandal to the powerful. It cannot be otherwise. The cross is a permanent standing rebuke to every human system that runs on power and self-interest and the survival of the strong, which is to say every human system there has ever been. The world cannot receive the cross without ceasing to be the world, without abandoning the very logic by which it operates, and so the world must either be transformed by the cross or be perpetually offended by it. There is no third option, no way to make the cross respectable to a wisdom built on power, because the cross exists precisely to overturn that wisdom. Paul saw this clearly. The cross is not a wisdom that competes with the world's wisdom on the world's terms and wins. It is a wisdom that looks, by the world's terms, exactly like folly, and is vindicated only by the resurrection and only to the eyes of faith.

I want to press this against our own sophistication, because we imagine ourselves wiser than Paul's first-century hearers, and we are not. We have our own version of the

wisdom that finds the cross foolish. It is the wisdom that finds the whole idea of a God who dies for sinners embarrassing, primitive, unworthy of an enlightened age. It is the wisdom that wants a Christianity of ethics without atonement, of love without blood, of Jesus the great moral teacher without Jesus the crucified God. That wisdom is everywhere in the respectable religion of our time, and it is exactly the wisdom Paul says God chose to shame. It cannot bear the folly of the cross, and so it edits the cross out and keeps a manageable Jesus, a Jesus who confirms our existing values rather than overturning them. And in doing so it loses the one thing that made Christianity anything more than another system of self-improvement, the scandalous claim that God himself died to save us.

The folly of the cross is also a comfort of a particular and precious kind, and I do not want to end this chapter only in confrontation. Because if the wisdom of God looks like folly, then the people the world has written off as foolish and weak are exactly the people God has chosen. Paul says it. Not many of you were wise by worldly standards, not many were powerful, not many were of noble birth, but God chose the foolish, the weak, the low and despised, the things that are not, to bring to nothing the things that are. This is staggering good news for everyone the world's wisdom has discounted, everyone who has been made to feel foolish, weak, low, not enough. The cross means that God's choosing runs exactly opposite to the world's ranking, that the last are first, that the despised are chosen, that the wisdom of God embraces the very people the wisdom of the world throws away. If you have always felt like folly by the world's standards, the cross is your homecoming, because the God who saves is the God who chose folly to shame the wise.

I came to the cross as a man who prized his own wisdom, an atheist confident in his intellectual superiority to the simple believers I looked down on. And the cross humbled that wisdom by revealing it as folly, showing me that the thing I had dismissed as beneath my intelligence was in fact wiser than everything I had built my pride upon. That is not a comfortable conversion to describe, because it requires admitting that my wisdom was foolishness and that the folly I mocked was the wisdom of God. But it is the only honest account of what happened. I did not condescend to faith from a position of intellectual strength. I was undone by a wisdom that had looked, from my proud distance, exactly like folly, and turned out to be the power and the wisdom of God. The cross took my wisdom apart, and I have been grateful ever since that it did.

*The world called the cross folly and it
was right, by its own standards. What
it did not know is that its standards
were the folly, and the cross was the
wisdom of God.*

SO THE WISDOM THAT looks like folly is the final scandal, the one beneath all the others. The cross does not merely challenge our behavior or our religion. It challenges our very sense of what is wise and what is foolish, what is strong and what is weak, and it declares that on these most basic questions the human race has been catastrophically wrong,

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

and that the proof of how wrong we have been is that when Wisdom itself came among us, we crucified it as a fool. To become a Christian is finally to have your standards of wisdom overturned, to look at the cross that the world calls folly and to see there the deepest wisdom that exists, the power of God at work in what looked like total defeat. That reversal is the beginning of real understanding, and it starts, always, at the foot of a cross that the wise of every age agree is foolishness.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Cross at the Center of the Church

IF THE CROSS IS the center of everything, then it must be the center of the church, and I have to say with some grief that in a great deal of contemporary church life it is not. We have made many things the center. We have made the experience of worship the center, the feeling of transcendence we chase in our services. We have made moral improvement the center, the steady project of becoming better people. We have made community the center, the belonging and connection we all crave. We have made cultural relevance the center, the anxious effort to seem current and accessible. And each of these is a good thing that has crept into a place it was never meant to hold, displacing the one thing that belongs at the center, which is the crucified God.

I do not say this to sneer at worship or community or the desire to be good, all of which are genuine goods. I say it because a church organized around anything other than the cross will, in the end, become something other than the

church. A church centered on worship experience becomes a provider of religious feeling, a spiritual entertainment service that competes for attention like any other, and it dies when the feelings fade or a better production is offered elsewhere. A church centered on moral improvement becomes a self-help program with hymns, and it either produces proud people who think they are succeeding or despairing people who know they are not. A church centered on community becomes a club, warm and pleasant and finally indistinguishable from any other affinity group. A church centered on relevance chases the culture forever and, having no fixed center of its own, is absorbed by the very culture it was trying to reach. Only a church centered on the cross has something the world cannot offer and cannot absorb.

What does it mean, practically, for the cross to be the center of a church. It means, first, that the cross is preached, not as one theme among many, not as a doctrine we affirm and move past, but as the constant, returning, inexhaustible center of everything we proclaim. Paul resolved to know nothing among the Corinthians except Jesus Christ and him crucified, and that resolution should govern every pulpit that claims his gospel. Not that we preach only the cross to the exclusion of all else, but that everything we preach is finally connected to the cross, drawn from it, oriented toward it, unintelligible apart from it. The morality we teach is cross-shaped morality, self-giving love. The community we build is a cross-formed community, marked by forgiveness and the bearing of one another's burdens. The worship we offer is worship of the crucified and risen God. Take the cross out of the center and every other thing loses its meaning and drifts.

It means, second, that the church itself becomes cross-shaped in its life, and this is where it gets costly. A church

centered on the cross is a church that takes up its own cross, that follows the pattern of its crucified Lord not only in what it believes but in how it lives, laying down its life for the world rather than grasping for power over the world. This is the hardest thing, and it is where the church most often fails, my own included. It is easy to put a cross on the building. It is hard to let the cross shape the life, to be a community that forgives rather than retaliates, that serves rather than dominates, that would rather be crucified than compromise, that gives itself away for the sake of the very world that despises it. That is a cross-shaped church, and it is rare, because it costs exactly what the cross costs, everything.

The sacraments of the church exist in part to keep the cross at the center when our attention wanders, and I want to name this because we have often reduced them to mere symbols or rituals emptied of their weight. Baptism is a death and resurrection, a being buried with Christ and raised with him, a participation in the cross written onto the body of every believer. The Lord's Supper is the church's constant return to the cross, the broken body and the poured-out blood set before us again and again so that we cannot forget, so that the center stays the center, so that we eat and drink the death of the Lord until he comes. These are not empty rituals. They are the church's way of keeping the cross at the center of a memory that is always trying to drift toward something more comfortable. Every time we baptize, we preach the cross. Every time we break the bread, we proclaim the Lord's death. The sacraments are the cross made physical again and again, refusing to let us abstract it away.

I have pastored for years, and I have felt in my own ministry the constant gravitational pull away from the cross toward the many good things that want to take its place. It is

easier to grow a church on experience than on the cross. It is easier to gather people around community or relevance or moral uplift than around a crucified God who calls them to die. The cross does not draw crowds the way the alternatives do, because the cross asks everything, and I have felt the temptation, as every pastor does, to lead with the thing that fills the room rather than the thing that saves the soul. This chapter is written against that temptation in myself as much as in the wider church. The moment the cross stops being the center, the church becomes a religious version of something the world already has, and the world does not need a religious version of what it already has. It needs the one thing only the church can give, the crucified God.

*Put a cross on the building and you
have decoration. Let the cross shape the
life, and you have the church, which is
rare, because the cross costs exactly
what it costs.*

SO THE CROSS BELONGS at the center of the church, in its preaching, in its sacraments, in the very shape of its common life, or the church becomes something else while keeping the name. This is not nostalgia for old-time religion. It is the recognition that a church is only a church insofar as the crucified God stands at its heart, and that everything else, however good, becomes an idol the moment it takes the center. The scandal of the cross is meant to scandalize the

church first, to keep the church from becoming comfortable, respectable, absorbed into the world it was sent to save. A church at ease with itself has usually lost the cross. A church that keeps the cross at the center will never be entirely at ease, because the cross does not permit ease. It permits only the strange, costly, cruciform life of a people who have died with Christ and been raised, and who live now not for themselves but for the one who died for them and rose again.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Hinge of History

I HAVE CALLED THE cross the center of everything and the hinge of history, and before this book ends I want to make good on that claim in the largest terms, to step back from the particular darknesses the cross addresses and ask what it means for the whole story of the world. Because either the cross is a private religious symbol, meaningful to those who happen to find it meaningful and irrelevant to everyone else, or it is what the church has always claimed it to be, the turning point of the entire human story, the axis on which everything else moves. There is no middle position that is worth holding. Either God died on a Roman cross and changed everything, or he did not and we should stop pretending.

Consider what the cross claims about history. It claims that at a particular time, under a particular governor, at a particular place outside a particular city wall, the decisive event of all history occurred, not in a palace or a battlefield or a center of power but on an execution ground, in the death of a man the world had written off as a failed messiah. It claims that this obscure death, unnoticed by the historians of the great empires, unrecorded in the annals of the powers that

mattered, was in fact the event toward which all previous history had been moving and from which all subsequent history flows. It claims that the meaning of the entire human story is concentrated in that afternoon, that everything before it was preparation and everything after it is consequence, that the cross is the still point around which the whole turning world turns. This is either megalomania or it is the truth, and the church has staked everything on the second.

I find this claim more credible, not less, the more I consider how history actually works. The great events of history are rarely the ones the powerful notice at the time. The powers are always watching the wrong things, the palaces and the armies and the movements of empire, while the decisive things happen at the margins, unnoticed, in the places power ignores. Rome did not notice the crucifixion of Jesus. It was one execution among thousands, a minor administrative matter in a troublesome province, beneath the attention of anyone who mattered. And that unnoticed death has outlasted Rome, has shaped the moral imagination of the world more profoundly than every emperor combined, has been the subject of more thought and art and devotion than any other event in human history. The powers were watching the wrong thing, as they always are. The hinge of history turned on a hill they did not bother to look at.

And the cross reorganizes not only our sense of what matters in history but our sense of what history is for. If the center of history is a God who dies for the world, then history is not, at bottom, the story of the rise and fall of empires, not the survival of the fittest, not the march of progress or the endless cycle of power. It is the story of a God working toward the redemption of a world he loves, a story whose climax is

not a victory of force but a death of love, and whose end is not the triumph of the strong but the making new of all things. This changes how we read everything. The great and terrible events of history, the wars and the conquests and the achievements of the mighty, are not the main plot. They are the background against which the real story runs, the story of God's patient, costly, cross-shaped work to win back a world that had turned from him. The cross tells us what history is actually about, and it is not about the things the powerful have always insisted it is about.

There is a personal dimension to this that I cannot leave out, because the claim that the cross is the hinge of history is also the claim that it is the hinge of my history and yours. If the cross is the center of everything, then it is the center of your particular everything, the turning point not only of the cosmic story but of your own. Every life has a before and an after, and the gospel says the deepest before and after runs through the cross, through the death that becomes your death and the resurrection that becomes your life, through the point where your story is taken up into the story of the crucified God and given a meaning it could never have on its own. This is what conversion is, at its root. It is not primarily the adoption of a set of beliefs. It is the discovery that the hinge of all history is also the hinge of your history, that the cross at the center of everything is also, if you will have it, the center of you.

I was an atheist who believed history was a tale told by no one, signifying nothing, a random walk of matter and force with no center and no meaning and no end. And the thing that broke that conviction was the cross, the discovery that history has a center after all, and that the center is a God who loved the world enough to die for it. I cannot prove this to you

the way I could prove a theorem. But I can tell you that once you have seen the cross as the hinge of history, you cannot unsee it, and every other account of what the human story is about comes to seem, by comparison, thin and finally hopeless. The cross gives history a meaning that no secular story has ever managed to supply, a meaning centered not on our achievement, which always fails, but on God's love, which does not. That is either the greatest truth ever told or the greatest fiction, and I have staked my life on the first.

*The powers were watching the palaces.
The hinge of history turned on a hill
they did not bother to look at, in the
death of a man they had already
forgotten.*

SO THE CROSS IS the hinge of history, the point on which the whole story turns, the center of everything, and this is not a pious exaggeration but the sober claim of the Christian faith, which either means it or means nothing. The world will keep watching the wrong things, the palaces and the powers and the loud events that seem to matter. The church exists to keep pointing at the hill they are not looking at, at the unnoticed death that turned out to be the turning of the world. And to every person who feels their own small history is meaningless, a random and forgettable flicker in an indifferent universe, the cross says otherwise. It says the center of all history is also willing to be the center of yours,

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

that your story can be taken up into the greatest story there is, and given, at the foot of a cross, a meaning that death itself cannot take away.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Sacrifice We Stopped Understanding

THE NEW TESTAMENT CALLS the death of Christ a sacrifice, and this is language we have almost entirely lost the ability to hear. Sacrifice belongs, in the modern imagination, to a primitive past, to bloody altars and superstitious peoples trying to bribe capricious gods, to a stage of religion we have thankfully outgrown. So when the Scriptures call Christ a sacrifice, when they name him the Lamb of God, when the letter to the Hebrews devotes chapter after chapter to the sacrificial system and its fulfillment in the cross, we tend to skim past it, embarrassed, as though the writers had lapsed into an old idiom we can quietly translate into something more palatable. And in skimming past it we lose one of the deepest things the cross reveals about God and about ourselves.

Let me first grant the caricature its due, because the caricature is real. There have been sacrificial religions that were exactly what the modern critic despises, systems for appeasing angry deities, for buying off divine wrath with

blood, for manipulating the gods into cooperation through the right ritual performed at the right altar. That is real, and the Hebrew prophets themselves denounced it with a fury that no modern secularist has exceeded. When Israel imagined its sacrifices were a mechanism for buying God off while its people oppressed the poor, the prophets thundered that God despised their offerings, that he wanted mercy and not sacrifice, that their solemn assemblies were a stench to him. So the critique of sacrifice as manipulation is not a modern discovery. It is inside the Bible, aimed by God at his own people's misuse of the system he had given. The prophets got there first.

But the sacrifice at the heart of the biblical faith is the opposite of the manipulation the prophets condemned, and this is what we miss. In pagan sacrifice, human beings offer something to appease the gods. In the sacrifice of the cross, God offers himself to reconcile human beings. The direction is reversed. It is not us giving to God to change his disposition toward us. It is God giving himself to change our situation. The Lamb of God is not a lamb we bring to the altar to buy God's favor. It is God himself, become the Lamb, offered by God for us. This reversal is the whole thing, and missing it is missing everything. The sacrificial language does not mean that God is a bloodthirsty deity who had to be appeased. It means that God, rather than requiring a sacrifice from us that we could never adequately give, became the sacrifice himself, provided the offering out of his own being, did for us what we could never do.

The old sacrificial system, understood rightly, was never about buying God off. It was a God-given picture, a teaching in blood and ritual, meant to press upon a people the terrible seriousness of sin and the costliness of its forgiveness, and

meant to point forward to the one sacrifice that would fulfill and end all the others. The endless repetition of the sacrifices, the daily and yearly return to the altar, was itself a sermon, declaring that these offerings could not finally take away sin, that they were shadows waiting for a substance, pointers to a sacrifice not yet made. And when Christ died, the letter to the Hebrews says, he did once for all what the whole system had been unable to do, offered a single sacrifice for sins that needed never be repeated, and so ended the altars forever. The tearing of the temple curtain at the moment of his death was the announcement that the sacrificial system had reached its fulfillment and its close. There would be no more altars, because the one sacrifice had been made, by God, of God, for us.

Why does this matter for us, who live so far from altars and lambs. It matters because the loss of sacrifice as a category has left us unable to understand the costliness of forgiveness, and therefore unable to understand grace. We imagine forgiveness is free, a simple decision to let go, a waving away of the debt at no cost to anyone. The sacrificial language insists otherwise. Forgiveness is never free. It always costs the one who forgives, always requires the absorption of a real loss, always involves the forgiver in a kind of death, bearing the wrong themselves rather than exacting it from the wrongdoer. Sacrifice is the biblical way of saying that grace is costly, that the forgiveness of sins required the death of God, that our reconciliation was purchased at a price beyond calculation. Lose the sacrificial language and you lose the cost, and lose the cost and grace becomes cheap, a divine indulgence that asks nothing because it cost nothing. The cross cost everything.

I confess I spent years as a preacher quietly embarrassed

by the sacrificial language, translating it wherever I could into something more congenial to modern ears, speaking of the cross as an act of love and solidarity while edging away from the altar and the Lamb and the blood. And in doing so I was, without admitting it, participating in the very reduction I now warn against, thinning the cross into a beautiful idea and losing the costly reality that the sacrificial language exists to protect. It was Fleming Rutledge, in that patient book of 2015, who helped me see that I could not keep the depth of the cross while discarding the language the Scriptures use to speak of it, that the sacrificial imagery was not a primitive shell around a modern kernel but part of the truth itself. I had wanted a cross without a sacrifice. There is no such cross. The one at the center of the faith is a sacrifice, God's own, offered by God for a world that could never have offered it for itself.

*Pagan sacrifice is us giving to appease
the gods. The cross is God giving
himself to reconcile us. The direction is
reversed, and the reversal is the whole
gospel.*

SO WE MUST RELEARN the language we stopped understanding. The cross is a sacrifice, not because God is a deity who craves blood, but because forgiveness is costly and God paid the cost himself. The Lamb of God is not our offering to God but God's offering for us. The end of the

sacrificial system is not the abolition of sacrifice but its fulfillment in the one sacrifice that ended all the others. And the grace that reaches us through the cross is not the cheap forgiveness of a God who asks nothing because it costs nothing, but the costly grace of a God who gave himself, the last and deepest thing, to reconcile a world that had turned from him. When we recover the sacrifice, we recover the cost, and when we recover the cost, we recover the wonder, that God did not require the offering from us but became it for us, once for all, on a hill outside the city, where the true and final altar stood.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Cross and the Wrath of God

I HAVE CIRCLED THIS word several times without landing on it directly, and it is time to face it, because it is the word that gives the modern reader the most trouble, and the word that a great deal of contemporary preaching has quietly abandoned. The word is wrath. The Scriptures speak, without embarrassment, of the wrath of God, and they connect it directly to the cross, saying that Christ bore the wrath our sin deserved, that he was set forth as a propitiation, which is an old word meaning the turning away of wrath. And nothing in the vocabulary of the faith is more offensive to the modern ear than the idea that God has wrath, and that the cross has anything to do with satisfying it.

Let me first say why the word troubles us, because the trouble is not stupid. Wrath, in human beings, is usually a defect. It is anger out of control, the loss of composure, the eruption of a passion that clouds judgment and lashes out. When we hear that God has wrath, we import all of that, and we picture a deity in a rage, volatile and dangerous, needing

to be calmed down, an angry god who must be appeased before he does something regrettable. And such a god would indeed be a monster, unworthy of worship, a projection of our own worst tempers onto the heavens. If that is what divine wrath meant, we would be right to reject it, and much popular preaching has indeed made it mean exactly that, and has earned the rejection.

But the wrath of God in the Scriptures is not a divine loss of temper. It is something far more serious and far more coherent, and once you see it you cannot go back to the caricature. The wrath of God is the settled, holy, personal opposition of a good God to everything that destroys what he loves. It is not the opposite of his love but an expression of it. Consider. If you love someone, you are not neutral toward the things that harm them. A father who watched his child being abused and felt nothing, no anger, only a mild disapproval, would not be a good father but a moral catastrophe. The absence of wrath in the presence of evil is not virtue. It is indifference, and indifference toward evil is a failure of love. The wrath of God is the necessary response of perfect love to the presence of that which destroys the beloved. A God without wrath would be a God without love, a God who looked at the torture of children and the ruin of the world he made and felt nothing worth naming.

So the wrath of God is not a problem to be explained away but an implication of his goodness to be understood. And here is where the cross does its most astonishing work, because the cross is the place where the wrath of God and the love of God are revealed to be, in the deepest sense, one thing. The same event that expresses God's total opposition to sin, his wrath against everything that ruins his creation, is the event that expresses his total love for the sinner, his refusal to

let us be destroyed by the sin he opposes. He does not pour out his wrath on us. He takes it into himself. The wrath against sin is real, and it falls, but it falls on God, in the person of the Son, so that it need not fall on us. This is the meaning of that old and difficult word propitiation, the turning away of wrath, not by our appeasing an angry deity, but by God himself providing, in his own person, the place where his wrath against sin is exhausted.

I want to be careful here, because this can be preached in a way that tears the Trinity apart, that makes the Father the wrathful one and the Son the loving one, as if Jesus came to protect us from an angry God. That is the distortion I addressed in the chapter on substitution, and it is a genuine heresy. The wrath is not the Father's against the Son. It is the triune God's against sin, and it is borne by the triune God in the person of the Son, Father and Son of one will and one love throughout. The Father is not the angry party and the Son the kind party. Both love. Both oppose the sin. And together, in one act of a single divine will, they arrange that the wrath against sin should fall on God himself rather than on the world God loves. That is not a God venting his temper on an innocent. That is a God absorbing his own righteous opposition to evil into his own being, so that we can be spared.

I resisted this doctrine for a long time even after I believed much else, because I had absorbed the modern discomfort with wrath and wanted a God who was only love, love without judgment, love without opposition to anything. And what I slowly came to see is that a God who is only that kind of love is a God who does not finally take evil seriously, a God for whom the suffering and injustice of the world are matters of ultimate indifference. I did not want that God after all. I

wanted a God who was angry at the abuse of children, at the oppression of the weak, at the vast machinery of human cruelty, a God whose love was fierce enough to include opposition to everything that love hates. And that God has wrath, necessarily, because that God loves. The cross did not free me from the wrath of God. It showed me that the wrath and the love met there, and that the God who had every reason for wrath against me chose to bear it himself.

*A God who felt no wrath at the abuse of
the innocent would not be loving. He
would be indifferent. The wrath of God
is the fury of his love against
everything that destroys what he made.*

SO WE CANNOT LOSE the wrath of God without losing the seriousness of his love. The task is not to abandon the word but to rescue it from the caricature, to understand that divine wrath is not a temper to be appeased but the holy opposition of love to evil, and that the cross is the place where that wrath fell on God himself rather than on us. This is the deepest reason the cross is good news and not merely a beautiful gesture. It means that the God who has every right to be against us, whose holiness opposes our sin with a fury we cannot imagine, has arranged at infinite cost to himself to be for us instead, to take the wrath into his own body so that we might receive the love. The wrath is real. The cross is where it landed. And it landed on God.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Descent into Hell

THERE IS A LINE in the ancient creed that most Christians recite without pausing over it, and it may be the strangest line in the whole confession. He was crucified, dead, and buried. He descended into hell. On the third day he rose again. That middle clause, he descended into hell, has puzzled the church for centuries, and interpreters have argued endlessly about what it means. But I want to sit with it, because whatever the precise meaning, it points to something the cross reveals that we have barely begun to receive, that the death of God reached all the way down, to the very bottom, to the lowest place there is, and that there is now no depth a human being can fall to where God has not already been.

The descent into hell, at minimum, means this, that Christ truly died, that his death was not a partial or symbolic thing but the real and total experience of death in all its darkness, including whatever lies on the far side of it. He did not merely approach death and pull back. He entered it fully, went where the dead go, tasted death to the last drop. And this matters enormously for anyone who has ever feared that their darkness was too deep for God to reach, that they had fallen to a place beyond the light, that their particular hell was a

country God had never visited and could not enter. The descent says otherwise. It says God has been to the bottom, to the lowest and darkest place, to the realm of the dead and the god-forsaken, and there is no pit so deep that his descent has not already reached its floor.

Consider the cry from the cross, my God, my God, why have you forsaken me. This is the deepest word in the whole account of the crucifixion, and it names an experience we usually try to keep away from God, the experience of god-forsakenness, of feeling utterly abandoned by the very God we cry to. We assume that the sense of being forsaken by God is the one place God cannot be, the definition of his absence. And the cross shatters that assumption, because on the cross God himself cries the cry of the forsaken. The Son, in the darkness of the cross, experiences the absence of the Father, the forsakenness that is the essence of hell, so that even that experience, even the sense of being abandoned by God, has now been taken up into God, has become part of God's own experience, and is therefore no longer a place outside his reach. Moltmann built his whole theology of the crucified God around this cry, arguing that in it God experienced god-forsakenness, took the very hell of abandonment into his own life, so that no one who cries that cry cries it alone.

This is unspeakably good news for the person in the depths, and I have watched it be the only good news that reached them. There are places human beings fall to that no cheerful gospel can enter, places of despair so complete that any word of easy comfort is an insult, the pit of the person who feels God has abandoned them, who cries out and hears nothing, who is convinced they have fallen beyond all reach. To such a person you cannot say cheer up, God is with you, because they do not feel God is with them, they feel forsaken,

and to deny their experience is to lose them. But you can say something else. You can say that the God you feel has forsaken you cried that very cry himself, that he has been where you are, in the darkness of feeling abandoned by God, and that he went there precisely so that you would not be alone in it. That is not a denial of the darkness. It is God present in the darkness, having descended all the way to its floor.

I have to speak here of my own descent, because I have been to a version of that bottom, in the years of my atheism and after, in seasons of a darkness I did not have words for, and the thing that finally reached me was not a bright and cheerful God who summoned me up out of the pit from a safe distance above. It was the discovery that God had come down into the pit himself, that the God I had felt was absent had cried the cry of the absent God on a cross, that there was no darkness I could reach that he had not reached first and reached deeper. That is what finally held. Not a God who called down to me from the light, but a God who had descended into the dark ahead of me and was waiting there, at the bottom, having gone lower than I could go. The child raised without a father learns the geography of abandonment early, and the descent into hell means that even that country, the country of the forsaken, has been visited by God.

There is a final dimension of the descent that I do not want to lose, and it is the note of victory hidden inside the defeat. The oldest traditions of the church pictured the descent not only as Christ's entry into the depths but as his conquest of them, the harrowing of hell, the crucified God going down into the realm of death and shattering its gates from the inside, freeing the captives, plundering the domain of the enemy. Whatever we make of the imagery, it names a truth we

have already seen, that the descent was not only solidarity but victory, that God went to the bottom not merely to be with us there but to defeat what held us there, to break the power of death and hell from the inside, in the one place they could truly be broken. The descent is the deepest reach of the Christus Victor pattern, the conquest carried all the way down to the lowest floor of the enemy's house.

*There is no pit so deep that his descent
has not already reached its floor. The
God you feel has forsaken you cried the
cry of the forsaken first, and went
lower than you can go.*

SO THE DESCENT INTO hell, that strange clause we recite without thinking, is one of the most precious lines in the creed, because it means that the death of God reached all the way down. There is no darkness beyond his reach, no despair he has not entered, no god-forsakenness he has not himself experienced and taken into his own being. And this is the answer to the deepest fear the human heart can hold, the fear that we have fallen to a place God cannot come, that our particular hell is a country outside the map of grace. The cross says there is no such country. God has been everywhere the lost can go, down to the very bottom, and he is there now, at the floor of every pit, having descended ahead of us and for us, so that even in hell, if we make our bed in hell, he is there. That is how far the death of God reached. All the way down.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Cheap Grace and the Cost of the Cross

DIETRICH BONHOEFFER, WRITING IN Germany in 1937 as the church around him was capitulating to a monstrous regime, gave us a phrase that has never lost its edge, and it names the great danger of a church that has forgotten the cost of the cross. He called it cheap grace, and he called it the deadly enemy of the church, and he said that we are fighting today for costly grace. I have quoted him already in these pages, but I want to give his distinction a chapter of its own, because it is the point where everything this book has argued about the cost of the cross comes to bear on the actual life of the believer, and because I am as guilty of cheap grace as anyone I could name.

Cheap grace, Bonhoeffer wrote, is grace we bestow on ourselves. It is the preaching of forgiveness without requiring repentance, baptism without church discipline, communion without confession, grace without discipleship, grace without the cross, grace without Jesus Christ living and incarnate. It is the grace that asks nothing because it cost the recipient

nothing, the grace that leaves the sinner exactly as he was, comfortable in his sin, assured of a forgiveness that makes no claim on his life. Cheap grace is the mortal enemy of the church because it looks exactly like the real thing while being its opposite, a counterfeit so close to the genuine that we cannot tell the difference until it is too late, until we discover that a whole church has been living on a grace that never actually saved anyone because it never actually cost anything or changed anything.

Against this, Bonhoeffer set costly grace, and he defined it by the cross. Costly grace is the treasure hidden in the field, for which a man sells everything he has. It is the pearl of great price, for which the merchant gives all. It is costly because it costs a man his life, and it is grace because it gives a man the only true life. Above all it is costly because it cost God the life of his Son, and what has cost God so much cannot be cheap to us. The whole logic of Bonhoeffer's distinction runs through the cross. Grace is costly because the cross was costly, because our forgiveness required the death of God, and a grace purchased at such a price cannot be received as though it were free. To receive the costly grace of the cross cheaply, as a mere assurance that we are fine as we are, is to insult the blood that bought it, to treat the death of God as though it had changed nothing.

I said I am guilty here, and I want to be specific, because vague confession is its own form of cheap grace. I have preached forgiveness without repentance, offered people an assurance of God's love that made no claim on how they lived, told congregations they were accepted just as they are and stopped there, without the second half, without the call to take up the cross and die and follow. I have wanted to be liked, and cheap grace is popular, because it comforts without

disturbing, forgives without requiring, saves without costing. Costly grace is not popular, because it asks everything, because it tells the forgiven sinner that he has been bought at a price and is no longer his own, because it joins forgiveness to discipleship and refuses to separate them. Every time I have separated them, offering the comfort of the cross without the call of the cross, I have preached cheap grace, and I have done it for the oldest of reasons, because I wanted the room full and the people pleased.

The context of Bonhoeffer's writing gives his words a weight that should shame our comfortable versions of them. He was watching a church surrender to Hitler, watching Christians who had received grace cheaply discover that a faith that cost nothing was a faith that could stand for nothing, that would bend to any power, that would baptize any evil, because it had no cross at its center to stiffen its spine. Cheap grace produced a church that could be absorbed by the Reich without resistance, because it had never learned that grace makes a claim, that the crucified Lord calls his people to a cross of their own, that a faith worth anything must be willing to lose everything. And Bonhoeffer backed his words with his body, refusing the cheap grace that would have let him stay safe, taking up the costly grace that led him to the resistance and finally to the gallows. He wrote that when Christ calls a man he bids him come and die, and then he died, and the correspondence between his words and his death is what gives his words their terrible authority.

The application to our own moment is not far to seek, though it takes different forms. We too are surrounded by cheap grace, by a Christianity that asks nothing and costs nothing and therefore changes nothing, a grace that has been detached from the cross and become mere self-acceptance

with religious decoration. And we too face the temptation to enlist our faith in the service of powers that would love a church too comfortable to resist them, a church living on cheap grace that would baptize whatever it was told to baptize because it had no cross at its center. The recovery of the scandal of the cross is, among other things, the recovery of costly grace, the rediscovery that what cost God everything cannot cost us nothing, that a grace worth having is a grace that makes a claim, that the forgiveness of the cross comes joined to the call of the cross, and that the two must never be separated.

*Cheap grace is grace we bestow on
ourselves, forgiveness without
repentance, the cross with the cost
removed. Costly grace cost God his Son,
and what cost God that much cannot
be cheap to us.*

SO THE COST OF the cross is not only something God paid long ago. It is something that reaches into the present and makes a claim on everyone who would receive its grace. Bonhoeffer's distinction is finally a call to let the cost of the cross become the cost of discipleship, to refuse the counterfeit grace that comforts without changing, and to receive instead the costly grace that gives real life because it makes a real claim. This is not works-righteousness, not an earning of what can only be given. It is the recognition that a

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

gift purchased at such a price cannot be treated as though it were cheap, that the grace which cost God his Son will cost us our lives, and that this costing is not the denial of grace but its very depth. The cross was costly. The grace that flows from it is costly. And a church that recovers the scandal of the cross will recover the cost, and be changed by it, and become again a church that can stand.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Two Thieves

THERE WERE THREE CROSSES on Golgotha, not one, and the church has always known that the two beside Jesus were not incidental. Luke tells us they were criminals, and that one of them mocked Jesus while the other rebuked the first and turned to Jesus with a request so simple and so desperate that it has become the model of every deathbed conversion since. Remember me when you come into your kingdom. And Jesus answered, today you will be with me in paradise. Two men, equally condemned, equally close to the same dying Savior, and one is saved and one is not, and the difference between them is the whole drama of the human response to the cross played out in miniature at the foot of the cross itself.

I want to sit with these two thieves because they represent the two possibilities that stand before every person who encounters the crucified God, and because they strip the choice down to its essentials. Both men are guilty. Luke does not soften this. They are criminals, justly condemned, and the one who is saved admits it plainly, we are receiving the due reward of our deeds. There is no pretense here of innocence, no claim to have earned anything, no record of good works to appeal to. The saved thief has nothing. He is a

condemned criminal hours from death, with no time to reform, no opportunity to make amends, no righteousness to offer. He is, in the starkest possible terms, a man with nothing but his need, and this is precisely why he is the perfect picture of what it means to be saved by grace.

Consider what the saved thief does not do. He does not clean up his life first. He cannot, there is no time, he is dying. He does not perform a single good work after his conversion. He does not get baptized, does not join a church, does not amend his ways, does not have the opportunity to become a better man. He does nothing but recognize his own guilt, recognize who Jesus is, and cast himself on the mercy of the dying King. And he is saved, fully and immediately, on the word of Jesus himself, today you will be with me in paradise. This is the gospel in its purest and most scandalous form, salvation given to a man with nothing to offer but his need, in the last hour of a wasted life, on the basis of nothing but the mercy of Christ. It offends our sense of fairness because it is not fair. It is grace, and grace is never fair, it is better than fair.

The other thief is the more troubling figure, because he is so close to salvation and misses it. He is on a cross next to the Savior of the world. He is as near to Jesus as any human being has ever been. And he mocks. He joins the crowd in its jeering, demanding that Jesus prove himself by coming down, by exercising the power of glory that would validate the whole spectacle. If you are the Christ, save yourself and us. Notice the theology of glory in the demand. Save yourself. Come down. Show us the power. The unsaved thief cannot see God in the weakness of the cross, cannot recognize the King in the dying man beside him, because he is looking for a God who fits his expectations, a God of power who escapes the cross rather than a God of love who hangs on it. He is a

theologian of glory to the last, and it costs him everything.

What separates the two thieves is not the depth of their sin, which is the same, nor their proximity to Jesus, which is the same, nor their circumstances, which are identical. What separates them is one thing. One recognizes his guilt and casts himself on mercy, and one demands that God prove himself on his own terms. One admits he has nothing and receives everything. One demands that Jesus perform and receives nothing. This is the whole difference between salvation and its loss, played out between two dying men, and it is the same difference that stands before every reader of these words. Will you recognize your guilt and cast yourself on the mercy of the crucified God, or will you demand that he prove himself to you on your terms before you will believe. The two thieves are not just historical figures. They are the two of us, and everyone must be one or the other.

I have been both thieves. I was the mocking thief for years, demanding that God prove himself, insisting that a real God would come down from the cross of my objections and perform the miracle that would compel my belief, standing in judgment over the God I did not believe in and finding him wanting. And then, by grace I did not earn and cannot explain, I became the other thief, the one who finally stopped demanding and started asking, who admitted I was receiving the due reward of my deeds, who turned to the dying King with nothing but my need and heard, against all deserving, the word of paradise. The distance between the two thieves is the distance grace crossed in me, and it is a distance I did not travel by my own effort. I was moved from the one cross to the other, from the mockery to the mercy, and I do not take credit for the crossing.

*Two thieves, equally guilty, equally
close to the same Savior. One
demanded that God prove himself. One
admitted he had nothing. That is the
whole difference between heaven and
hell.*

SO THE TWO THIEVES are a parable enacted in blood at the foot of the cross, and they present the choice that the cross always presents, the choice between the theology of glory that demands God come down and the faith that receives him where he is, dying, offering mercy to those who have nothing. The saved thief is the patron saint of everyone who comes to the cross too late, too broken, too empty-handed, with a wasted life and no time to fix it, because he proves that the cross saves not the worthy but the needy, not those who have earned it but those who admit they never could. And the unsaved thief is the sober warning to everyone who would stand in judgment over the crucified God, demanding proof on their own terms, unable to see the King in the dying man because they are looking for a God of glory and refusing the God of the cross. Between the two crosses stands the choice, today, as it stood that afternoon on Golgotha, and no one can decline to choose.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Cross and the Prodigal

JESUS TOLD A STORY that is often called the parable of the prodigal son, though it might better be called the parable of the two lost sons, or the parable of the running father, and it is the most beloved story he ever told about the heart of God. And yet there is something strange about it that the church has long puzzled over, something that connects it directly to the scandal of the cross. The story seems to show forgiveness without a cross. The father simply forgives, runs to embrace the returning son, restores him without any payment, any sacrifice, any death. And some have used this parable to argue against the whole idea of the cross, saying, see, God forgives freely, no atonement required, the father just takes the boy back. But this reading misses the deepest thing in the story, and when we see what it misses, the parable becomes not an argument against the cross but a window into it.

Let me tell the story as Jesus told it, because familiarity has dulled its shock. A younger son demands his inheritance while his father is still alive, which in that culture was a way

of saying I wish you were dead, a wound of staggering cruelty. He takes the money and squanders it in a far country, ending in the pigsty, feeding swine, longing to eat their food, a Jewish boy reduced to the most unclean labor imaginable. He comes to himself and returns, rehearsing a speech of repentance, hoping only to be taken back as a servant. And the father, who has been watching the road, sees him while he is still far off and runs to him, an old man hiking up his robes and running, which was itself a humiliation in that culture, a loss of dignity no patriarch would ordinarily accept, and embraces him and restores him fully as a son. It is one of the most moving pictures of grace ever drawn.

Now where is the cross in this. Here is what the shallow reading misses. The father does not forgive at no cost. The forgiveness costs him enormously, and the story shows it if we have eyes to see. It costs him his dignity, in the running, the public humiliation of an old man racing down the road to a son who had wished him dead. It costs him materially, because the inheritance is gone, squandered, and taking the boy back means absorbing that loss, bearing it himself rather than making the son repay what could never be repaid. And it costs him with the elder son, whose bitter resentment the father must also go out to meet, absorbing that wound too. The father in the parable is not a picture of costless forgiveness. He is a picture of forgiveness that costs the forgiver everything, that bears the loss and the shame and the wound rather than exacting them from the wrongdoer. And that is exactly what the cross is.

This is the thing the tradition has seen that the shallow reading misses. Forgiveness is never free for the one who grants it. The parable does not show forgiveness without cost. It shows the cost borne by the father rather than exacted from

the son, which is the very shape of the cross. When God forgives, he does not simply wave the debt away as if it never mattered. He absorbs it, bears it, takes the loss into himself, pays it out of his own being. The running father, humiliating himself to reach the returning son, absorbing the loss of the squandered inheritance, is a picture drawn in miniature of the God who would humiliate himself all the way to a cross, absorb the loss of our rebellion, bear in his own body the cost of taking us back. The parable does not contradict the cross. It portrays its logic. The father runs. God runs all the way to Golgotha.

There is a further depth here that Tim Keller pressed in his own reflection on this parable, that the story has two lost sons, not one, and that the elder son, the dutiful one who never left, is lost in a way more dangerous than the prodigal, lost in his self-righteousness, his resentment, his refusal to enter the feast. And the story ends unresolved, with the father pleading with the elder son to come in, and we never learn whether he does. This is the sting in the tail. The parable is aimed not only at the obvious sinners but at the religious, the dutiful, the ones who think they have earned the father's favor by their obedience and resent the grace shown to the undeserving. And it is the elder brother, the religious son, who in the end will not come to the feast, while the prodigal, the obvious failure, is inside rejoicing. The cross offends the elder brother in all of us, the part that wants to earn, that resents free grace, that would rather have a wage than a gift.

I have been both sons, as I have been both thieves, and I confess the elder brother is the one who dies hardest in me. The prodigal in me came home years ago and was received with a grace I did not deserve. But the elder brother lives on, the part of me that, having come home, now resents the grace

shown to others, that keeps a private ledger of my obedience, that would prefer to have earned my standing rather than received it, that stands outside the feast of grace sulking about fairness. The cross rebukes the elder brother most of all, because the cross is the death of all earning, the end of every ledger, the declaration that no one is inside the feast on the basis of their obedience, that we are all there, prodigal and elder brother alike, only because the father ran to us and bore the cost himself. The elder brother in me finds that as offensive as the younger brother found it liberating.

*The father does not forgive at no cost.
He absorbs the loss, bears the shame,
runs the humiliating road. The
parable does not skip the cross. It draws
its shape in a running old man.*

SO THE PARABLE OF the prodigal is not an argument against the cross but a portrait of its heart, the God who forgives by bearing the cost himself, the father who runs, who humiliates himself, who absorbs the loss and the shame rather than exacting them, and who then must go out again to plead with the elder brother, the religious son who resents the grace. The cross is the running father taken all the way to its end, the humiliation carried to the point of death, the loss absorbed to the last drop of blood. And the feast at the end of the parable is the feast the cross opens, the celebration of the undeserving welcomed home, which offends the elder

brother and delights the prodigal, and which is thrown not because anyone earned it but because the father ran, and bore the cost, and would not rest until the lost were found and seated at his table.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Cross and the Table

WHEN JESUS WANTED TO leave his followers something that would keep the meaning of his death before them until he returned, he did not leave them a book, a doctrine, or a monument. He left them a meal. On the night he was betrayed, he took bread and broke it and said this is my body, and took the cup and said this is my blood, and told them to do this in remembrance of him. The central act of Christian worship, repeated in every generation and on every continent for two thousand years, is a meal that proclaims a death. And there is more theology of the cross packed into that simple table than in whole libraries of argument, if we will slow down and receive it.

Consider first the sheer physicality of it, which we have already seen the blood insisting upon. Jesus did not leave us an idea to contemplate but a meal to eat, bread to chew and wine to swallow, the death made tangible, taken into the body. This is God's mercy toward our forgetfulness and our abstraction. We are creatures who spiritualize everything, who turn realities into concepts and concepts into vagueness, and the table refuses to let us do this with the cross. It puts the broken body and the poured-out blood into our hands

and our mouths, insists on the physical reality, makes the cross something we eat rather than merely something we think about. Every time the church gathers at the table, it is prevented from abstracting the cross away, because the cross is on the plate, in the cup, in the mouth. The table is the cross made edible, the death made present, so that we cannot forget what we are always trying to forget.

Consider next what the table says about who the cross is for. Jesus ate this meal with the men who would abandon him. Judas was at the table, the betrayer, dipping his bread in the same dish. Peter was at the table, who would deny him three times before morning. All of them were there, every one of whom would fail him that very night, and he broke the bread for all of them, knowing exactly what they would do. The table is set for the very people who will fail. It is not a reward for the faithful but a gift to the failing, a meal offered to those who are about to abandon the host, which is to say it is offered to us, who abandon him daily and are welcomed back to the table daily. The cross was for the failing, and the table that proclaims the cross is set for the failing, and if you have ever wondered whether you belong at that table, the answer is written in the fact that the first ones invited were the ones who ran away that night.

Consider also what the table does to time. The bread and the cup reach backward and forward at once. They reach back to a death that happened once, on a particular afternoon, under Pontius Pilate, a completed event that will not be repeated. And they reach forward to a feast not yet come, the great banquet of the kingdom, the marriage supper of the Lamb, the day when the crucified and risen Lord will gather his people at a table where death is no more. Paul says we proclaim the Lord's death until he comes, and that little

phrase holds the whole span, the death behind us and the coming before us, and the table stands in the middle, drawing both into the present moment, so that in eating we remember the cross and anticipate the kingdom at once. The table is where the whole story of redemption is compressed into a bite of bread, the death that saves and the feast that awaits, held together in a single act of eating.

There is a dimension of the table I have often neglected in my preaching and want to recover, and it is the way the table forms a people, not just individuals. When Paul rebuked the Corinthians for their misuse of the Supper, his complaint was not primarily about their private devotion but about their divisions, the fact that the rich ate while the poor went hungry, that the body of Christ was fractured at the very table that proclaimed his broken body. The table is meant to make one people out of many, to break down the divisions the world builds, to seat the rich beside the poor and the slave beside the free at a single table where all eat the same bread and drink the same cup because all are saved by the same cross. A church that eats the Supper while maintaining its divisions has not understood the table, because the cross that the table proclaims tore down the dividing walls, and to eat at the table while rebuilding those walls is to eat, Paul says, to our own judgment.

I have stood behind the table countless times, breaking the bread and lifting the cup, and I confess I have sometimes done it as a mere ritual, a thing we do because we have always done it, my mind elsewhere, my heart cold, the mystery reduced to a procedure. And every time I have caught myself doing this, I have been rebuked by the sheer weight of what is in my hands, the body and the blood, the death of God made present, the meal set for failures like me. The table will not let

me stay abstract. It puts the cross into my hands and asks me to eat, and in the eating I am confronted again with everything this book has tried to say, that God died, that the death was for the failing, that the death that happened once is present here, and that a feast is coming where the crucified Lamb will be the light and there will be no more crosses, only the table, forever.

*He left us a meal, not a monument. The
cross made edible, set for the very men
who would run away that night, which
is to say, set for us.*

SO THE TABLE IS the cross the church returns to again and again, the death made present, made physical, made edible, set before us as often as we gather so that we cannot forget and cannot abstract and cannot imagine we have outgrown our need. It proclaims the death until he comes. It gathers the failing to the feast of grace. It forms one people out of many across every division the world can build. And it holds, in a bite of bread and a sip of wine, the whole span of the story, the cross behind us and the kingdom before us, the death that saved and the banquet that waits. Every meal at that table is a small scandal of the cross, God's death handed to sinners to eat, and every time we come to it we are proclaiming, in the humblest possible act, that the center of everything is a place where God bled, and that his broken body is our bread.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Why the Resurrection Needs the Cross

I HAVE DELIBERATELY KEPT this book on the cross, on the death of God, resisting the pull to rush toward the empty tomb before we have sat long enough in the dark of Friday. And I have done this on purpose, because the great temptation of the church has always been to hurry past the cross to the resurrection, to treat Good Friday as a brief unpleasantness on the way to Easter, to preach a triumphant Christianity that has skipped the death and kept only the victory. But now, near the end, I want to say clearly how the cross and the resurrection belong together, why neither means anything without the other, and why the church that rushes past the cross ends up losing the resurrection too.

Begin with the obvious point that the resurrection requires a real death. There can be no rising without a real dying, no empty tomb without a filled one first, no victory over death without a genuine defeat by death. And this is not a trivial logical point but a matter of the deepest substance, because a resurrection that followed a merely apparent death

would prove nothing, would be a magic trick, a divine sleight of hand in which God never actually risked anything and never actually defeated anything. The power of the resurrection is precisely that it followed a real death, the real death of God, a death as total and final as any death, and that death was reversed, conquered, undone. Take away the reality of the death and you take away the meaning of the rising. The resurrection is only good news because the cross was real bad news first, the actual death of the actual Son of God, from which he actually rose.

But the deeper point is the reverse, that the cross without the resurrection would be defeat, and this is the point the church that rushes past the cross forgets in its haste. Without the resurrection, the cross is simply the death of another good man crushed by the powers, another idealist destroyed by the empire, a tragedy and nothing more. Paul says it with brutal clarity, that if Christ has not been raised our preaching is in vain and our faith is in vain, and we are of all people most to be pitied. The cross alone, without the resurrection, does not save anyone. It is just a death. It becomes the salvation of the world only because it was vindicated by the resurrection, only because God raised the crucified one and thereby declared that his death was not a defeat but a victory, not the end of the story but its turning point. The resurrection is God's verdict on the cross, his declaration that this death, which looked like the ultimate failure, was in fact the ultimate triumph.

So the cross and the resurrection interpret each other, and neither can be understood alone. The resurrection tells us what the cross was, that it was not the defeat it appeared to be but the victory it secretly was, that the powers who thought they had destroyed the Son of God had in fact been destroyed

by him, that the death that looked like the end was the death of death itself. And the cross tells us what the resurrection is, that it is not merely the resuscitation of a corpse but the vindication of a death, the Father's amen to the Son's obedience, the declaration that the way of the cross is the way of life, that self-giving love unto death is not folly but the very power of God. Take them apart and you get either a tragic cross with no hope or a triumphant resurrection with no cost, and both are distortions. Held together, they are the gospel.

This is why the theology of glory is so eager to rush past the cross to the resurrection, and why we must resist it. The theology of glory loves the resurrection because it looks like power, like victory, like the God who wins, and it hurries past the cross because the cross looks like weakness and defeat. But a resurrection torn loose from the cross becomes exactly the triumphalism Luther warned against, a Christianity of power and success and winning that has forgotten the way of the cross entirely. The risen Christ still bears the wounds. When he appears to his disciples after the resurrection, he shows them his hands and his side, the marks of the nails and the spear, the cross carried into the resurrection, the wounds not erased but glorified. The risen Lord is the crucified Lord, forever marked by his death, and any resurrection that leaves the wounds behind is not the resurrection of Jesus but the fantasy of a glory that skipped the cross.

I have preached too many triumphant Easters that skipped the cross, and I feel the rebuke of my own argument. In my eagerness to give people hope, to send them out of the sanctuary rejoicing, I have sometimes rushed past the death to the victory, offered the resurrection without the cross, a cheap Easter that had not passed through a real Good Friday. And a cheap Easter, like cheap grace, saves no one, because it

offers a victory that cost nothing over an enemy that was never real. The Easter that saves is the one that has passed all the way through the cross, that has sat in the dark of Friday and the silence of Saturday and only then arrived at the dawn, that preaches a risen Lord who still bears the wounds. I want to preach that Easter, and to do it I have to preach the cross first, fully, without hurrying, which is what this whole book has tried to do.

*The risen Christ still bears the wounds.
Any resurrection that leaves the cross
behind is not his rising but our fantasy
of a glory that skipped the grave.*

SO I HAVE KEPT this book on the cross not because the resurrection does not matter but because it matters too much to be reached cheaply, by skipping the death that gives it meaning. The cross and the resurrection are one event with two moments, the death and the vindication of the death, and to have either without the other is to have neither. The resurrection needs the cross to be more than a magic trick, and the cross needs the resurrection to be more than a tragedy. Together they are the hinge of history, the death of God and the defeat of death, and the risen Lord who meets us bears forever the marks of the cross, so that even in glory the scandal remains, the wounds remain, the crucified God remains crucified even as he reigns. We do not leave the cross behind on the way to the resurrection. We carry it with us, as he did, into the life that death can no longer touch.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Fatherless and the Father Who Died

I HAVE MENTIONED MORE than once in these pages that I was raised without a father, and I have circled the fact without landing on it, because it is the hardest thing I have to write about and the thing most bound up with why the cross reached me when nothing else could. I want to land on it now, not for the sake of my own story, but because there is a whole population of the fatherless in the world, and the cross speaks to them, to us, in a way I have found in no other place, and I would be withholding something if I did not say it plainly.

The child raised without a father learns a lesson early, below the level of words, and the lesson is a lie, but it installs itself as truth. The lesson is that you were not worth staying for. It does not matter how many times a mother says otherwise, does not matter what explanations are offered about the father's failures or absence or death. The child's heart draws its own conclusion, and the conclusion is a verdict on the self. If I had been enough, he would have

stayed. Something in me was insufficient, defective, unworthy of a father's presence, and that defect is still there, still visible, still the reason I will be left again. This is not a thought the fatherless child articulates. It is a foundation the fatherless child builds a whole life upon, a foundation of shame and abandonment and the certainty of being not enough, and it shapes everything that gets built on top of it.

I built an atheism on top of it, though I did not understand at the time that this was what I was doing. A God who was Father was, to me, either a cruel joke or an obvious wish, and I could not tell which I found more offensive. If there was a Father God, then he was, like my earthly father, absent, and the absence was the same verdict written cosmic-sized, the whole universe declaring that I was not worth showing up for. And if there was no Father God, then the longing for one was just a childish wish projected onto the empty sky, the fatherless boy inventing a Father in heaven to compensate for the one he lacked on earth. Either way, the fatherhood of God was a wound, and I kept my distance from it, and told myself my distance was intellectual when it was, at the root, the self-protection of a boy who had learned not to expect a father to stay.

And then I met the cross, and the cross did something to this wound that I am still learning to describe. Because the cross is the place where the Father did not stay away. The cross is the place where the Father gave his own Son, entered into the deepest suffering, refused the distance, came all the way down. The God of the cross is not the absent father writ large. He is the opposite, the Father who would not remain at a safe remove, who gave everything, who came into the abandonment himself. And there is more, because on the cross the Son himself cries the cry of the abandoned, my God,

my God, why have you forsaken me, so that even the experience of fatherlessness, even the sense of being abandoned by the Father, has been taken up into God, has become part of God's own experience. The fatherless child's deepest wound, the sense of being forsaken, is a wound God himself has borne, on the cross, in the Son's cry of dereliction.

This did not heal me instantly, and I will not pretend it did. The lie installed in a fatherless childhood does not lift in a moment. But the cross gave me something the lie could not survive in the presence of, over time, which was the discovery that the verdict I had lived under was false. I was not, after all, not worth staying for. I was worth the death of God. The Father who I had assumed found me insufficient had, in fact, given his own Son for me, had come all the way into my abandonment, had cried my cry from the cross. The verdict of the fatherless child, that I was not enough, that the defect in me was the reason I was left, that verdict was answered at Golgotha by a Father who gave everything and a Son who bore my forsakenness, and slowly, over years, the false foundation began to be replaced by a true one. I was left, once, by a man. But I was not abandoned by God. God came for me, at the cost of his Son, into the very abandonment I had built my life around.

I have five sons now, and I understand that the deepest thing I am trying to do as their father is to not repeat the absence, to stay, to be present, to give them the earthly father I did not have. But I have also come to understand that even my staying is not enough, that no earthly father, however present, can finally answer the wound of the human heart, because even the best fathers fail and die and cannot be everywhere their children need them. The deepest thing I can give my sons is not my presence, precious as it is, but the

cross, the knowledge that there is a Father who will never leave them, who gave his Son for them, who came all the way into every abandonment they will ever feel and cried their cry before them. I want to be a good father to them. But more than that, I want them to know the Father who died for them, because he is the only Father who can finally heal what an absent father breaks, and I know this because he healed it in me.

*The fatherless child learns a lie, that he
was not worth staying for. The cross
answers it with a Father who gave his
Son and a Son who cried the cry of the
forsaken. You were worth the death of
God.*

SO TO EVERYONE WHO carries the particular wound of the fatherless, the abandonment that becomes a verdict on the self, I want to say what I most needed someone to say to me. The verdict is a lie, and the cross is the proof. You were not left because you were not enough. You were worth, to God, the death of his own Son. And the God who comes to you is not the absent father made cosmic but his opposite, the Father who would not stay away, who gave everything, who entered your abandonment and bore it in the cry of the Son on the cross. The absence you knew was real, and its wound was real, and I will not minimize it. But it was not the last word about you. The last word about you was spoken at Golgotha,

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

by a Father who ran the whole distance of the cross to reach you, and it is not the word you feared. It is the word you most needed. You are worth everything to me, and I will never leave you, and to prove it, I gave my Son.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The Cross and the Enemy

JESUS SAID SOMETHING FROM the cross that is either the most beautiful sentence ever spoken or a moral impossibility, and I have come to believe it is both, which is precisely why it is the deepest thing the cross has to teach us about how to live. He looked at the men who were killing him, the soldiers driving the nails, the crowd jeering, the leaders congratulating themselves on a job well done, and he said, Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do. Forgiveness of the enemy, offered in the very act of the enemy's crime, from the mouth of the victim, with the nails still going in. This is the ethic of the cross, and it is an ethic the world has never been able to receive, and neither, if I am honest, have I.

Let me first grant how impossible this seems, because the church has often preached it glibly, as though forgiveness of enemies were an easy virtue rather than the hardest thing a human being can do. It is not easy. It cuts against everything in us. Every instinct of justice, every reflex of self-protection,

every natural movement of the wounded heart cries out for the enemy to pay, to suffer, to be answered in kind. And there is something in this that is not merely sin, something that touches a real love of justice, a real refusal to treat evil as though it did not matter. The demand that the enemy pay is not simply vindictiveness. It is, in part, the voice of justice itself, insisting that wrong be answered, that the wound not be waved away as if it were nothing. So the forgiveness of enemies cannot mean a shrug, a pretense that the evil did not matter, a cheap peace that betrays justice. That would be its own kind of moral failure.

And here is where the cross does something no mere ethical command could do. The forgiveness of enemies from the cross is not a shrug at evil, because the cross is the place where evil is taken with total seriousness, where the wrong is not waved away but borne, absorbed, paid for. Jesus can forgive the men killing him not because their crime does not matter but because he is, in that very moment, bearing the cost of it, taking it into himself, paying what justice demands rather than exacting it from them. The forgiveness of the cross is not costless forgiveness, the cheap forgiveness that betrays justice by pretending the wrong away. It is costly forgiveness, forgiveness that absorbs the full cost of the wrong into the one who forgives, so that justice is satisfied not by the enemy's suffering but by the victim's. This is why only the cross makes the forgiveness of enemies possible. Apart from the cross, forgiveness either betrays justice by ignoring the wrong or abandons mercy by demanding payment. At the cross, justice and mercy meet, the wrong is fully paid and the enemy is fully forgiven, because the payment is borne by the one who forgives.

This transforms the ethic from an impossible command

into a participation. Jesus does not simply command us to forgive our enemies while remaining outside the difficulty of it. He forgives his enemies from the cross, bearing the cost himself, and then invites us into the same pattern, to forgive as we have been forgiven, to absorb the wrong rather than pass it on, to break the cycle of retaliation as he broke it. And crucially, he gives us the resource to do it, because the forgiveness we extend to our enemies flows from the forgiveness we have received, from our knowledge that we too were enemies, that we too were forgiven at infinite cost, that the God we wronged bore our wrong rather than exacting it from us. Paul says that while we were enemies we were reconciled to God by the death of his Son. We forgive our enemies out of the astonished recognition that we were the enemies, and were forgiven.

I have to confess that this is the ethic of the cross I have most consistently failed. I can affirm the doctrines of the atonement, can preach the theology of the cross against the theology of glory, and then go home and nurse a grudge against someone who wronged me, rehearsing the injury, keeping the ledger, wanting them to pay. The forgiveness of enemies is not an abstraction to me but a daily failure, a place where the cross rebukes my actual life most sharply. It is easier to have a correct theology of forgiveness than to forgive. And every time I refuse to forgive, I am declaring, in effect, that the cross was not enough, that I require my own additional payment beyond the one Christ made, that I will exact from my enemy what Christ has already borne. The unforgiving Christian is a walking contradiction, forgiven everything and forgiving nothing, and I have been that contradiction more often than I want to admit.

The forgiveness of enemies is also, I want to say clearly,

not the same as the toleration of injustice or the denial of consequences. Christ forgave his executioners while the injustice of his execution remained a real injustice, one that God would vindicate in the resurrection. Forgiveness does not mean pretending the wrong was right, does not mean the abused must return to the abuser, does not mean justice in the courts or the world should be abandoned. It means the refusal of personal vengeance, the release of the enemy from the debt of our own hatred, the breaking of the cycle of retaliation in our own hearts, even as we may still seek justice through proper means and protect ourselves and others from further harm. Forgiveness and justice are not opposites. The cross holds them together, absorbing the cost while vindicating the right, and our forgiveness of enemies must hold them together too, releasing our vengeance without pretending the wrong was not wrong.

*Forgiveness of the enemy is not a shrug
at evil. It is the costliest thing there is,
the absorption of the wrong into the
one who forgives, and only the cross
makes it possible.*

SO THE FORGIVENESS OF enemies, spoken from the cross with the nails still going in, is the ethic that flows from the atonement and is impossible without it. It is not a command to shrug at evil, which would betray justice, nor a demand that the enemy pay, which would abandon mercy, but the

costly forgiveness that absorbs the wrong and releases the wrongdoer, the pattern of the cross stamped onto the life of everyone who has been forgiven by it. We forgive because we were forgiven, we release because we were released, we absorb the wrong because the wrong we did was absorbed by God rather than exacted from us. And every time we forgive an enemy, we preach the cross, we declare that the cycle of retaliation has been broken, that there is a way to answer evil other than returning it, that the crucified God who forgave his killers has planted his own forgiveness in us. It is the hardest thing he asks, and it is the surest sign that the cross has actually reached us, because a forgiven person who cannot forgive has not yet understood what happened to them at Golgotha.

CHAPTER THIRTY

The Cross and the Poor

THERE IS A PATTERN in the whole biblical story, and it comes to its sharpest point at the cross, and it is this. God consistently identifies himself not with the powerful but with the lowly, not with the winners but with the losers, not with the strong but with the weak and the poor and the despised. And the cross is the ultimate expression of this pattern, God himself taking the place of the lowest of the low, dying the death reserved for slaves and rebels, identifying with the crucified of the earth so completely that he became one of them. Any account of the cross that does not reckon with this has missed something the Scriptures will not let us miss, that the crucified God is the God of the crucified, and that where the powerful see only failure the poor have often seen their own vindication.

Consider who Jesus was and where he came from and how he died. He was born to poor parents in an occupied land, a member of a despised people under the boot of an empire. He had, he said, nowhere to lay his head, no wealth, no property, no standing among the powerful. He spent his ministry among the poor, the sick, the outcast, the sinners the respectable would not touch. And he died the death of the

lowest, crucified, a punishment Rome reserved for those it considered subhuman, slaves and insurrectionists, the death designed to strip away every shred of dignity and status. God did not come as a king in a palace. He came as a poor man in an occupied province and died the death of a slave. This is not incidental to the meaning of the cross. It is central to it. The crucified God chose the place of the lowest, and in doing so he declared, once and for all, whose side he is on.

This has enormous consequences that the comfortable church has often preferred not to draw. If God identifies himself with the crucified of the earth, with the poor and the oppressed and the despised, then the church that claims his name cannot align itself comfortably with the powerful, cannot baptize the interests of the winners, cannot look at the poor and the suffering as problems to be managed rather than the very people among whom their Lord is found. The cross means that when we look for God in the world, we should look first not in the places of power and wealth and success, where the theology of glory expects to find him, but in the places of suffering and poverty and oppression, where the theology of the cross has always known he dwells. The God of the cross is found among the crucified, and a church that has lost sight of the poor has, to that extent, lost sight of its Lord.

I want to hold this carefully, because it can be pressed into a purely political program that reduces the cross to a slogan for one side, and I have watched that happen, watched the cross conscripted into ideologies of both left and right that use it to bless their own agendas. The cross is not the property of any political party, and it will not be reduced to a policy platform. But refusing to reduce it to politics is not the same as evacuating it of its clear meaning, and its clear

meaning includes this, that God took the side of the lowly, that he identified with the poor and the despised, that the church which forgets the poor forgets its Lord. This is not a partisan claim. It is a claim that indicts every party and every program, including the ones I am tempted to trust, because none of them has loved the poor the way the crucified God loved them, all the way to death.

The poor have often understood the cross better than the comfortable, and this should humble those of us who theologize about it from positions of security. The suffering church, the persecuted church, the church of the poor across the world and across history, has frequently grasped the meaning of the crucified God more deeply than the prosperous church of the comfortable West, because they have known suffering from the inside, because they have needed a God who suffers with them rather than a God who blesses their success. When you are crucified, you do not need a theology of glory. You need a God who was crucified too. And the poor and the suffering have found in the cross exactly that, a God who did not stay above their suffering but entered it, who was poor as they are poor, who was despised as they are despised, who died the death of the lowest as one of them. They have understood the cross as vindication, as solidarity, as the promise that the God who was crucified will raise the crucified, and in this they have often seen further than the rest of us.

I write as a comfortable American pastor, and I feel the rebuke of this chapter in my own life more than in my preaching. I have theologized about the crucified God from a position of considerable comfort, have written about the poor while living far from poverty, have preached solidarity with the suffering while arranging my own life to minimize

suffering. The cross indicts this. It asks whether a church so comfortable, so aligned with the winners, so far from the poor among whom its Lord is found, has not lost something essential, whether we can even see the crucified God clearly from the heights of our comfort, or whether we would need to come down, as he came down, to the places of suffering and poverty where he actually dwells. I do not have this fully worked out in my own life, and I distrust anyone who claims they do. But I know the cross is calling me down, toward the poor, toward the suffering, toward the crucified, because that is where my crucified Lord is to be found.

*God did not come as a king in a palace.
He came as a poor man in an occupied
province and died the death of a slave.
The crucified God is the God of the
crucified.*

SO THE CROSS REVEALS whose side God is on, and it is not the side the theology of glory expects. It is the side of the poor, the lowly, the despised, the crucified of the earth, among whom the crucified God dwells and with whom he identified all the way to death. This is not a reduction of the cross to politics, which would betray it, but it is a refusal to let the cross float free of its clear meaning, which would empty it. The God of the cross took the place of the lowest, and the church that bears his name is called to look for him there, among the suffering, not in the places of power where we

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

would rather find him. And when we lose sight of the poor, we lose sight of our Lord, because he is there, crucified among the crucified, and to find him we may have to go where he went, down, toward the places of suffering the theology of glory teaches us to avoid, where the crucified God is waiting to be found.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The Scandal to the Religious

WE HAVE SPOKEN MUCH of the cross as a scandal to the world, to the skeptic and the powerful and the sophisticated. But there is another scandal of the cross that the church has been slower to face, because it strikes closer to home, and it is this. The cross is a scandal to the religious. It offends the devout more deeply, in some ways, than it offends the unbeliever, because it declares that all our religion, all our devotion, all our moral striving, could not save us, that we needed a Savior precisely because our religion had failed, and that the most religious people of Jesus's day were the ones who crucified him. This is the scandal the church does not want to hear, and it is the one I most need to preach to myself.

Consider the sobering fact that Jesus was killed not by the irreligious but by the religious. It was not the atheists and the pagans and the sinners who crucified the Son of God. It was the devout, the observant, the theologically serious, the men who had given their lives to God and his law and his temple.

The Pharisees were not villains in their own eyes or in the eyes of their contemporaries. They were the most committed, the most careful, the most religiously earnest people in Israel, the ones who took God most seriously, who kept the law most scrupulously, who would have been horrified to be told they were the enemies of God. And they were the ones who arranged the death of God, convinced they were defending the faith, certain they were doing God's work in destroying the blasphemer. This should terrify every religious person, and it terrifies me, because it means that religious devotion is no guarantee against opposing God, that one can be the most committed believer in the room and be, at that very moment, God's enemy.

How could this happen. How could the most religious people become the murderers of God. The answer is the heart of the scandal, and it is this. Religion, at its deepest and most dangerous, is a project of self-salvation, an attempt to earn our standing with God by our devotion and our morality and our correct belief, and a God who saves by grace, apart from all our earning, is a mortal threat to that project. The religious project depends on the possibility of earning, on the ledger of our righteousness, on the security of knowing we have done what God requires. And the cross destroys all of it. The cross declares that no one earns anything, that our righteousness is filthy rags, that the most devout among us is saved on exactly the same basis as the worst sinner, by sheer unmerited grace. This is unbearable to the religious heart, because it means our devotion earns us nothing, our morality secures us nothing, our correct belief entitles us to nothing. And so the religious heart, threatened at its foundation, rises up against the grace that would save it, and in the extreme case, crucifies the God who offers it.

I know this scandal from the inside, not as a former atheist now but as a current pastor, because the religious project is not something I left behind at my conversion. It is a temptation I face every day, perhaps more now than when I was an unbeliever. The unbeliever at least knows he is not righteous. The religious man is in constant danger of believing he is, of building a private ledger of his devotion and his service and his correct doctrine, of feeling, somewhere below articulation, that God owes him something for all he has done. And this is exactly the elder brother's disease, the sin of the older son in the parable, the resentment of grace shown to the undeserving because it exposes that grace was never earned by the deserving either. The cross is a scandal to the religious because it puts the pastor and the prostitute on the same footing, saved by the same grace, and the religious heart cannot bear the leveling.

This is why the cross must be preached to the church as much as to the world, and why a church can hear the cross for years and never actually receive it. It is possible to be a lifelong Christian, devout and moral and orthodox, and to have never actually come to the cross, because coming to the cross requires the abandonment of the religious project, the confession that all our devotion could not save us, the acceptance of a grace that levels us with the worst sinner and makes our righteousness irrelevant. Many religious people never do this. They use their Christianity as the vehicle of their self-salvation, their devotion as the ledger of their earning, their correct belief as the ground of their superiority, and they never come to the cross at all, because the cross would destroy the very thing they are using Christianity to build. The cross is a scandal to the religious, and many of the religious never get past it, though they sit in pews their whole

lives.

The application to my own tribe, the theologically serious, the doctrinally careful, is sharp and I do not exempt myself. We who take God most seriously are in the greatest danger of the Pharisee's sin, of using our seriousness as a ground of superiority, of building a ledger of our right belief, of becoming the elder brother who resents grace shown to the careless and the wrong. The cross rebukes our seriousness at its root, tells us that our careful theology saves us no more than the sinner's ignorance damns him, that we are all at the foot of the cross on exactly the same terms, empty-handed, saved by grace alone. And the mark of whether we have actually received this is not our devotion, which the Pharisees had in abundance, but our response to grace shown to the undeserving. If it delights us, we have understood the cross. If it offends us, we are still the elder brother, still the Pharisee, still religious people who have not yet come to the cross that would save us from our religion.

*Jesus was killed not by the irreligious
but by the devout, who were certain
they were defending God. Religious
devotion is no guarantee against being
God's enemy. It is often the disguise.*

SO THE CROSS IS a scandal to the religious, and this is the scandal the church most needs to hear and most resists hearing. It declares that our religion could not save us, that

the most devout among us needed grace as desperately as the worst sinner, that the ledger of our earning is worthless, that we are all saved, if we are saved at all, by sheer unmerited mercy that levels every distinction we were counting on. The religious heart rises against this, because it destroys the project of self-salvation that religion so easily becomes. And the mark of a Christian who has actually come to the cross, as opposed to one who has merely used Christianity to build a righteousness of their own, is joy at the grace shown to the undeserving, because they know they are the undeserving, saved by the same grace, at the same cross, on the same terms as the thief and the prostitute and the prodigal. The cross saves us from the world, yes. But first it must save us from our religion, and that is a harder salvation, because it is the one we least think we need.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

The Weight of Glory Hidden in the Weight of the Cross

I HAVE SPENT THIS whole book insisting that we must not rush past the cross to the glory, must not skip Good Friday for Easter, must not trade the theology of the cross for the theology of glory. But now I want to say something that might seem to reverse all of that, and does not, but completes it. There is a glory in the cross, a weight of glory hidden within the weight of the suffering, and to miss it is to miss the deepest thing of all. The cross is not merely a defeat that the resurrection reverses. It is itself, in a hidden way, the hour of glory, the moment of God's deepest self-revelation, the place where the divine glory shines most brightly precisely because it shines in darkness.

This is not my invention. It is the strange and consistent testimony of John's Gospel, which speaks of the cross in a way the other Gospels do not, calling it the hour of Jesus's glorification. When Jesus anticipates his death, he says the

hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified, and he means the cross. He speaks of being lifted up, and the lifting up is the crucifixion, and yet he speaks of it as exaltation, as glory, as the moment toward which his whole life has moved. In John, the cross is not merely the low point before the high point of the resurrection. The cross is itself the height, the throne, the glory, the place where the King is enthroned in the act of dying. This is a paradox so deep that we have largely failed to receive it, preferring the simpler story in which the cross is the defeat and the resurrection is the victory. But John insists on something stranger, that the cross itself is the victory, the glory, the enthronement, hidden under the appearance of its opposite.

How can the cross be glory. It can be glory because glory, in the biblical sense, is the manifestation of who God truly is, and nowhere is God more truly revealed than at the cross. We think of glory as splendor, as radiance, as overwhelming majesty, and God has that glory too. But the deepest glory of God, the glory that reveals his very heart, is not the glory of power but the glory of love, and the love of God is most fully revealed not in the creation of galaxies or the splendor of the heavens but in the death of the Son for his enemies. At the cross, we see God as he most truly is, not as we imagined him, not as power and majesty and untouchable splendor, but as self-giving love unto death, love that would rather die than abandon the beloved, love that pours itself out to the last drop. That is the glory of God, the real glory, the glory hidden in the weight of the cross, and it is a glory the theology of glory can never see, because it is looking for splendor and God has revealed himself in a wound.

This is why the cross exposes and reverses every false idea of glory, even as it is itself the deepest glory. The theology of

glory seeks God in power, in splendor, in success, in the ways the world calls glorious, and it cannot find him there, because he has revealed his deepest glory in the place the world calls shameful. The theology of the cross finds God in the cross, in the weakness and the suffering and the shame, and precisely there it discovers a glory greater than any splendor, the glory of a love that goes all the way down. So the theology of the cross does not deny glory. It relocates it. It finds the true glory in the very place the theology of glory refused to look, and it discovers that the weight of the cross was, all along, the weight of glory, the fullest revelation of who God is, shining most brightly in the deepest dark.

I have preached the cross as defeat and the resurrection as glory, and I have not been wrong exactly, but I have missed something, and this chapter is my attempt to recover it. Because if the cross is only defeat, then the way of the cross, the cross-shaped life I am called to, is only a losing that will be reversed later, a suffering to be endured on the way to a glory that lies elsewhere. But if the cross is itself glory, then the way of the cross is itself glorious, not merely a defeat to be reversed but a participation in the deepest glory there is, the glory of self-giving love. This changes how I understand the whole Christian life. The cross-shaped life is not merely a temporary suffering redeemed by a future glory. It is the present manifestation of the glory of God in us, the shining of the divine love through our own self-giving, the weight of glory carried in the weight of the cross we take up. To lose our lives for Christ is not merely to endure a loss that heaven will repay. It is to participate, now, in the very glory of God, the glory that is love poured out.

C.S. Lewis wrote an essay he called *The Weight of Glory*, and though he was speaking of the glory that awaits us, the

phrase captures something true about the cross itself, that there is a weight of glory hidden in the weight of the suffering, a splendor concealed in the shame, a divine radiance shining precisely in the darkness of Golgotha. The soldiers saw a dying criminal. The crowd saw a failed messiah. The disciples saw the end of their hopes. And all of them were looking at the most glorious event in the history of the universe, the fullest revelation of the glory of God, the enthronement of the King, hidden under the appearance of its opposite, visible only to the eyes of faith. That is the final scandal of the cross, that its glory is real but hidden, that its splendor is genuine but concealed, that the weight of glory is carried in the weight of the wood, and only faith can see it.

The soldiers saw a dying criminal. The crowd saw a failed messiah. They were all looking at the most glorious event in the history of the universe, hidden under the appearance of its opposite.

SO THERE IS A glory in the cross, the deepest glory of all, and to miss it is to miss the heart of the matter. The cross is not only a defeat reversed by the resurrection but is itself, in a hidden way, the hour of glory, the fullest revelation of the God who is love, the enthronement of the King in the act of dying for his enemies. And this glory transforms the whole Christian life, because the way of the cross we are called to walk is not merely a suffering to be endured until glory comes

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

elsewhere but a participation, now, in the very glory of God, the shining of divine love through our own self-giving. The weight of the cross is the weight of glory, and the eyes of faith learn to see, in the darkest place in the world, the brightest light there is, the glory of the crucified God, shining not despite the darkness but in it, and through it, and precisely there.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

The Objections of the Honest Skeptic

I PROMISED AT THE start that I would not soften the offense of the cross to keep the skeptic reading, and I want to make good on that promise by facing, near the end of this book, the strongest objections an honest unbeliever might raise, the objections I raised myself for years, and by answering them not with cleverness but with the same honesty I would want if I were still on the other side. Because the skeptic is often the most honest person in the room, having refused the easy answers the church kept offering, and the skeptic deserves not to be handled but to be met.

The first objection is the one I have already touched, the problem of suffering, and I will not pretend the cross solves it as a philosophical matter, because it does not, and to claim otherwise would be exactly the kind of dishonesty that drives thoughtful people away. The honest skeptic looks at the suffering of the world and finds it impossible to square with a good and powerful God, and this is not a stupid objection but the strongest one there is. My only answer, and I offer it not as

a proof but as a testimony, is that the cross does not explain suffering but changes the God we are objecting to, replacing the aloof deity whose distance is the offense with a crucified God who entered the suffering himself. You may still not believe it. But you cannot say it is the god of the comfortable, the god who stays safely above the pain. The Christian God went to the bottom of the pain and died there, and that is not the god the problem of suffering was designed to refute.

The second objection is the moral one, the charge that the cross is a barbaric idea, that a God who requires blood, who saves through violence, who deals with sin by killing his Son, is a moral monster unworthy of worship. I have tried to answer this throughout, by showing that the cross is not God demanding blood but God giving himself, not the Father punishing the Son but the triune God bearing the cost in his own person, not the sacralizing of violence but its exposure and absorption. But I want to add here, to the honest skeptic, that if this objection moves you, it is because you have a moral sense that recoils at violence and injustice, and that moral sense is itself a thing that needs explaining, and the Christian account explains it better than the alternatives. The very outrage you feel at the idea of an innocent suffering is an outrage the cross shares, because the cross is God taking the side of the innocent sufferer by becoming one, exposing the violence, refusing to return it. Your moral objection to the cross is, strangely, an objection the cross agrees with, and answers, by being the one place violence was met with a love that would not answer in kind.

The third objection is the historical one, the doubt that any of this happened, that a first-century Palestinian preacher was God, that he rose from the dead, that we can know anything reliable about events so distant and so encrusted

with legend. This is a serious objection and I will not wave it away, but I will say two things. First, the offense of the cross is itself a kind of historical evidence, as I argued early in this book, because no one inventing a religion invents a crucified God, and the early Christians preached exactly the thing that made them ridiculous, which is not the behavior of people making things up. Second, the resurrection, whatever you conclude about it, is not a legend that grew slowly over centuries but a claim made within the lifetime of the witnesses, by people who died for it, about a tomb that was empty and could have been checked. You may conclude they were deceived or deceiving. But the claim is early, and costly, and specific, and it is not the vague myth that the objection assumes. The honest skeptic should at least grapple with the actual evidence rather than the caricature.

I do not expect these answers to convince the determined unbeliever, and I do not offer them as knockdown arguments, because I do not think the cross is finally received through argument. It was not argument that moved me from the mocking thief to the believing one. It was something stranger, an encounter with a God who would not stay above the suffering, who came down into the worst of it, who died rather than abandon me, and who met me in the very place of my abandonment and my guilt and my shame. The arguments cleared away some obstacles, made it possible to consider, removed the excuse that believing was simply stupid. But the actual crossing was not an argument. It was a person, the crucified God, who reached me where I was and would not let me go. And that I cannot prove to you, though I can testify to it.

Here is what I would want to hear if I were still the skeptic, and so it is what I will say. I do not ask you to find the cross

easy. I ask you to find it worthy of your consideration, worthy of your grappling, worthy of your honest attention rather than your dismissal. The cross is not the comfortable fiction you may assume it to be, the wish-fulfillment of frightened people who wanted an easy god. It is the hardest thing any religion has ever asked its adherents to believe, a crucified God, folly to the wise and a scandal to the devout, and its adherents preached it precisely because they could not deny it, whatever it cost them. You may conclude it is false. But do not conclude it is stupid, or comfortable, or beneath your intelligence, because it is none of those things. It is the deepest and strangest claim ever made, that the maker of the galaxies died on a Roman cross for the people who killed him, and if it is true, nothing is the same.

*I do not ask you to find the cross easy. I
ask you to find it worthy of your honest
grappling, because it is not the
comfortable fiction you assume. It is
the hardest thing anyone was ever
asked to believe.*

SO TO THE HONEST skeptic I say, the cross does not solve the problem of suffering but it changes the God you are objecting to. It is not the barbarism you fear but the exposure and absorption of the very violence you rightly hate. And it is not the vague legend the objection assumes but an early, costly, specific claim that deserves your grappling. I do not

expect to argue you into the kingdom, because I was not argued into it, and I distrust conversions that rest on argument alone. But I do ask you to give the cross the honest attention you give to any serious claim, to refuse the easy dismissal, to consider that the thing you may have written off as beneath you is in fact the deepest thing ever said. The win, for me, is not that you agree. The win is that you can no longer accuse the cross of being stupid, or comfortable, or a lie people told themselves to feel better. It is none of those things. It is a scandal, and a folly, and it may just be the power and the wisdom of God.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

The Silence of Saturday

BETWEEN THE DEATH OF God on Friday and the rising of God on Sunday there is a day the church has almost forgotten, and it is the most honest day in the Christian calendar. Holy Saturday. The day when God was dead and buried and had not yet risen, when the disciples sat in the wreckage of everything they had hoped, when the tomb was sealed and the stone was in place and nothing had happened yet and there was no reason to think anything would. We rush from Friday to Sunday, from the cross to the empty tomb, and in our haste we skip the day that most of us actually live in, the day of waiting, of silence, of a God who seems absent and a hope that has not yet been vindicated.

I want to sit in Saturday for a chapter, because I think it is where most of the Christian life is actually lived, and because the church that only knows Friday and Sunday has nothing to say to the people stuck in Saturday, which is nearly everyone. Think about what Saturday was for the disciples. They did not know Sunday was coming. We know, and so we cannot fully feel Saturday, because we read it already knowing the ending. But they did not know the ending. For them, Saturday was simply the day after their Lord had died, the day when the

hope was dead and buried with him, when everything they had left their homes and their livelihoods to follow had ended on a Roman cross, when God, if there was a God, had let his Messiah be killed and had done nothing. Saturday was despair. It was the silence of a God who seemed to have abandoned the whole project. And they had no promise that the silence would break.

This is where so many people actually live, and the church's rush from Friday to Sunday leaves them unaddressed. There is the person whose prayers have gone unanswered for years, who cries out and hears nothing, who lives in the silence of a God who seems absent. There is the person in the long middle of a grief that will not lift, past the acute agony of Friday but nowhere near the dawn of Sunday, stuck in the gray waiting of Saturday. There is the person whose faith has died, who once believed and now sits in the tomb of their lost certainty, unable to go back to Friday's living faith and unable to reach Sunday's resurrection, marooned in the silence between. To all of these, a Christianity that only preaches Friday's cross and Sunday's triumph has nothing to say, because they are living in the day the church skips, the day of waiting, of silence, of a hope that has not yet come and may, for all they can tell, never come.

The gift of Holy Saturday is that it is in the Bible, that the church has always kept it, that God himself passed through it. There is a whole day in the gospel story when God is dead and buried and nothing is happening, and this day is not an embarrassment to be rushed past but a truth to be received, the truth that the life of faith includes the silence, the waiting, the seeming absence of God. The disciples were not faithless for despairing on Saturday. They were living in the reality of Saturday, which was a real death and a real silence and a real

absence of any evidence that hope was warranted. And God did not rebuke them for it. He met them, on Sunday, in the middle of their despair, before they had worked up any faith, appearing to men and women who had given up hope, whose Saturday despair he did not scold but simply ended. Saturday is not a failure of faith. It is a station of the Christian life, and God has been there.

There is something even deeper in the descent into hell we considered earlier, which the church has connected precisely to Holy Saturday. On that silent day, the old traditions say, Christ was not merely inert in the tomb but was at work in the depths, descending to the dead, present in the very place of absence, laboring in the silence. Whatever we make of the imagery, it names a hope for those stuck in Saturday, that God is not absent from the silent day but present in it, working in the dark, laboring in the depths where nothing seems to be happening. The silence of Saturday is not the silence of a God who is not there. It is the silence of a God who is at work in a way we cannot see, in the depths, in the dark, in the tomb, preparing a Sunday that has not yet dawned and that we have no evidence to expect. The waiting is not empty. God is in it, working, even when the silence tells us he is not.

I have lived in Saturday, in seasons of silence and waiting and the apparent absence of God, and I confess that the church's rush to Sunday has sometimes made those seasons lonelier, because the triumphant Christianity around me seemed to have no place for a faith that was waiting in the dark. I felt I was failing, that a stronger believer would already be at Sunday, that my Saturday silence was a defect to be ashamed of. And it was the recovery of Holy Saturday that helped me, the discovery that the silence is in the Bible, that God passed through it, that the disciples lived it, that the day

of waiting is a real station of faith and not a failure of it. If you are in Saturday now, in the silence and the waiting and the seeming absence, I do not have a Sunday to hand you on command, because Sunday comes in God's time and not on our schedule. But I have Saturday to give you, the assurance that the silent day is a real day, that God has been in it, that the waiting is not the absence of faith but a form of it, and that Sunday, when it comes, will come as it came the first time, to people who had given up hope, in the middle of their despair, unearned and unexpected and breaking the silence at last.

*Most of us do not live in Friday's agony
or Sunday's triumph. We live in
Saturday, in the silence, in the
waiting, in the tomb between the death
and the dawn. God has been there too.*

SO LET US NOT skip Saturday, the day the church forgets and the day most of us live in. The silence between the cross and the resurrection is a real part of the story, a day when God was dead and buried and nothing was happening and there was no evidence that anything would. It is the day of the waiting, of the unanswered prayer, of the grief that will not lift, of the faith that has died and not yet risen. And the gift of Holy Saturday is that God passed through it, that the silence is in the Bible, that the disciples' despair was not rebuked but met, that Sunday came to people who had stopped expecting it. If you are in Saturday, you are not failing. You are in the

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

day God himself passed through, waiting in a silence he has already inhabited, and the dawn will come as it always comes, not because you earned it by your faith but because the God who was dead and buried did not stay that way, and neither, in the end, will your hope.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

The Cross Written on the Body

BAPTISM IS THE MOST physical thing the church does, and it is a preaching of the cross written onto the body of the believer, and we have often reduced it to a formality, a rite of passage, a symbol emptied of its weight. But Paul understood baptism as nothing less than a death and a resurrection, a being buried with Christ and raised with him, the cross and the empty tomb enacted on the body of every person who is plunged beneath the water and lifted out again. And I want to recover this, because the church that has lost the meaning of baptism has lost one of the ways the cross is meant to be made real in the life of every believer, not as a doctrine affirmed but as a death died and a life received.

Consider what Paul says, that we were buried with Christ by baptism into death, so that as Christ was raised from the dead, we too might walk in newness of life. Baptism is not primarily a symbol of cleansing, though it is that. It is a burial. It is a going down into the water as into a grave, a joining of ourselves to the death of Christ, a real participation

in his cross. And it is a rising, a coming up out of the water as out of a tomb, a joining of ourselves to his resurrection, a real participation in his new life. The old self, Paul says, was crucified with him. The person who goes down into the water is put to death there, joined to the cross, and the person who comes up is a new creation, joined to the resurrection. Baptism is the cross and the empty tomb written onto the body, the whole gospel enacted in water, the death and the life made physical and personal.

This means that the cross is not merely something that happened to Jesus two thousand years ago, an event I look back on and affirm. In baptism, the cross becomes something that happened to me, a death I died, a grave I entered, a tomb I was buried in. Paul says our old self was crucified with him. Not merely that Christ was crucified for me, though that is true, but that I was crucified with Christ, that in baptism I was joined to his death so completely that his death became my death, his cross my cross, his grave my grave. This is the deepest personal meaning of the cross, that it is not only something done for me but something done to me, that I have died, that the old self I was has been crucified and buried, that I am now living a new life that is not my own but Christ's living in me. I have been crucified with Christ, Paul says, and it is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me.

The practical consequence of this is enormous and largely unrealized in the way most Christians live. If I have died with Christ, if my old self has been crucified and buried, then I am free from the old self's tyranny, free from the compulsions and fears and identities that ruled the person I was, because that person is dead, crucified with Christ, buried in the waters of baptism. The old self does not have to be managed, improved, or negotiated with. It has been put to death. And I

am now free to live the new life, the resurrection life, the life of Christ in me, no longer bound to the dead self I was. This is why Paul can say we should consider ourselves dead to sin and alive to God. Not that sin has no more pull, but that its ultimate claim on us has been broken, because we have died, and a dead person is beyond the reach of sin's tyranny. The cross written on the body in baptism is the death of the old self and the freedom of the new.

I want to name where I have failed to live this, because I have often lived as though my old self were still alive and in charge, still the one I had to manage and appease and negotiate with, rather than as one who has died with Christ and been raised to a new life. I have treated my baptism as a past event, a thing that happened to me once, rather than as the ongoing truth of my existence, the death I died and the life I now live. And in doing so I have forfeited the freedom the cross written on my body was meant to give me, the freedom of one who has already died and therefore has nothing left to lose, the freedom of one whose old self is crucified and whose new self is hidden with Christ in God. The cross on the body is meant to be lived, daily, as the reality of who I now am, one who has died and been raised, and I have too often left it as a doctrine on a shelf rather than the death and life it actually is.

There is a further gift here for the person crushed by their own past, their own failures, their own sense of being unchangeably the person they have always been. Baptism says that person is dead. The old self, with all its failures and shame and bondage, has been crucified with Christ and buried in the water. You are not condemned to be forever the person you were, because that person has died, and you have been raised a new creation. This is not positive thinking or

self-improvement. It is a death and a resurrection, a real ending of the old and a real beginning of the new, written onto your body in the waters of baptism, sealed by the cross of Christ. The person you were is dead. The person you are is alive with the life of Christ. That is what the cross written on the body means, and it is good news for everyone who has despaired of ever being anything other than what they have always been.

*Baptism is a burial. You go down into
the water as into a grave and come up
as out of a tomb. The old self is not
improved. It is crucified, and a new self
is raised.*

SO THE CROSS IS written on the body in baptism, the death and the resurrection enacted in water, the whole gospel made physical and personal in the life of every believer. It means that the cross is not only something done for me but something done to me, a death I have died, a grave I have entered, a new life I have received. And it means I am free, free from the tyranny of the old self that has been crucified and buried, free to live the resurrection life of Christ in me, free from the condemnation of a past that has been put to death. The cross written on the body is not a formality or an empty rite. It is the death of the old and the birth of the new, the deepest personal reality of the Christian, who can say with Paul, I have been crucified with Christ, and the life I now

THE CROSS WRITTEN ON THE BODY

live I live by faith in the Son of God who loved me and gave himself for me.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

The Cross and the End of Religion as Performance

THERE IS A PHRASE we throw around, that Christianity is not a religion but a relationship, and like most slogans it is half true and half misleading, but there is something real underneath it that the cross makes clear, and it is this. The cross is the end of religion understood as performance, as the human effort to reach God, to earn his favor, to climb our way up to the divine by our devotion and our morality and our striving. Every religion in the world, at its natural level, is a system of ascent, a ladder we climb toward God, and the cross is the demolition of every ladder, because at the cross God descends to us, and the whole direction of religion is reversed.

Let me describe the ladder, because we are all on it by nature, whether we are religious in the formal sense or not. The ladder is the assumption that we reach God, or goodness, or salvation, or whatever we are seeking, by climbing, by our effort, by becoming better, by doing enough, by performing

well enough to earn what we seek. Formal religion builds the ladder out of rituals and laws and devotions. Secular versions build it out of morality, achievement, self-improvement, the project of becoming a good enough person to deserve a good life. But it is the same ladder, the same assumption, that we ascend to what we seek by our performance. And the ladder is exhausting, because it never ends, because there is always another rung, because we can never be sure we have climbed high enough, because the summit recedes as we approach it and we are left forever climbing, forever performing, forever anxious that we have not yet done enough.

The cross demolishes the ladder by reversing its direction. At the cross, God does not wait at the top for us to climb to him. He descends to the bottom, comes all the way down to where we are, meets us not at the summit of our achievement but in the depths of our failure. The whole movement of the cross is descent, God coming down, emptying himself, taking the form of a servant, humbling himself to the point of death, even death on a cross. And this descent is the end of the ladder, because if God has come all the way down to us, then we do not have to climb up to him. The ladder is not needed. The performance is not required. The exhausting ascent is over, because the summit came down to the valley, because God reached us where we were rather than waiting for us to reach him. Grace is the end of the ladder, and the cross is grace made visible, the descent of God that makes our ascent unnecessary.

This is the deepest relief the cross offers, and it is a relief the performing heart can barely believe. Because we are so committed to the ladder, so certain that we must earn what we receive, so unable to imagine a gift that is truly free, that the news of the cross sounds too good to be true, sounds like

a trick, sounds like it must have a catch. Surely we must do something. Surely we must climb at least a little. Surely the gift requires some performance on our part to make us worthy of it. And the cross says no. It says the performance is over, the climbing is done, the ladder is demolished, that God has come all the way down and there is nothing left for us to do but receive what he has already done. This is the scandal of grace, that it is free, that it requires no performance, that it meets us in our failure rather than rewarding our success, and the performing heart finds it almost impossible to accept, because it destroys the whole project of earning that we have built our lives upon.

I have been a performer all my life, and the cross has been demolishing my ladder for years, and I still keep rebuilding it. I came out of atheism into faith, and I immediately began building a religious ladder, a project of Christian performance, a striving to be a good enough pastor, a devoted enough believer, a righteous enough man, to earn the favor I had supposedly received freely. The old performing heart does not die easily. It converts to religion and keeps performing, keeps climbing, keeps trying to earn what was already given, and the cross has to demolish the ladder again and again, has to keep reminding me that God came all the way down, that the performance is over, that there is nothing left to climb toward because the summit descended to meet me in the valley of my failure. I am a slow learner of grace, and I suspect I am not alone, because the ladder is the most natural thing in the human heart, and the descent of God is the most unnatural, and it takes a lifetime to believe it.

So when we say Christianity is not a religion but a relationship, this is the truth underneath the slogan, that the cross ends religion understood as the human performance of

ascent to God, and replaces it with the reception of God's descent to us. Not that there is nothing to do, because the grace we receive makes a claim on our whole lives, as we have seen. But the doing is response, not performance, gratitude, not earning, the life that flows from grace received rather than the striving that tries to earn grace not yet given. The ladder is demolished. The performance is over. God has come down. And the exhausting project of climbing our way to the divine, which has driven the religion of the human race since the beginning, is ended at the cross, where God descended all the way to the bottom to meet us in our failure and give us, freely, what we could never have climbed high enough to earn.

*Every religion is a ladder we climb
toward God. The cross is the demolition
of every ladder, because at the cross
God came all the way down, and the
climbing is over.*

SO THE CROSS IS the end of religion as performance and the beginning of grace as reception. It demolishes the ladder of human ascent by the descent of God, meets us in our failure rather than rewarding our success, ends the exhausting project of earning that we have built our lives upon. And it offers the performing heart a relief it can barely believe, that the climbing is over, that there is nothing left to earn, that God has come all the way down and given us freely what no ladder could ever have reached. The performing heart resists

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

this, keeps rebuilding the ladder, keeps trying to earn the gift, because the descent of God is the most unnatural thing there is to a heart built for ascent. But the cross keeps demolishing the ladder, keeps preaching the descent, keeps offering the grace, until at last, slowly, we learn to stop climbing and start receiving, and discover that the God we were trying to reach had already reached us, at the bottom, on a cross, where the whole direction of religion was reversed forever.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

The Cross and the Marriage

I SAID AT THE beginning that I write toward people trying to live well, toward the ordinary weight of a Tuesday afternoon, and I have kept the book largely on the great themes of guilt and shame and suffering and death. But the cross reaches into the most ordinary places too, and none is more ordinary or more difficult than marriage, and I want to turn there, because the cross has more to say about how two people stay together than all the advice in all the books, and what it says is not what the advice says.

The advice about marriage, most of it, is a version of the ladder we just discussed, a performance, a technique, a set of skills to be mastered so that the marriage will work. Communicate better. Meet each other's needs. Keep the romance alive. Find your love languages. And there is nothing wrong with any of it as far as it goes, but it does not go far enough, because it treats marriage as a project of mutual satisfaction, an arrangement for meeting needs, a transaction in which each party gives in order to receive. And marriages

built on that foundation crumble, because the moment one party stops receiving what they are giving for, the transaction fails, and the whole thing was a transaction from the start. The advice cannot save a marriage because it operates on the very logic that dooms marriages, the logic of exchange, of performance, of getting what you give.

The cross offers a different foundation, and it is a hard one, and it is the only one that holds. Paul, writing to the Ephesians about marriage, reaches for the cross. Husbands, love your wives, he says, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her. The pattern for marital love is not the transaction, not the exchange of needs met, but the cross, the self-giving that holds nothing back, that loves not in order to receive but in order to give, that lays down its life for the other the way Christ laid down his life for us. This is a love that does not depend on being reciprocated, that does not keep a ledger, that does not stop giving when it stops receiving, because it is patterned not on exchange but on the cross, where God loved us while we were still his enemies, still giving him nothing, still failing him at every turn. The cross-shaped marriage is one in which each party is committed to the self-giving of the cross, whether or not it is returned in equal measure, because the model is not the transaction but Golgotha.

This is impossibly hard, and I will not pretend otherwise, and I will not pretend I have mastered it. To love another person the way Christ loved the church, to give yourself up for them, to keep giving when you are not receiving, to lay down your life for someone who is failing you, is beyond the natural capacity of any human being. It cannot be done by willpower, cannot be achieved by technique, cannot be sustained by gritted teeth. It can only be lived by people who have

themselves received the self-giving love of the cross, who have been loved by God while they were still failing him, and who love their spouse out of the overflow of the love they have received rather than out of their own depleted resources. This is why a cross-shaped marriage requires the cross, not merely as a model to imitate but as a source to draw from, because you cannot give what you have not received, and the self-giving love that marriage requires can only come from having first been loved that way by God.

There is a further depth here that the church has often gotten wrong, and I want to be careful. The call to cross-shaped love in marriage is a call to both parties, mutual and reciprocal, not a tool for the domination of one by the other. Paul's instruction to husbands to love as Christ loved the church, giving himself up for her, is the most radical demand, because it calls the one with the cultural power to lay it down, to serve, to give himself up, in an age when husbands held all the authority. It has been twisted into a justification for the subjection of wives, for the demand that women bear crosses their husbands refuse to bear, and this is a monstrous inversion of the text, which calls the husband to the cross first and most costly. The cross-shaped marriage is not one party sacrificing while the other rules. It is both parties giving themselves up for each other in mutual self-donation, patterned on the Christ who gave himself up for the church, and any use of these words to sanctify the domination of one spouse by another has betrayed the cross it claims to honor.

I have been married and I have failed at this daily, and I write as a fellow failure, not as a master. The transaction is my natural mode, the keeping of the ledger, the giving in order to receive, the withdrawal when I am not getting what I gave for. And the cross keeps calling me out of the transaction

into the self-giving, keeps reminding me that I am to love as Christ loved the church, that the ledger is to be torn up, that I am to give myself up whether or not it is returned, out of the overflow of the love I have received from the crucified God. I fail at this constantly, and the failing drives me back to the cross, back to the love I have received, back to the only source from which the self-giving marriage can be lived. My marriage is not a testimony to my success at cross-shaped love. It is a testimony to a grace that keeps calling me back to it after every failure, a cross that keeps offering me the love I need in order to love.

*Marriage advice is mostly a
transaction, giving in order to receive.
The cross offers the only foundation
that holds, a love patterned on
Golgotha, that gives itself up whether
or not it is returned.*

SO THE CROSS REACHES even into marriage, the most ordinary and most difficult of arrangements, and it offers there what all the advice cannot, a foundation that is not the transaction but the self-giving of Golgotha. The cross-shaped marriage is one in which each party loves as Christ loved the church, gives themselves up for the other, tears up the ledger, keeps giving out of the overflow of the love they have received rather than the transaction of getting what they give. It is impossibly hard, beyond natural capacity, sustainable only by

people who have been loved by the crucified God and love out of that love. And it is mutual, both parties giving themselves up for each other, never a tool for the domination of one by the other. The cross does not offer a technique for a better marriage. It offers a foundation, the only one that holds, the self-giving love of a God who gave himself up for us while we were still his enemies, and calls us to give ourselves up for each other in the same way.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

The Cross and Our Sons

I HAVE FIVE SONS, and I have mentioned them throughout this book, and I want to give them a chapter, not because my particular fatherhood matters to you, but because the raising of children is one of the most ordinary and most weighty things human beings do, and the cross has more to say about it than the parenting books, and what it says is not what they say. The parenting books are mostly about outcomes, about how to produce successful, well-adjusted, high-achieving children, and the cross cuts against the whole project of parenting for outcomes, because it teaches a different aim entirely.

Let me name the anxiety that drives most parenting, because I feel it in myself constantly. It is the anxiety of outcomes, the fear that our children will not turn out well, will not succeed, will not be happy, will not achieve, will not be safe. And this anxiety drives us to a parenting of control, of management, of optimization, in which we try to engineer our children's success, to protect them from every failure, to smooth their path, to produce the outcome we fear they will not reach on their own. It is exhausting, and it is idolatrous, because it makes the child's success into the thing we are

ultimately serving, the god we are ultimately worshiping, and it crushes both the parent, who cannot control the outcome, and the child, who cannot bear the weight of being the parent's justification. The parenting of outcomes is a ladder, the same ladder we have seen throughout this book, the human project of ascent, transferred now onto our children.

The cross cuts against this at the root, because the cross teaches that the deepest thing is not success but grace, not achievement but being loved, not the outcome but the cross-shaped life. And so the deepest thing I can give my sons is not a smoothed path to success but the knowledge that they are loved by God apart from any success, that their worth is established by the cross and not by their achievement, that there is a Father who will never leave them and who gave his Son for them. If I raise them to believe their worth is in their success, I have raised them on the ladder, and the ladder will exhaust and crush them as it exhausts and crushes everyone. If I raise them to know they are loved by the crucified God apart from all success, I have given them a foundation that no failure can shake, because it does not rest on their performance but on the cross.

This means I must be willing to let my sons fail, which is the hardest thing, and it is where the parenting of outcomes and the parenting of the cross most sharply diverge. The parenting of outcomes protects the child from failure at all costs, because failure threatens the outcome. But the parenting of the cross knows that failure is often the very place where grace is learned, where the ladder is demolished, where the child discovers that they are loved not for their success but in their failure. If I protect my sons from all failure, I protect them from the very place where they might learn the cross, where they might discover that they are loved

at the bottom and not only at the top, where the God who meets us in our failure might meet them. I do not want my sons to fail, any more than any father does. But I want them to know, when they fail, as they will, that failure is not the end, that they are loved in it, that the cross meets us precisely there, and this they can only learn if I am willing to let them fail and to love them in the failing.

There is a deeper thing still, and it touches my own history, the fatherlessness I have written about. The deepest thing I want to give my sons is not the success I fear they will lack, nor even the presence I lacked, precious as that is, but the Father who will never leave them, the crucified God who gave his Son for them and cried their cry of abandonment before them. Because I know that even my presence, even the fatherhood I am trying to give them that I did not have, is not enough, that I will fail them, that I will die, that no earthly father can be everything a child needs. The only Father who can be everything is the one who died for them, and the deepest gift I can give my sons is to point them to him, to raise them not primarily toward success or even toward my own love, but toward the love of the crucified God who will hold them when I cannot, who will be present when I am absent, who will never abandon them as I one day must.

I fail at this daily, and I write as a failing father, not a successful one. The anxiety of outcomes grips me constantly, the fear for my sons' success and safety and happiness, the temptation to parent by control and management and optimization. And the cross keeps calling me out of the anxiety into trust, out of the parenting of outcomes into the parenting of grace, reminding me that my sons' worth is not in their success but in the love of the God who died for them, that I can let them fail because grace meets us in failure, that

the deepest thing I can give them is not my own inadequate love but the love of the Father who will never leave them. I am not a good enough father to raise them perfectly, and the cross frees me from the crushing burden of trying to be, because their ultimate hope is not my adequacy but the crucified God who loves them more than I ever could.

*The deepest thing I can give my sons is
not a smoothed path to success but the
knowledge that they are loved by the
crucified God apart from all success, by
a Father who will never leave them.*

SO THE CROSS REACHES even into the raising of children, and it cuts against the parenting of outcomes at the root, replacing the anxious project of engineering our children's success with the aim of raising them to know they are loved by the crucified God apart from all success. It frees me to let my sons fail, because grace meets us in failure, and it points me past my own inadequate love to the love of the Father who will never leave them. I am a failing father, and the cross frees me from the crushing burden of trying to be a perfect one, because my sons' ultimate hope is not my adequacy but the God who died for them. And the deepest gift I can give them, deeper than success, deeper even than the presence I lacked and am trying to give, is to point them to the crucified God who loves them more than I ever could, and who will hold them, when I cannot, all the way to the end.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

The Cross and the Work That Crushes Us

MOST PEOPLE SPEND MOST of their waking lives at work, and most people find their work, at least some of the time, a source of crushing weight, of anxiety, of exhaustion, of a sense that they are giving their lives to something that gives little back. And the cross speaks to this, to the ordinary weight of vocation, of labor, of the daily grind that consumes our hours and often our spirits. It does not speak to it the way the productivity gurus speak, with techniques for optimizing our output or finding our passion, but at a deeper level, at the level of what our work is for and why it so often crushes us.

Let me name why work crushes us, because the diagnosis matters. Work crushes us, in large part, because we ask it to give us what it cannot give, which is our identity, our worth, our justification. In a world that has lost God, work has become for many people the primary source of meaning, the answer to the question of who we are and whether our lives matter. We are what we achieve, what we produce, what we accomplish in our labor. And so our work carries a weight it

was never meant to carry, the weight of our whole identity, and it crushes us, because no job can bear the weight of being the thing that justifies our existence. When the work goes well, we are inflated with a pride that cannot last. When the work goes badly, we are crushed with a shame that goes to the core, because it is not merely our work that has failed but our very self, our worth, the thing we were counting on to justify us. This is why work crushes us, because we have made it into the ladder of our salvation, and it cannot save.

The cross frees us from this by establishing our worth somewhere else entirely, somewhere our work cannot touch. If my identity is established by the cross, by the fact that God loved me to the point of death, by a worth that was fixed before I ever accomplished anything and that no failure can diminish, then my work is freed from the impossible burden of justifying me. I do not have to succeed in order to be worth something, because my worth is already established, at the cross, apart from my success. And this frees my work to be what it was meant to be, a service, a contribution, a way of loving my neighbor and tending the world, rather than the desperate project of justifying my existence. The cross does not make work easy, but it makes work bearable, because it takes off the crushing weight of identity that work was never meant to carry and places that weight where it belongs, on the cross, where my worth is settled forever.

There is more, because the cross also speaks to the futility we often feel in our work, the sense that we are laboring at things that do not matter, that will not last, that vanish as soon as they are done. Much work is like this, repetitive, thankless, forgotten, the daily labor that must be done again tomorrow because it undoes itself today. And the cross speaks to this futility by connecting our small labor to the

great work of God, by teaching that the crucified God is redeeming the whole creation, and that our work, however small and forgotten, can be offered to him, taken up into his work, given a meaning it could never have on its own. The cross does not make our work important by the world's standards, does not guarantee it will be remembered or rewarded. But it gives our work a dignity it cannot lose, the dignity of being offered to God, taken up into his redemption, done as service to the crucified one who himself worked as a carpenter and knew the weight of ordinary labor.

I have to confess my own bondage to work as identity, because I am a pastor, and pastoral work is peculiarly susceptible to this idolatry. My work is my faith, my calling, my service to God, and it is therefore terribly easy to make it the ground of my worth, to measure myself by the success of my ministry, to be inflated when the church grows and crushed when it does not, to carry the weight of my identity in my vocation. And the cross keeps calling me out of this, keeps reminding me that my worth is not in my ministry but in the God who died for me, that I do not have to succeed as a pastor in order to be worth something, that my identity is settled at the cross and not in the size of my congregation or the impact of my preaching. I fail at this constantly, and the failing crushes me exactly as it crushes everyone who has made their work the ground of their worth, and the cross keeps freeing me, keeps taking the weight off my work and placing it where it belongs.

The person exhausted by their work, crushed by its weight, anxious about its outcomes, needs to hear that the cross offers a freedom the productivity gurus cannot offer. Not a technique for better output, not a path to finding your passion, but a liberation from the burden of being justified by

your labor, because your justification is already accomplished, at the cross, apart from anything you produce. You can work without the crushing weight of identity, because your identity is settled. You can fail without being destroyed, because your worth does not depend on your success. And you can find in even the smallest, most thankless labor a dignity it cannot lose, the dignity of being offered to the crucified God who worked with his hands and takes up our labor into his redemption. That is what the cross says to the work that crushes us, and it is deeper and truer than anything the world has to offer.

*Work crushes us because we ask it to
justify our existence, and no job can
bear that weight. The cross settles our
worth elsewhere, and frees our work to
be service instead of salvation.*

SO THE CROSS REACHES into the work that consumes our hours and often our spirits, and it frees us from the crushing weight we have placed on it by making it the ground of our identity. It settles our worth at the cross, apart from our success, so that our work no longer has to justify us and is freed to be service rather than salvation. It speaks to the futility we feel by connecting our small labor to the great work of God, giving our forgotten toil a dignity it cannot lose. And it offers the exhausted and the anxious a freedom the world cannot give, not a technique for better output but a liberation

THE SCANDAL OF THE CROSS

from the burden of being justified by our labor, because our justification is already accomplished at the cross. The work may still be hard. But it no longer has to carry the weight of our whole identity, because that weight has been lifted and placed on the cross, where the crucified God settled our worth forever, and set us free to work without being crushed.

CHAPTER FORTY

The Cross and the Fear of Death Undone

I WROTE A CHAPTER earlier on the cross and death, on how the death of God defeats death from the inside. But I want to return to death near the end of this book, not to the metaphysics of it but to the fear of it, because the fear of death is, according to the letter to the Hebrews, the thing that holds the human race in lifelong slavery, and the cross is aimed precisely at breaking that slavery. Hebrews says that Christ shared our flesh and blood so that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong bondage. The fear of death, Hebrews says, is a lifelong slavery, and the cross is the breaking of it.

Consider how the fear of death enslaves us, often without our knowing it. Most of us do not walk around consciously afraid of death, because we have arranged our lives to keep the thought at bay. But the fear is there, underneath, driving us in ways we do not recognize. The frantic accumulation of wealth and achievement is, in part, a defense against death,

an attempt to build something that will outlast us, to matter in a way that death cannot erase. The desperate pursuit of pleasure and experience is, in part, a defense against death, an attempt to fill the brief span with enough sensation to distract us from its brevity. Even our relationships are shadowed by the fear, loved under the sentence of loss, held with an anxiety that comes from knowing they will end. The fear of death is the hidden engine of much of human life, the slavery that Hebrews names, driving us to accumulate, to distract, to defend ourselves against the void, and we do not even know we are enslaved, because the slavery is so total and so hidden.

The cross breaks this slavery by defeating the thing we fear. If death has been conquered, if the crucified God has passed through it and out the other side and dragged its keys behind him, then death is no longer the final and absolute enemy that our fear has made it. It is a defeated enemy, a conquered tyrant, a passage rather than a terminus, and the fear that enslaved us loses its grip. Not that we no longer feel the natural human aversion to death, because even Jesus in Gethsemane recoiled from it, sweating blood at the prospect. But the enslaving fear, the terror that death is the absolute end and therefore the thing against which we must defend ourselves at all costs, that fear is broken, because death is no longer the end. The crucified and risen God has made it a doorway, and the one who knows this is freed from the lifelong slavery that the fear of death imposes.

And this freedom is enormous, because the person freed from the fear of death is freed for a kind of life that the enslaved cannot live. If I am no longer defending myself against death at all costs, then I am free to give my life away, free to take risks that the fear of death forbids, free to love

without the frantic grasping that comes from knowing everything will be lost, free to serve and sacrifice and pour myself out, because I have already died with Christ and death holds no final threat over me. The martyrs understood this. The people who have given their lives for Christ across the centuries were not people with a death wish but people freed from the fear of death, people who could lay down their lives because they knew death was not the end, people whose freedom from the fear made them dangerous to every power that rules through the threat of death. You cannot enslave a person who does not fear death. You cannot control them, cannot threaten them, cannot make them bow, because the ultimate weapon, the threat of death, has lost its power over them. The cross makes people free in exactly this way, and free people are the terror of tyrants.

I do not claim to have fully received this freedom, and I write as one still partly enslaved to the fear I am describing. The accumulation, the distraction, the anxious grasping, the loving under the sentence of loss, all of it is in me, the marks of a fear of death not yet fully broken. But I have tasted the freedom, in moments, the strange liberty of one who knows that death is not the end, that the worst the world can do to me has already been undone by the cross, that I have died with Christ and been raised and death holds no final claim on me. And I want more of that freedom, want to be freed from the lifelong slavery of the fear of death, want to live the life that only the death-freed can live, the life of self-giving and risk and love without grasping. The cross offers this freedom, offers to break the slavery of the fear of death, and I am learning, slowly, to receive it.

For the person gripped by the fear of death, whether they know it consciously or feel it only as a background dread, the

cross offers the deepest possible liberation. Not a denial of death, not a pretense that it does not matter, but its defeat, its transformation from a terminus into a doorway, its conquest by the God who passed through it and out the other side. You do not have to spend your life defending yourself against the void, because the void has been filled, the enemy has been beaten, the doorway has been opened by the crucified and risen Christ. And on the far side of the fear is a freedom you have never known, the freedom of one who has already died and been raised, who cannot be enslaved by the threat of death, who is free at last to give their life away because they have found a life that death can no longer touch.

*The fear of death is a lifelong slavery
that drives us to accumulate, distract,
and grasp. The cross breaks the slavery
by defeating the thing we fear, and free
people are the terror of tyrants.*

SO THE CROSS UNDOES the fear of death, the hidden engine of human slavery, the terror that drives us to accumulate and distract and grasp and defend ourselves against the void. It breaks the slavery by defeating death itself, transforming it from an absolute end into a conquered doorway, freeing us from the lifelong bondage that the fear of death imposes. And on the far side of that fear is a freedom the enslaved cannot imagine, the freedom to give our lives away, to take the risks the fear forbids, to love without the frantic grasping of those

who know they will lose everything, because we have already died with Christ and been raised, and death holds no final claim on us. The crucified God passed through death and dragged its keys behind him, and he holds them out to us, and says that because he lives, we will live also, and the fear that enslaved us all our lives is broken at last.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

The Cross and the Justice We Cannot Achieve

THERE IS A HUNGER for justice in the human heart that will not be satisfied, and our age feels it acutely, and it drives a great deal of the passion and the rage of our moment. We want the wrongs of history answered, the oppressors held accountable, the victims vindicated, the accounts balanced. And this hunger is good, it is the image of God in us, the reflection of a God who loves justice and hates oppression. But it is a hunger we cannot satisfy, because the justice we seek is beyond our reach, and the ways we pursue it so often become new injustices, and the cross speaks to this in a way that neither the cynic who abandons justice nor the zealot who pursues it by any means can hear.

Let me name the problem with our pursuit of justice, because it is a real problem and not a counsel of despair. The wrongs of history are beyond our power to right. The dead cannot be raised, the tortured cannot be untortured, the vast

accumulated suffering of the human race cannot be undone by any human justice, however thorough. And our pursuit of justice, even when it is right, so often becomes a new injustice, because we are not innocent judges but implicated parties, because the oppressed of one generation become the oppressors of the next, because the machinery of justice in human hands so easily becomes the machinery of vengeance, of the scapegoat, of a new violence dressed as righteousness. We cannot achieve the justice we hunger for, because the wrongs are too vast and our hands are too dirty, and the honest reckoning with this drives some to cynicism, the abandonment of justice as a hopeless dream, and others to a zealotry that pursues justice by any means and becomes the very thing it opposes.

The cross speaks to this at the deepest level, because the cross is the place where the justice we cannot achieve is achieved by God. The hunger for the wrongs of the world to be answered is not a hunger the cross dismisses but a hunger the cross satisfies, because at the cross God takes the wrongs of the world with total seriousness, does not wave them away, does not pretend they do not matter, but answers them, bears them, deals with them at infinite cost to himself. The cross is God's justice, the place where the accumulated wrong of human history is not ignored but addressed, where the accounts are not left unbalanced but settled, where the oppression and the violence and the cruelty of the ages are not forgotten but borne by God himself. The person who hungers for justice can find at the cross a God who hungers for it too, who answered it, who took it so seriously that he died to address it.

And the cross also frees us from the impossible burden of achieving the justice we cannot achieve, which is a liberation

the zealot desperately needs. If the final justice of the world rests on our shoulders, if it is up to us to right every wrong and balance every account and vindicate every victim, then we are crushed by a burden we cannot bear, and we will pursue justice by any means, and become monsters in the pursuit, because the burden is too great and the stakes are absolute and we have made ourselves the final judges of the world. But if the final justice rests with God, if the crucified God has taken the wrongs of history onto himself and will finally set all things right, then we are freed from the crushing burden of being the world's final judges, freed to pursue justice with passion but without the absolutism that turns justice into vengeance, freed to work for the right without the desperate zealotry that comes from believing it all depends on us. The cross does not excuse us from the pursuit of justice, but it frees us from the burden of being its final guarantors, because God is, and he has proven it at the cross.

There is a hard word here for the cynic too, the one who has abandoned justice as a hopeless dream, and it is this. The cross means justice is not hopeless, that the wrongs of the world will be answered, that the accounts will be balanced, not by us, whose hands are too dirty and whose reach is too short, but by the God who took the wrong onto himself and will finally set all things right. The cynic's despair is a failure of hope, a conclusion that because we cannot achieve justice, there will be no justice. And the cross answers this despair by pointing to a justice beyond our achieving, a divine justice that has already begun at the cross and will be completed at the end, when the crucified God returns to judge the living and the dead and to make all things new. The hunger for justice is not a hunger that will go unsatisfied. It is a hunger

that the cross has begun to satisfy and that God will finally satisfy, and the cynic who has abandoned justice as hopeless has abandoned it too soon.

I feel the pull of both the zealotry and the cynicism, because I too hunger for justice and despair of achieving it. I want the wrongs of the world answered, and I am tempted, at times, to pursue that answer by any means, to become a zealot who would sacrifice mercy on the altar of justice. And at other times I am tempted to cynicism, to conclude that because the wrongs are too vast and our hands too dirty, there is no justice and no point in seeking it. And the cross calls me out of both, out of the zealotry that would make me a monster and out of the cynicism that would make me abandon the good. It tells me that justice is real, that God takes the wrongs of the world seriously enough to die for them, that the final justice rests with him and not with me, and that I am therefore freed to pursue justice with passion but without absolutism, to work for the right without the crushing burden of being its final guarantor, because the crucified God has taken that burden onto himself.

*We cannot achieve the justice we
hunger for, because the wrongs are too
vast and our hands too dirty. The cross
is where God takes the wrong onto
himself and settles the account we
never could.*

SO THE CROSS SPEAKS to the hunger for justice that will not be satisfied, and it speaks in a way that neither the cynic nor the zealot can hear. It satisfies the hunger by taking the wrongs of the world seriously enough to die for them, answering the accumulated wrong of human history not by ignoring it but by bearing it. It frees the zealot from the crushing burden of achieving a justice beyond human reach, so that we can pursue justice without the absolutism that turns it into vengeance. And it answers the cynic's despair by pointing to a justice beyond our achieving, a divine justice begun at the cross and completed at the end. The hunger for justice is good, the image of God in us, and it is a hunger the cross does not dismiss but satisfies, because at the cross the God who loves justice took the injustice of the world onto himself, and settled the account that we, with our short reach and our dirty hands, could never have settled ourselves.

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

The Cross and the Church That Must Suffer

IF THE CROSS IS the center of the church's message, then it must also be the pattern of the church's life, and this means the church, like its Lord, must be willing to suffer. Not to seek suffering, not to court persecution, not to wear martyrdom as a badge, but to accept that a church faithful to a crucified Lord in a world that crucified him cannot expect to be received more gently than he was. The theology of glory wants a triumphant church, a winning church, a church that dominates its culture and enjoys the favor of the powerful. The theology of the cross knows that the church is called to a cross-shaped life, and that faithfulness will often look like losing.

This is a hard word for the church of my nation and my time, because the American church has largely assumed that it should win, that it should be powerful, that it should enjoy cultural dominance and political favor, that a healthy church

is a growing, thriving, influential church. And when that dominance began to slip, when the culture turned, when the church found itself increasingly marginal and even despised, we responded with alarm, with a sense that something had gone terribly wrong, with a scramble to regain the power we were losing. But the theology of the cross asks whether our alarm reveals that we had made an idol of our dominance, whether we had assumed a triumph the cross never promised, whether the loss of our cultural power might be, not a disaster to be reversed at all costs, but an invitation to rediscover the cross-shaped life we had forgotten in our comfort. A church that must suffer is closer to its crucified Lord than a church that dominates, and the loss of our power might be the mercy that returns us to the cross.

I want to be careful here, because this can be twisted into a masochism that seeks suffering, or into a passivity that accepts every injustice, and neither is what the cross teaches. The church is not called to seek persecution, to manufacture martyrdom, to accept every harm done to it as a cross to be borne. The church should work for justice, should resist evil, should protect the vulnerable, should use whatever lawful means it has to serve the good. The cross-shaped life is not passivity in the face of evil but the willingness to suffer for the good rather than to abandon it, the willingness to lose rather than to win by unfaithful means, the willingness to be crucified rather than to crucify. The church that must suffer is not a church that seeks suffering but a church that will not purchase its safety by betraying its Lord, that will not trade the cross for the sword, that would rather share the sufferings of Christ than escape them by becoming the thing that crucified him.

The persecuted church across the world and across

history has understood this better than the comfortable church of the prosperous West, and we have much to learn from them. The church under Rome, the church under the totalitarian regimes of the twentieth century, the church in places where following Christ still costs everything, has grasped the cross-shaped life in a way that our comfort has obscured from us. They have known what it is to suffer for Christ, to lose everything for faithfulness, to share the sufferings of the crucified Lord. And their witness has often been more powerful, their faith more vibrant, their grasp of the gospel more profound, than that of the comfortable church that has never had to suffer for its faith. The blood of the martyrs, the ancient writers said, is the seed of the church, and there is a strange truth in it, that the church has often been most alive when it has most suffered, and most compromised when it has most prospered.

Bonhoeffer, whom I have quoted throughout, understood this in the crucible of the German church's capitulation to Hitler, and his life is the great modern example of the cross-shaped church. He watched a comfortable, prosperous, powerful church surrender to a monstrous regime because it had never learned to suffer, because it valued its safety and its status more than its faithfulness, because it had a theology of glory that could not comprehend a call to the cross. And he chose the other way, the way of the cross, the way of costly discipleship, resisting the regime, joining the conspiracy against it, and finally dying at its hands, sharing the sufferings of the crucified Lord he had preached. His death was not a defeat but a witness, not a failure but the very shape of faithfulness, the church suffering with its Lord rather than escaping suffering by betraying him. And his witness has outlasted the regime that killed him, as the cross outlasted

the Rome that crucified Christ.

I write as a comfortable pastor in a comfortable church, and I feel the rebuke of this chapter in my own ministry. I have assumed the church should win, should be powerful, should enjoy the favor of the culture, and I have been alarmed by the loss of that favor rather than seeing in it a possible mercy, an invitation back to the cross-shaped life. I have valued the safety and the prosperity of my ministry, have been reluctant to say the things that would cost me, have trimmed my faithfulness to preserve my comfort. And the cross calls me out of this, calls the whole comfortable church out of it, toward a willingness to suffer for the good rather than to win by betraying it, toward the cross-shaped life that shares the sufferings of Christ rather than escaping them. I do not seek suffering, and I do not romanticize the persecution that others have endured and I have not. But I want to be part of a church that would rather be crucified than crucify, that would rather lose faithfully than win unfaithfully, that follows its crucified Lord all the way to the cross if faithfulness requires it.

*The theology of glory wants a church
that wins. The theology of the cross
knows the church is called to a cross-
shaped life, and that faithfulness to a
crucified Lord will often look like
losing.*

SO THE CROSS IS not only the church's message but the pattern of the church's life, and a church faithful to a crucified Lord must be willing to suffer, not seeking suffering but refusing to purchase its safety by betraying its Lord. This is a hard word for the comfortable church of the prosperous West, which has assumed it should win and been alarmed by its losses, and which may need to learn from the persecuted church and from witnesses like Bonhoeffer what the cross-shaped life actually costs. The church that must suffer is closer to its crucified Lord than the church that dominates, and the loss of our cultural power might be the mercy that returns us to the cross. A church that would rather be crucified than crucify, that would rather lose faithfully than win unfaithfully, that shares the sufferings of Christ rather than escaping them, is the church shaped by the cross it preaches, and it is the only church that has ever finally been worth anything to the world it was sent to save.

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

The Cross We Cannot Improve Upon

WE LIVE IN AN age of improvement, of progress, of the confident assumption that the human race is advancing, that we know more and can do more than our ancestors, that the old ways are being surpassed by the new. And this assumption reaches even into religion, into the persistent modern project of improving upon the faith, of updating it, of keeping what is useful and discarding what is embarrassing, of producing a Christianity fit for an enlightened age. And the great embarrassment that this project always wants to discard is the cross, the blood, the atonement, the scandal of a God who died. I want to argue, near the end of this book, that the cross is the one thing we cannot improve upon, that every attempt to update it has produced something lesser, and that the scandal we keep trying to remove is the very thing that makes the faith worth having.

Consider the pattern of the modern project of improving Christianity. It began, in earnest, in the nineteenth century, with the confident liberal theology that sought to strip away

the primitive, supernatural, embarrassing elements of the faith and keep the ethical core, the teaching of Jesus, the fatherhood of God and the brotherhood of man, the golden rule, the kingdom of love. And the cross was the first thing to go, or nearly, reduced from an atonement to an example, from the death of God for our sins to the inspiring self-sacrifice of a great moral teacher. The blood was an embarrassment. The wrath was a relic. The substitution was a barbarism. And so they were removed, and what remained was a Christianity of ethics and inspiration, a religion of moral improvement with Jesus as its great example, purged of the scandal of the cross.

And here is what happened to that improved Christianity. It died. It produced, within a generation or two, churches that had nothing to say, a faith that had been so thoroughly updated that there was nothing left to believe, a religion of ethical uplift that could not survive the collapse of the optimism that had produced it. When the twentieth century arrived with its wars and its genocides and its demonstration that the human race was not, after all, steadily improving, the liberal Christianity that had staked everything on human progress had nothing to say, because it had removed the one thing that spoke to a world of sin and suffering and death, the cross. The improved Christianity, the Christianity with the scandal removed, turned out to be a Christianity with the power removed, because the scandal was the power, the folly was the wisdom, the offense was the very thing that made the faith able to speak to the depths of the human condition. Remove the cross and you remove everything.

This is the lesson the modern project of improvement keeps failing to learn, and keeps repeating in new forms. There is always a new movement to update the faith, to

remove the embarrassing bits, to produce a Christianity fit for the latest sensibility, and it always begins with the cross, and it always ends in the same place, a Christianity so improved that there is nothing left of it, a faith so accommodated to the age that it has become indistinguishable from the age and therefore useless to it. Because the world does not need a religious version of what it already believes. It needs the one thing the church alone can offer, the scandal of the cross, the crucified God, the folly that is wiser than human wisdom and the weakness that is stronger than human strength. And every time we improve that away, we produce a church with nothing to say, a salt that has lost its savor, a light that has been hidden under the bushel of our accommodation.

The cross cannot be improved upon because it is not a human idea to be updated but a divine act to be received. We did not invent the cross, and we cannot improve it, any more than we can improve upon a fact. God died on a Roman cross for the people who killed him. That is not a doctrine we constructed and can therefore revise. It is an event that happened, a thing God did, and our task is not to improve it but to receive it, not to update it but to proclaim it, not to remove its scandal but to be scandalized by it and saved by it. The persistent modern itch to improve the cross is finally an itch to be God, to sit in judgment over the divine act, to decide what God should have done and to correct him. And it always fails, because the cross is wiser than our improvements, deeper than our updates, more powerful than our accommodations, and every generation that tries to improve it discovers, too late, that it has thrown away the pearl of great price in exchange for a religion it could have gotten anywhere.

I have felt the itch to improve the cross, to update it, to remove its embarrassing bits for the sake of the skeptical and

sophisticated people I want to reach, the people I myself once was. I have wanted a Christianity with less blood and less wrath and less scandal, a faith easier to commend to the cultured despisers. And every time I have followed that itch, I have produced something lesser, a gospel with the power drained out, a cross with the scandal removed and therefore the salvation removed. The people I was trying to reach did not need my improved cross. They needed the real one, the scandalous one, the crucified God who could speak to the depths of their guilt and shame and suffering and death in a way my updated version never could. The cross I was embarrassed by was the only thing that could save them, and me, and every attempt to improve it was an attempt to throw away the very thing that made the faith worth commending at all.

*Every generation tries to improve the
cross by removing its scandal, and
every generation discovers too late that
the scandal was the power, and the
improved faith has nothing left to say.*

SO THE CROSS IS the one thing we cannot improve upon, and the persistent modern project of updating it, of removing its embarrassing scandal, always produces something lesser, a Christianity with the power drained out. The improved faith dies, because the scandal was the power, the folly the wisdom, the offense the very thing that let the gospel speak to the

depths of the human condition. The cross cannot be improved because it is not a human idea to be revised but a divine act to be received, an event that happened, a thing God did, which our task is to proclaim and not to correct. And the itch to improve it is finally the itch to be God, to sit in judgment over the divine act, and it always fails, because the cross is wiser than our improvements and more powerful than our accommodations. The world does not need a religious version of what it already believes. It needs the crucified God, and the church that improves him away has nothing left to offer but a religion it could have gotten anywhere, drained of the one scandal that could have saved it.

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

The Cross and the Return to Wonder

I HAVE SPENT THIS whole book taking the cross apart, examining it from every angle, holding up the models and the objections and the applications, and there is a danger in all of this analysis, the danger of losing the wonder in the dissection, of turning the cross into a problem to be solved rather than a mystery to be adored. So near the end I want to return to wonder, to the sheer astonishment of the thing, because the final response to the cross is not analysis but adoration, not explanation but worship, not the mastery of a doctrine but the falling down before a God who died.

Consider again, as if for the first time, what the cross claims. The maker of the galaxies, the one who spoke the universe into being, the source of all that is, became a human being, a helpless infant, a growing child, a working man, and then allowed himself to be arrested, tortured, and executed by his own creatures, hanging naked on a Roman cross, suffocating slowly, mocked and abandoned, dying the death of a slave, for the people who were killing him. This is the

claim. And we have heard it so often that we have lost the power to be astonished by it, have reduced it to a familiar doctrine, a thing we affirm without wonder. But if we could hear it fresh, if we could strip away the familiarity and encounter the claim in its raw astonishment, it would knock us to the ground. God died. The immortal one tasted death. The one who holds the universe in being was held by nails to a beam of wood. There is no stranger claim in all the history of human thought, and no more wonderful one.

The wonder deepens when we consider why. Not because we deserved it, not because we had earned it, not because we were worth the trouble, but out of sheer love, a love that would rather die than abandon us, a love that saw us in our rebellion and our ruin and chose, at infinite cost to itself, to rescue us. Paul says God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners Christ died for us. While we were still sinners. Not after we had cleaned ourselves up, not because we had become worthy, but while we were still his enemies, still failing him, still in the very act of rebellion, he died for us. This is a love beyond all human analogy, a love that gives everything for those who have earned nothing, and the only adequate response to it is not analysis but adoration, not the mastery of a theory but the worship of a God whose love is beyond our comprehension.

I worry that this book, for all its intentions, may have contributed to the very problem it set out to solve, the reduction of the cross to a familiar doctrine, the loss of the wonder in the analysis. I have taken the cross apart, examined its mechanisms, held up its models, answered its objections, and there is a place for all of that, but it is not the final place. The final place is on our knees. The final response to the crucified God is not to have understood him but to

adore him, not to have solved the mystery but to have been undone by it, not to have mastered the doctrine of the atonement but to have fallen down before the God who loved us to the point of death. If this book has helped you understand the cross better, I am glad, but if it has left you merely understanding it, it has failed, because the cross is not finally a thing to be understood but a God to be worshiped, and the understanding is only worth anything if it leads to the worship.

Let me try, then, to return us to wonder before this book ends. Stand again at the foot of the cross. See the God who made you hanging there, dying for you, loving you to the end. Hear the words, Father forgive them, spoken over the very people driving the nails, spoken over you, over me, over all of us who by our sin held him there. Watch the blood run down the wood, the blood that is the life of God poured out for the life of the world. See the darkness fall over the land, the sun refusing to shine on the death of its maker. Hear the cry of dereliction, the God-forsaken God crying out to the God who has forsaken him, entering the deepest darkness so that we would never have to enter it alone. And then hear the last word, it is finished, the announcement that the work is done, the debt is paid, the victory is won, the powers are defeated, the way is open. Stand there, and let the wonder return, and do not analyze it, only adore.

The wonder is not a naive thing that analysis destroys but a mature thing that analysis, at its best, deepens. The more we understand the cross, the more astonishing it becomes, not the less, because every angle we examine reveals a further depth of the love and the wisdom and the mystery. The models of the atonement are not solvents that dissolve the wonder but windows that increase it, showing us more of

the greatness of what God did. The objections we answer do not domesticate the cross but reveal its strangeness more fully, its refusal to fit our categories, its scandal that will not smooth out. And so the analysis, rightly done, does not replace the wonder but leads back to it, deeper than before, a wonder informed by understanding, an adoration grounded in truth, a worship that knows what it worships and is more astonished, not less, for the knowing.

*The final response to the crucified God
is not to have understood him but to
adore him, not to have solved the
mystery but to have been undone by it,
on our knees at the foot of the cross.*

SO I WANT TO end this chapter, and nearly this book, by returning us to wonder, to the sheer astonishment of a God who died, of the maker of the galaxies hanging on a Roman cross for the people who killed him, out of a love that gives everything for those who have earned nothing. This is the claim, and it is the strangest and most wonderful claim in all the history of human thought, and we have lost the power to be astonished by it only because we have heard it too often and analyzed it too much and worshiped it too little. The final place is on our knees. The final response is adoration. And if this book has helped you understand the cross, let it lead you now not merely to understanding but to wonder, to the worship of a God whose love is beyond comprehension, who

loved you to the point of death, who died for you while you were still his enemy, and who calls you now, not merely to understand what he did, but to fall down before him and adore.

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

The Cross and the Hope That Does Not Disappoint

THERE IS A DIFFERENCE between optimism and hope, and the difference is the cross. Optimism is the belief that things will get better, that the arc bends upward, that progress is real and the future is bright, and optimism is a fragile thing, easily shattered by the first genuine catastrophe, easily exposed as wishful thinking by a world that does not, in fact, reliably get better. Hope is something else entirely. Hope is not the belief that things will get better but the confidence that God will finally set them right, and it rests not on the evidence of progress but on the fact of the cross, and it does not disappoint, because it is grounded not in our reading of the trends but in what God has already done. Near the end of this book I want to speak of hope, the hope that the cross makes possible, because it is the final gift of the crucified God and the note I want to leave you on.

Paul says that hope does not disappoint us, and he

grounds this claim in the cross, in the love of God poured out through the death of his Son. The reason Christian hope does not disappoint, he argues, is that it is not based on our circumstances, which may be terrible, nor on our progress, which may be illusory, nor on our optimism, which may be shattered, but on the demonstrated love of God at the cross. If God has already done the hardest thing, if he has already died for us while we were still his enemies, then we can be confident that he will finish what he started, that he will not abandon the work he began at such cost, that the God who gave his Son for us will, with him, freely give us all things. Christian hope is not a bet on the future but a confidence grounded in the past, in what God has already proven about himself at Golgotha, and because it rests on an accomplished fact rather than an uncertain trend, it does not disappoint.

This is why Christian hope can survive what optimism cannot. Optimism is destroyed by catastrophe, by the war, the diagnosis, the loss, the evidence that things are not, in fact, getting better. But Christian hope is not destroyed by catastrophe, because it never rested on the absence of catastrophe in the first place. It rested on the cross, on a God who entered the catastrophe, who was himself a victim of the worst the world could do, and who defeated it not by avoiding it but by passing through it. The hope grounded in the cross has already reckoned with the worst, has already faced the death of God, and so it cannot be shattered by lesser darknesses, because it was born in the greatest darkness there is and survived it. This is a hope with scars, a hope that has been through the cross, a hope that does not depend on things going well because it was forged in things going as badly as they possibly could, and therefore it can hold when everything else fails.

I have watched this hope hold in people when nothing else could, and I have watched optimism shatter in people who had nothing deeper. The optimist facing a terminal diagnosis has nothing, because the trend has turned against them and their whole faith was in the trend. But the person whose hope is grounded in the cross can face the same diagnosis with a confidence that does not depend on the outcome, because their hope was never in the outcome but in the God who died and rose, who has already defeated the death they are facing, who will raise them as he was raised. I do not romanticize this, and I have seen faith struggle and waver in the face of death, because we are human and the darkness is real. But I have seen the hope grounded in the cross hold where every other hope failed, hold in the valley of the shadow, hold at the graveside, hold in the places where optimism has nothing to say, because it rests on a love that has already been proven at the cross and cannot be taken away.

The hope of the cross reaches all the way to the end of all things, to the final future the crucified God has promised. Because the cross is not the last word but the turning point, and beyond it lies the resurrection, and beyond the resurrection lies the return of the crucified and risen Lord, and beyond that lies the making new of all things, the wiping away of every tear, the end of death and mourning and crying and pain, the world set right at last. This is the hope the cross makes possible, not a vague optimism that things will improve but a definite confidence that God will finish what he began, that the crucified God who defeated death will finally abolish it, that the love poured out at Golgotha will have the last word over all the darkness of the world. And this hope does not disappoint, because it rests on the cross, on what God has already done, on a love that has already gone all the

way down and come back up, and will not stop until it has made all things new.

I write as one who lives by this hope, imperfectly, waveringly, but really, because I have found nothing else that holds. The optimism I once had as a young man, the vague confidence that things would work out, that progress was real, that the future was bright, shattered against the realities of a hard world, as it shatters for everyone eventually. And what replaced it was not despair but a different kind of hope, a hope with scars, a hope grounded not in the trends but in the cross, in a God who entered the darkness and defeated it, who has already done the hardest thing and will surely do the rest. This hope has held me through darkneses that would have shattered any optimism, held me at gravesides and in the silence of unanswered prayer and in the long Saturdays of waiting, because it does not depend on things going well but on a love that was proven at the cross and cannot be taken away.

*Optimism is the belief that things will
get better, and it shatters at the first
catastrophe. Hope is the confidence that
God will set things right, and it was
forged in the greatest catastrophe there
is.*

SO THE CROSS MAKES possible a hope that does not disappoint, a hope grounded not in our circumstances or our

progress or our optimism but in the demonstrated love of God at Golgotha. It is a hope that survives what optimism cannot, because it was born in the greatest darkness there is and passed through it, a hope with scars, a hope that does not depend on things going well because it was forged in things going as badly as possible. It reaches all the way to the end of all things, to the return of the crucified Lord and the making new of all things, the final future the God who died has promised. And it does not disappoint, because it rests on a love that has already gone all the way down and come back up, and will not stop until every tear is wiped away and every darkness is undone. This is the hope I leave you with as this book turns toward its end, the hope of the crucified God, the hope that does not disappoint, because its foundation is not our optimism but his cross.

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

The Cross and the Forgiveness We Withhold From Ourselves

THERE IS A PARTICULAR prison that many sincere believers live in, and it is not the prison of unbelief or the prison of open sin but the prison of a forgiveness they will not accept, a grace they affirm for others and withhold from themselves. They believe God forgives sinners. They just cannot believe he forgives them, or they believe he forgives them for everything except the one thing, the thing they cannot forgive themselves for, the wound they carry that no amount of good doctrine seems to heal. And I want to speak to this near the end, because it is one of the most common and most painful conditions I have encountered in years of ministry, and because the cross speaks to it with a precision that we have been slow to preach.

The condition looks like humility, and that is why it is so

hard to name and so hard to heal. The person who cannot forgive themselves often thinks they are being humble, taking their sin seriously, refusing to let themselves off the hook. But it is not humility. It is a subtle form of pride, and I say this gently, because I have lived in this prison myself and I know how it feels from the inside. It is pride because it sets our own judgment of ourselves above God's judgment of us. God has declared us forgiven, at the cost of his Son, and we say, no, my sin is too great even for that, my case is the exception, the blood of Christ was sufficient for everyone else but not for me. Do you hear the strange arrogance buried in the false humility. We are claiming that our sin is bigger than the cross, that our failure exceeds the reach of the death of God, that we are, in our wretchedness, a more difficult case than the whole rest of the human race. That is not humility. It is unbelief wearing humility's clothes.

The cross confronts this directly, because the cross is the measure of what our sin actually cost and what it actually accomplished, and it will not let us set our own accounting above God's. If the death of God was sufficient to forgive the sin of the world, then it was sufficient to forgive yours, and to say otherwise is to say the cross was not enough, that God underpaid, that there is a sin somewhere whose weight exceeds the weight of the death of the Son of God. And there is no such sin. There cannot be, because the cross is the death of the infinite God, and no finite sin, however grievous, can exceed an infinite payment. The person who cannot forgive themselves is, whether they know it or not, doubting the sufficiency of the cross, treating their own sin as the one thing too heavy for God to lift, and the answer to this is not to think less of their sin but to think more of the cross, to see that the death of God is larger than the worst thing they have

ever done, that the blood shed at Golgotha reaches even to the sin they cannot forgive themselves for, because it reaches to all sin, without exception, including theirs.

There is a further depth here, and it touches the difference between self-forgiveness and receiving forgiveness that we considered in the chapter on guilt. The person trapped in this prison is often trying to forgive themselves, to work up enough self-acceptance to release their own debt, and it never works, because self-forgiveness for a real debt is impossible, as we saw. You cannot forgive yourself for a wrong done to another, because you are not the party who was wronged. But the cross offers something better than self-forgiveness, which cannot work. It offers forgiveness from the one actually wronged, from God, whose forgiveness is real and effective and complete because it comes from the offended party and is grounded in an actual payment. So the person who cannot forgive themselves does not need to try harder to forgive themselves. They need to stop trying to forgive themselves and start receiving the forgiveness of God, which is the only forgiveness that can actually reach their debt, and which has already been accomplished, at the cross, and waits only to be received.

I lived in this prison for years, even after my conversion, carrying a wound I could not forgive myself for, a failure so bound up with my sense of who I was that I could not release it. I believed God forgave sinners. I simply could not believe he had forgiven me for that, whatever that was in a given season, the thing I kept behind the fig leaves, the thing I was sure exceeded even the reach of grace. And the healing did not come from working up more self-acceptance, from finally managing to forgive myself, because that never worked and could not work. It came from the slow, hard-won recognition

that my inability to forgive myself was not humility but unbelief, that I was setting my accounting above God's, that I was treating my sin as bigger than the cross, and that the answer was not to think less of my sin but to fall down before a cross large enough to have already forgiven it. The prison door was open all along. I had been standing inside a cell that Christ had unlocked at Golgotha, refusing to walk out because I could not believe the door was really open for me.

To everyone in that prison, the sincere believer who affirms grace for others and withholds it from themselves, who carries the wound they cannot forgive themselves for, I want to say what I most needed to hear. Your inability to forgive yourself is not the humility you think it is. It is a subtle refusal of the cross, a treating of your sin as bigger than the death of God, a setting of your judgment above his. And the answer is not to work harder at self-forgiveness, which cannot reach your debt, but to receive the forgiveness of God, which already has. The blood of Christ was sufficient for the sin of the world, and the sin of the world includes yours, without exception, including the one thing, the thing you keep behind the fig leaves, the thing you are sure is too great. It is not too great. Nothing is too great for the death of God. The door is open. It has been open since Golgotha. You have only to believe it and walk out.

*To refuse to forgive yourself is not
humility. It is the strange arrogance of
claiming your sin is bigger than the
cross, that God underpaid, that your*

*case is the one exception to the blood of
his Son.*

SO THE CROSS SPEAKS even to the prison of the forgiveness we withhold from ourselves, the grace we affirm for others and cannot receive for ourselves, the wound we carry that no doctrine seems to heal. It names our inability to forgive ourselves not as the humility it pretends to be but as a subtle unbelief, a treating of our sin as bigger than the cross, a setting of our accounting above God's. And it offers not the self-forgiveness that cannot reach our debt but the forgiveness of God that already has, grounded in an actual payment, the death of the infinite God, larger than any finite sin. The door of that prison was unlocked at Golgotha, and it stands open still, and the only thing keeping us inside is our refusal to believe that the blood shed for the sin of the world was shed for ours too. It was. Walk out. The cross was enough, even for you, especially for you, and the God who died to open the door is waiting on the other side.

CONCLUSION

The Center of Everything

I BEGAN THIS BOOK with a confession, that I wore a cross around my neck for two years before I believed a word of what it meant, and I want to end it with a different confession, that I have written this whole book about the cross and I still have not reached the bottom of it. That is not a failure of the writing. It is the nature of the thing. The cross cannot be exhausted, cannot be mastered, cannot be finally comprehended, because it is the death of the infinite God, and everything about it opens onto depths beyond our reach. I have taken it apart from every angle I know, and I have only shown you the surface of an ocean whose depths I will spend eternity beginning to plumb. The cross is the center of everything, and the center of everything is inexhaustible.

Let me gather up what this book has tried to say, not as a summary but as a final pressing of the claim. The cross is not a detail of the Christian story but its center and its scandal, and the church has smoothed it into jewelry and lost the offense, and we must recover the offense or lose the thing

itself. A good God would die because goodness that will not enter the suffering is not yet love, and justice that will not bear the cost is not yet mercy, and the enemy death could only be defeated from the inside. Holiness and love, which we falsely oppose, meet at the cross in a single act. The death of God does many things at once, bearing our judgment in our place, defeating the powers that enslave us, demonstrating a love that breaks our hearts, absorbing the violence of the world instead of returning it, and no single model can contain it, and we must hold them all or shrink the cross to a slogan. The theology of the cross exposes every theology of glory, teaching us to find God in weakness and suffering and defeat, hidden under the form of his opposite, where the proud will never look and only faith can see.

And the cross reaches into every darkness the human heart can hold. It answers guilt with a real forgiveness from the one actually wronged. It answers shame by seeing us fully and loving us anyway, taking the exposure onto itself. It answers suffering not with an explanation but with a presence, a God who went to the bottom of the pain and cried the cry of the forsaken. It answers death by dying and rising, defeating the last enemy from the inside. It answers violence by absorbing it and refusing to return it. It answers the fear of death that enslaves us, the hunger for justice we cannot satisfy, the work that crushes us, the marriages that fail and the children we cannot save and the fatherlessness that installs its lie. There is no darkness the cross does not reach, because the cross went all the way down, to the very floor of every pit, and there is no place the lost can go where the crucified God has not gone first and deeper.

This is why I call the cross the center of everything and the hinge of history. Not because it is a private religious symbol

meaningful only to those who happen to find it meaningful, but because it is, if it is true at all, the turning point of the entire human story, the axis on which everything moves, the still point around which the whole turning world turns. The powers were watching the palaces, as they always are, and the hinge of history turned on a hill they did not bother to look at, in the death of a man they had already forgotten. And that unnoticed death has outlasted every empire, shaped the moral imagination of the world, been the subject of more thought and art and devotion than any other event in human history, and continues, two thousand years later, to reach into the depths of every human heart that will let it. The cross is the center of everything, and everything, in the end, will be seen to have turned on it.

I have written toward four kinds of readers throughout this book, and I want to speak a final word to each. To the skeptic, the one I was, I say again that I do not ask you to find the cross easy, only to find it worthy of your honest grappling, because it is not the comfortable fiction you may assume but the hardest and strangest claim ever made, and if it is true, nothing is the same. To the doubting Christian, I say that the questions you carry are not the enemies of faith but often its deepest form, and that the cross can hold your doubt, can meet you in your Saturday silence, can be trusted with the questions the church too often rushed you past. To the pastor, I say that the cross must be the center of your ministry as it must be the center of your church, and that every time you are tempted to lead with the thing that fills the room rather than the thing that saves the soul, the cross is calling you back. And to the one who came simply trying to live well, carrying the weight of an ordinary Tuesday, I say that the center of everything is a place where God bled, and that this

is not a small comfort but the only one that has ever finally held.

I said at the start that I came to faith not because someone made Christianity comfortable but because someone made it dangerous again, someone took the jewelry off the cross and showed me the wood. And that is what I have tried to do in these pages, to take the jewelry off, to show you the wood, to recover the scandal we have smoothed away, to make the cross strange and terrible and wonderful again. Because a cross we can wear as ornament and not mean is a cross that has lost its power to save. And a cross recovered in its full and terrible weight, the death of God for the people who killed him, is the power of God and the wisdom of God, folly to the perishing and the salvation of everyone who is being saved. The church that recovers the scandal of the cross recovers its own heart. And the person who stands beneath the cross in its full weight, and lets it be what it is, discovers the center of everything, the hinge of their own history, the God who loved them to the point of death and calls them now to die with him and be raised.

So I leave you at the foot of the cross, where this book has been trying to bring you all along. I do not resolve it for you, because the cross does not resolve. It leaves weight. It leaves you standing before a God who died, with the choice the two thieves faced, to mock or to ask, to demand that he prove himself or to admit you have nothing and cast yourself on his mercy. I cannot make that choice for you, and I will not press you toward it with manufactured urgency, because the cross does not press, it simply stands, the most terrible and wonderful fact in the history of the world, waiting. The maker of the galaxies died on a Roman cross for the people who killed him. That is the scandal. That is the folly. That is the

center of everything. And if it is true, then nothing you have ever known is quite what you thought it was, and the death of God is not the end of everything but the beginning, the hinge on which the whole world turns, the wisdom that looks like folly, the power that looks like weakness, the love that would rather die than let you go. Stand there. Do not look away. And let the wonder do what the analysis never could.